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CITY OF BERKELEY

BERKELEY CITY COUNCIL SPECIAL MEETING

November 6, 2025

WEBVTT

1
00:01:09.360 --> 00:01:19.180
Boardroom: Test, test. Okay.

2
00:01:58.560 --> 00:02:06.060
Boardroom: Okay? Yes.

3
00:02:06.890 --> 00:02:12.820
Boardroom: Okay, hello everyone! Good evening!

4
00:02:12.820 --> 00:02:28.299
Boardroom: Folks, thank you so much! Oh, I gotta wave, too. Hello, nice to see you all, thank you so much for being here. I'm gonna call this meeting to order. Theseâ€¦ we are calling to order the special meeting of the Berkeley City Council. Today is Thursday, November 6th, 2025.

5
00:02:28.730 --> 00:02:31.410
Boardroom: And, I'm gonna start us off with a roll.

6
00:02:31.590 --> 00:02:38.070
Boardroom: Okay. Councilmember Kastarwani, currently absent. Councilmember Taplin? Present.

7
00:02:38.490 --> 00:02:45.539
Boardroom: Councilmember Bartlett? Present. Trega? Present. O'Keefe? Here. Blackaby? Here. Lunapara?

8
00:02:46.200 --> 00:03:05.319
Boardroom: Here. Humbert, here. And Mayor Ishii? Here. Okay, quorum is present. Alright, so we are gonna start us off with the corridor zoning update presentation. I'm going to ask folks to please keep their conversations outside if you're gonna have them. We want to make sure we can hear the presentation and everyone's comments.

9
00:03:05.320 --> 00:03:21.189

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Boardroom: And, I just first want to, of course, express my appreciation for all the folks that are here, the business leaders, local residents, and community for coming out this evening. Staff has been working really hard to get to this point, and we're all looking forward to hearing to the presentation this night.

10
00:03:21.370 --> 00:03:45.659
Boardroom: I just want to make sure that it's clear to everyone before we begin that this is not an action item, so we're not going to be taking any vote this evening. This is a presentation, similar to the one that's been had already at the three commercial areas over the past few months. After the staff presentation, council members will have an opportunity to ask staff questions, then we're going to have public comment, and then after that, we'll move on to Council comments and discussions. So I just want to share

11
00:03:45.660 --> 00:03:48.630
Boardroom: Make sure folks know what to expect this evening.

12
00:03:48.630 --> 00:03:53.109
Boardroom: And I am gonna pass it off to our team over here. Thanks so much.

13
00:03:53.210 --> 00:04:10.019
Boardroom: Thank you, Mayor. Good evening, council members. I'm Jordan Klein, I'm Director of Planning and Development. I'm joined at the staff table by, Uttara Ramakrishnan, Justin Horner, both from our policy team, and, Chris Sensenig from Ramey & Associates, which, is assisting the City on this project.

14
00:04:10.930 --> 00:04:24.279
Boardroom: So we're really pleased to be here this evening to present to you on two projects, starting with the corridor zoning update, that, as the Mayor noted, we've been working on for a while. Both of these projects implement

15
00:04:24.330 --> 00:04:33.940
Boardroom: programs of our housing element, and they're part of the city's strategy for facilitating sustainable and equitable housing development.

16
00:04:34.550 --> 00:04:40.499
Boardroom: And expanding housing choices and opportunities for people at all income levels in Berkeley.

17

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00:04:40.780 --> 00:04:45.850
Boardroom: I'm gonna make a few points, and then turn it over to Utara for the presentation.

18
00:04:45.850 --> 00:05:02.119
Boardroom: First, I also wanted to make it clear that we're not yet advancing any plans or zoning amendments for adoption this evening, but for each of these projects, we're at a point where it would be very helpful to get input from Council and the community about the work we've completed so far.

19
00:05:03.350 --> 00:05:08.150
Boardroom: For corridors, the alternatives that we're presenting to you this evening

20
00:05:08.150 --> 00:05:25.979
Boardroom: as, again, the mayor noted, are the same as what was presented to community members at our most recent workshops. So, if any community members who were at those workshops, they see this and they're thinking, hey, nothing has changed since we saw this two months ago, please know that that's by design.

21
00:05:25.980 --> 00:05:34.689
Boardroom: And a product of our work schedule. We're intentionally moving this forward gradually and deliberately, rather than rushing change.

22
00:05:35.180 --> 00:05:46.049
Boardroom: Folks, please keep your comments to yourself. For both projects we're presenting this evening, we're seeking your feedback on objective design standards. So for corridors, we have a few specific

23
00:05:46.150 --> 00:05:59.949
Boardroom: Simple design standards that we'll ask you about, and we'll also be asking you whether you'd like to see even more detailed objective design standards incorporated into the regulations that we ultimately advance for adoption.

24
00:06:00.230 --> 00:06:16.839
Boardroom: And then for San Pablo, we have those detailed ODS already in the public draft of the plan that was published last week. And we'd love to get your feedback on specific standards, or broadly, whether you think it's too much, not enough, or just right.

25
00:06:17.390 --> 00:06:28.079

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Boardroom: I want to acknowledge that throughout our community engagement on this project, and especially over the past few weeks as this work session has approached.

26
00:06:28.080 --> 00:06:37.459
Boardroom: We've heard from many community members who are concerned about the health and well-being of the many small businesses that define the character of these corridors.

27
00:06:37.840 --> 00:06:46.170
Boardroom: We know from research, experience, and direct observation that zoning changes corridors gradually.

28
00:06:46.210 --> 00:06:48.960
Boardroom: Over the course of decades, not overnight.

29
00:06:48.980 --> 00:07:05.210
Boardroom: And Berkeley has policies and programs in place already that offer support and protection to small businesses to help ensure that they're able to continue to operate even when development happens. But these fears are understandable, and I'm not discounting them by any means.

30
00:07:05.210 --> 00:07:20.399
Boardroom: We've tasked our consultant team with conducting a survey of other potential policies and programs to support small businesses and mitigate potential displacement impacts. Policies that other cities have in place already that Berkeley can consider adopting.

31
00:07:21.310 --> 00:07:36.369
Boardroom: We'll present the results of that research to policymakers in early 2026, well in advance of sending any zoning amendments forward for adoption. And I want the small business community to know that we're committed to engaging with them as this project advances.

32
00:07:37.420 --> 00:07:57.980
Boardroom: Finally, although it's true that there's been a great deal of community outreach already about this project, I want to emphasize that there will still be more opportunities to gauge before anything is advanced to City Council for adoption. For each of the two projects we're discussing tonight, there will be at least one more community workshop, info sessions, and public hearings at Planning Commission.

33
00:07:58.150 --> 00:08:16.489

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Boardroom: And if there are any community members or groups that want to connect with us for focused engagement, we are more than happy to accommodate that. I know both Utara and Robert Rivera, who's the project manager for the San Pablo Specific Plan, brought their business cards, and we encourage community members to connect with us.

34
00:08:16.490 --> 00:08:20.580
Boardroom: So with that introduction, I'm now gonna turn it over to Utra for the presentation.

35
00:08:42.730 --> 00:08:45.060
Boardroom: Oh, you're not sharing anymore. Yeah.

36
00:08:52.590 --> 00:09:11.950
Boardroom: While you're pulling that up, I noticed there are a lot of folks standing in the back. If anyone needs a seat, there's reserved seating for folks that are disabled in the front, so I just want to make sure. And then there are also some seats, I think, over here. If you have a seat next to you, if you could move in so that folks can access it from the aisles, I just want to make sure that folks are safe.

37
00:09:13.480 --> 00:09:14.690
Boardroom: Thank you.

38
00:09:19.430 --> 00:09:20.350
Boardroom: All right.

39
00:09:20.550 --> 00:09:21.550
Boardroom: Good evening.

40
00:09:24.410 --> 00:09:36.109
Boardroom: Good evening, Mayor Ishii and Council Members. My name is Uttar Ramakrishnan. I'm an associate planner with the Land Use Planning Division and the project manager for the Corridor Zoning Update.

41
00:09:36.960 --> 00:09:39.310
Boardroom: So, here's today's agenda.

42
00:09:39.410 --> 00:09:46.440
Boardroom: We'll begin with a presentation summarizing the project, alternatives, and feedback received so far.

43
00:09:46.590 --> 00:09:55.970

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Boardroom: This will be followed by discussion questions. Council will then deliberate and provide direction on the overall approach for each corridor.

44
00:09:57.460 --> 00:09:58.310
Boardroom: All right.

45
00:09:59.110 --> 00:10:05.460
Boardroom: So, this slide shows the overall project schedule, with the star marking where we are today.

46
00:10:05.700 --> 00:10:15.169
Boardroom: Now, over the past few months, we completed the existing conditions report and held Workshop 1, which served as the official project kickoff.

47
00:10:15.320 --> 00:10:25.909
Boardroom: Most recently, we completed Workshop 2 in late summer, with 3 in-person workshops to present zoning alternatives to the community and to gather feedback.

48
00:10:26.260 --> 00:10:29.810
Boardroom: Planning Commission also reviewed the draft alternatives.

49
00:10:29.950 --> 00:10:41.610
Boardroom: From here, City Council will provide feedback on preferred approach, and our goal is to bring the updated zoning forward for adoption by summer 2026.

50
00:10:44.230 --> 00:11:02.169
Boardroom: So, in terms of community outreach, we've completed two rounds of community workshops, a citywide virtual workshop in May, and three in-person corridor-specific workshops in August, followed by a Planning Commission study session in September.

51
00:11:02.630 --> 00:11:15.999
Boardroom: Additional engagement has included meetings with community organizations, two technical advisory committee sessions, meetings with property owners, and an online survey that closed on October 10th.

52
00:11:17.570 --> 00:11:18.370
Boardroom: Andâ€¦

53

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00:11:18.530 --> 00:11:30.250
Boardroom: We know how much community members care about the health, well-being, and future of these three corridors, and we wanted to take the time to meet them in person.

54
00:11:30.510 --> 00:11:43.189
Boardroom: Staff reached out to over 30 community organizations and business organizations, offering to attend their meetings to share an overview of the project and gather feedback.

55
00:11:43.570 --> 00:11:53.230
Boardroom: So, the organizations that you see listed here invited city staff to present at their regularly scheduled meetings and provided inputs.

56
00:11:55.470 --> 00:11:57.510
Boardroom: Jumping into project overview.

57
00:11:58.420 --> 00:12:06.469
Boardroom: So, the corridor zoning update focuses on rezoning portions of Solano, North Shaddock, and College Avenue.

58
00:12:06.980 --> 00:12:23.309
Boardroom: The need for rezoning was identified in the 2023 housing element, specifically under Program 27, which commits the city to expand housing opportunities in its highest resource and highest income neighborhoods.

59
00:12:25.610 --> 00:12:33.180
Boardroom: The key goals are to expand housing capacity by encouraging new housing development through rezoning.

60
00:12:33.350 --> 00:12:41.249
Boardroom: To foster equity and inclusion by creating opportunities for new housing development in high-resource areas.

61
00:12:41.820 --> 00:12:45.579
Boardroom: Support local businesses by adding more customers.

62
00:12:45.790 --> 00:12:53.770
Boardroom: And promote sustainability by encouraging housing in amenity and transit-rich areas.

63

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00:12:55.750 --> 00:12:56.670
Boardroom: Nope.

64
00:12:56.960 --> 00:13:02.340
Boardroom: This slide here shows the zoning districts within the three corridors.

65
00:13:02.660 --> 00:13:09.220
Boardroom: On Solano Avenue, we're focusing on parcels within the CSO district.

66
00:13:09.370 --> 00:13:16.210
Boardroom: Along North Shaddock, we're studying the CNS district, while keeping the CC district as is.

67
00:13:16.640 --> 00:13:36.370
Boardroom: For College Avenue, the plan area includes parcels south of Dwight, south of Dwightway, but our analysis mainly focuses on the CE Elmwood district, since much of the corridor falls within the R2A, which was addressed through the middle housing rezoning project.

68
00:13:39.160 --> 00:13:51.379
Boardroom: Okay. Now, Berkeley has seen the greatest concentration of new multifamily housing in downtown Southside, along San Pablo, University, Telegraph Avenues.

69
00:13:52.140 --> 00:13:59.340
Boardroom: While Solano, North Shaddock, and College have seen very little high-density development.

70
00:14:01.510 --> 00:14:13.629
Boardroom: Two exceptions are on North Shattuck, an 8-storey project at Shattuck in Virginia, and a 7-story project at Shattuck and Francisco, now under construction.

71
00:14:14.260 --> 00:14:27.809
Boardroom: On College Avenue, there's one completed project in the R3 zone, and another under review at 2942 College Avenue, a two-story commercial building with two stories of home behind it.

72
00:14:30.380 --> 00:14:40.740
Boardroom: Now, this slide shows how existing zoning on Solano College on North Shaddock compare to other mixed-use corridors in the city.

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73
00:14:41.390 --> 00:14:46.520
Boardroom: These three corridors currently have the lowest minimum height standards.

74
00:14:46.800 --> 00:14:56.269
Boardroom: And the goal of Program 27 is to bring these high-resource corridors in line with others, providing more opportunities for new housing.

75
00:14:56.800 --> 00:15:08.249
Boardroom: So, here you can see how these corridors could move up the zoning ladder, better aligning with other mixed-use corridors citywide, while maintaining a neighborhood scale.

76
00:15:11.260 --> 00:15:17.340
Boardroom: Okay, so we'll now walk through three key elements of the alternatives report.

77
00:15:17.550 --> 00:15:22.660
Boardroom: Maximum height, building form, and ground floor land use.

78
00:15:25.540 --> 00:15:31.079
Boardroom: All right. So, we developed two alternatives for each corridor.

79
00:15:31.350 --> 00:15:45.590
Boardroom: So, Alternative 1, or the medium density option, increases the base height by 2 storeys on Solano and North Shaddock, where the streets are wider, and by one storey on College Avenue.

80
00:15:45.990 --> 00:15:54.860
Boardroom: Alternative 2, the higher density option, increases base height by one additional story beyond Alternative 1.

81
00:15:56.500 --> 00:16:09.479
Boardroom: Now, this slide here shows how the state density bonus affects overall total height. So, based on Berkeley's inclusionary housing ordinance and state density bonus laws.

82
00:16:09.600 --> 00:16:16.150
Boardroom: Most projects are expected to seek a 50% bonus, which we have used in our analysis over here.

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83
00:16:16.660 --> 00:16:26.440
Boardroom: Now, developers have flexibility in how they apply the bonus, so actual project heights will vary depending on site conditions and design.

84
00:16:26.990 --> 00:16:27.910
Boardroom: Nowâ€¦

85
00:16:28.160 --> 00:16:40.750
Boardroom: With a 50% bonus on Solano, buildings could reach 5 to 6 stories under Alternative 1, and 7 to 8 stories under Alternative 2.

86
00:16:41.650 --> 00:16:50.210
Boardroom: On North Shaddock, buildings could reach 7 to 8 stories under Alt 1, and 8 to 9 stories under Alt 2.

87
00:16:50.850 --> 00:17:02.249
Boardroom: On College Avenue, where the street width is narrower, buildings could reach 4 to 5 stories under Alternative 1, and up to 6 stories under Alternative 2.

88
00:17:02.780 --> 00:17:10.770
Boardroom: Projects that provide deeper affordability could qualify for a 100% bonus, allowing for greater heights.

89
00:17:10.839 --> 00:17:23.989
Boardroom: Okay. So, please, keep it down, let her finish her presentation. There's a comment period, you can speak then. Go ahead.

90
00:17:24.369 --> 00:17:31.889
Boardroom: Folks, Come on. This is their opportunity to speak, please.

91
00:17:32.390 --> 00:17:34.610
Boardroom: Go ahead.

92
00:17:34.740 --> 00:17:36.190
Boardroom: Thank you.

93
00:17:36.580 --> 00:17:44.860
Boardroom: So this slide compares the existing street sections of San Pablo Avenue with the three corridors in the study.

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94
00:17:45.130 --> 00:17:49.959
Boardroom: Updates about San Pablo will be presented to Council right after this presentation.

95
00:17:50.310 --> 00:17:55.450
Boardroom: Now, San Pablo has the widest right-of-way at 105 feet.

96
00:17:55.580 --> 00:18:03.649
Boardroom: Followed by North Shaddock at 94 feet, which offers relatively more flexibility for accommodating taller buildings.

97
00:18:04.000 --> 00:18:12.889
Boardroom: The other two corridors are narrower, with Solano Avenue at 85 feet, and College Avenue at approximately 60 feet in total right-of-way.

98
00:18:16.520 --> 00:18:22.709
Boardroom: Now, in addition to overall heights, the report looks at building form and facade design.

99
00:18:22.920 --> 00:18:31.959
Boardroom: So, Alternative 1 allows the building facade to extend to its full height, and it's the most efficient and cost-effective option.

100
00:18:32.150 --> 00:18:50.009
Boardroom: Alternative 2 requires an upper floor step back on facades facing the side streets, and Alternative 3 requires upper floor step-backs on all street-facing facades, creating a more sculpted form and visual transition to adjacent neighborhoods.

101
00:18:52.580 --> 00:19:04.180
Boardroom: So the examples shown here are from San Pablo Specific pan, which takes a prescriptive approach, and these images here are intended to spark a discussion.

102
00:19:04.320 --> 00:19:14.459
Boardroom: We'd like your feedback on whether and how objective design standards should be included in the new zoning, and how detailed they should be.

103
00:19:14.690 --> 00:19:25.580
Boardroom: So a key question here is how to balance clear, predictable standards with flexibility for design innovation along these three corridors.

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104
00:19:28.770 --> 00:19:38.610
Boardroom: So, in addition to heightened massing, we're studying where to require ground floor retail, and whether to allow ground floor residential in certain locations.

105
00:19:39.670 --> 00:19:47.680
Boardroom: So on Solano Avenue, the first alternative would require retail or retail-ready space along the entire corridor.

106
00:19:48.130 --> 00:19:57.450
Boardroom: The second alternative would focus retail near Ensenada Avenue, while allowing ground floor residential west of that point.

107
00:19:57.840 --> 00:20:09.950
Boardroom: So similarly, on College and North Shaddock, we're exploring options to target retail to active nodes, while allowing greater flexibility elsewhere to improve project feasibility.

108
00:20:11.400 --> 00:20:18.469
Boardroom: Now, another concept under consideration is allowing residential-only buildings in select locations.

109
00:20:18.590 --> 00:20:24.169
Boardroom: So, the first alternative would require retail on all street frontages.

110
00:20:24.400 --> 00:20:34.730
Boardroom: While the second, shown in yellow, would permit residential-only ground floors in certain areas where continuous retail may not be viable.

111
00:20:37.030 --> 00:20:41.250
Boardroom: And here, you can see another alternative concept we're exploring.

112
00:20:41.560 --> 00:20:47.040
Boardroom: This is more prominent on the other corridors than here onâ€¦ than here in Elmwood.

113
00:20:47.210 --> 00:21:04.800
Boardroom: But we're looking at potentially allowing residential-only buildings in certain locations. So on the top is an alternative that

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would require retail on all street frontages, and below, an alternative that would allow residential only on ground floors where you see yellow.

114
00:21:07.380 --> 00:21:12.840
Boardroom: Now, this section will summarize feedback received so far through our outreach efforts.

115
00:21:15.200 --> 00:21:33.979
Boardroom: Sharing key takeaways from the Planning Commission work session in September, and these include ground floor vitality. So, commissioners emphasized that street-level experience matters most. Storefronts should be active, transparent, welcoming to pedestrians.

116
00:21:34.410 --> 00:21:44.660
Boardroom: They also stressed maintaining affordable, flexible spaces for small and legacy businesses to preserve neighborhood character and economic diversity.

117
00:21:45.090 --> 00:21:55.599
Boardroom: Commissioners were less concerned about prescriptive, objective design standards above the ground floor, favoring flexibility to allow creative, context-sensitive design.

118
00:21:56.410 --> 00:22:09.739
Boardroom: And there was an overall openness to taller buildings if they demonstrate high-quality design, appropriate neighborhood transitions, and contribute to a vibrant, walkable environments.

119
00:22:12.880 --> 00:22:26.219
Boardroom: Now, as I previously mentioned, we published a survey at the end of August. The survey opened for a little over a month, and we received a total of 1,644 responses.

120
00:22:26.530 --> 00:22:33.019
Boardroom: Survey participants could answer questions about all three corridors, or choose one corridor.

121
00:22:35.940 --> 00:22:42.329
Boardroom: Now, we have about 1,200 people that responded to the demographic questions in the survey.

122
00:22:42.650 --> 00:22:49.069
Boardroom: Here we see there's a shift in the respondents' demographics to the survey versus the in-person meetings.

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123
00:22:49.530 --> 00:22:58.770
Boardroom: For the survey, around 53% of the respondents are over the age of 55, compared to over 65 for the in-person meetings.

124
00:23:04.160 --> 00:23:06.190
Boardroom: Now, Okay.

125
00:23:06.270 --> 00:23:22.729
Boardroom: So, for Solano Avenue, here we're comparing the workshop, the results that we received in the workshop, from what we heard in the survey. So, as you can see, we had about 120 participants, in the Solano Avenue workshop.

126
00:23:22.750 --> 00:23:30.159
Boardroom: and about 819 respondents who responded to the survey.

127
00:23:32.510 --> 00:23:45.089
Boardroom: Now, for North Shaddock, we again see a similar pattern as we saw in Solano, a stronger support for updating the zoning in the survey compared to the in-person workshop.

128
00:23:49.370 --> 00:23:56.679
Boardroom: on College Avenue, feedback was evenly divided in both the survey and the in-person workshops.

129
00:23:56.910 --> 00:24:06.430
Boardroom: While some participants supported rezoning to allow additional housing, an equally large group expressed a desire to keep the zoning as it is.

130
00:24:09.480 --> 00:24:18.050
Boardroom: Now, across both the workshops and the community survey, we heard many consistent themes about the future of these three corridors.

131
00:24:18.410 --> 00:24:33.060
Boardroom: Community members emphasize the importance of maintaining corridor vibrancy, keeping these areas active, walkable, and economically healthy, while continuing to support small and legacy businesses that define their character.

132
00:24:33.550 --> 00:24:42.140

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Boardroom: There's also strong recognition of the need to add housing at a range of affordability levels, especially in these high-resource locations.

133
00:24:42.630 --> 00:24:58.490
Boardroom: Participants also highlighted the value of high-quality, context-sensitive design, including step-backs and transitions that fit surrounding neighborhoods, and the importance of improving walkability, greenery, and public space to make the corridors more welcoming.

134
00:24:59.260 --> 00:25:11.789
Boardroom: At the same time, we also heard concerns about potential businesses, displacement, building height and scale, and parking and traffic impacts, particularly in the Elmwood and along Solano.

135
00:25:13.090 --> 00:25:21.280
Boardroom: Some participants also expressed skepticism about whether zoning changes will deliver meaningful affordability outcomes.

136
00:25:21.790 --> 00:25:37.310
Boardroom: So, overall, the feedback reflects some interest in allowing change, paired with a strong desire to ensure it is carefully managed through thoughtful design and balanced outcomes that reflect each corridor's character and needs.

137
00:25:37.790 --> 00:25:43.289
Boardroom: Now, this is all a very high-level overview of all the feedback that we received.

138
00:25:43.410 --> 00:25:49.279
Boardroom: We had a number of great discussions with many community members. We heard lots of concerns of

139
00:25:49.560 --> 00:25:59.029
Boardroom: about how change will impact their communities. Parking was a key issue that was continually brought up, along with the overall impact of new development.

140
00:25:59.170 --> 00:26:09.280
Boardroom: And we only have time to share a little today, but there's a larger report summarizing the feedback from the in-person meetings and survey on the project webpage.

141
00:26:10.780 --> 00:26:24.089

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Boardroom: Now, this slide highlights the difference between overall survey responses and responses from residents of each corridor regarding whether to update or retain the existing zoning.

142
00:26:24.630 --> 00:26:35.410
Boardroom: So overall, a slight majority of participants supported zoning updates along Solano Avenue and North Shaddock, as you can see in the top row.

143
00:26:35.690 --> 00:26:40.050
Boardroom: While College Avenue responses were more evenly split.

144
00:26:40.770 --> 00:26:52.800
Boardroom: However, comparing these pie charts show that slightly larger proportion of residents living on or near the corridors express stronger support for keeping the existing zoning.

145
00:26:55.700 --> 00:26:59.070
Boardroom: We now come to the last section of the presentation.

146
00:26:59.700 --> 00:27:04.489
Boardroom: So, before we jump into questions, I wanted to highlight next steps.

147
00:27:04.950 --> 00:27:24.730
Boardroom: We heard from many community members about the importance of supporting retail and existing small businesses along the three corridors. So following this series of second workshops that we held in August, staff asked the consultant team to develop strategies to mitigate potential impacts on small businesses.

148
00:27:24.940 --> 00:27:30.000
Boardroom: These findings will be presented to Planning Commission and City Council in the coming months.

149
00:27:30.240 --> 00:27:37.769
Boardroom: Community members will also have another opportunity to share feedback at the third round of workshops early next year.

150
00:27:38.170 --> 00:27:48.689
Boardroom: And to reiterate, all the ideas presented today are draft concepts, and we're looking for Council's input on the overall approach for each corridor.

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151
00:27:50.040 --> 00:27:55.519
Boardroom: So with that, Yeah, we're jumping into the questions per corridor.

152
00:27:55.850 --> 00:28:04.669
Boardroom: So, starting withâ€¦ Which base height option best adds housing while fitting corridor character?

153
00:28:05.530 --> 00:28:08.539
Boardroom: Second question, upper floor step backs.

154
00:28:08.640 --> 00:28:10.609
Boardroom: Should we require none?

155
00:28:10.970 --> 00:28:15.490
Boardroom: Only on side streets, or step backs on both streets.

156
00:28:19.040 --> 00:28:27.419
Boardroom: Ground floor users, should retail be required corridor-wide or targeted to nodes with flexibility elsewhere?

157
00:28:27.870 --> 00:28:34.089
Boardroom: And lastly, should the project include more detailed objective design standards?

158
00:28:35.140 --> 00:28:42.099
Boardroom: So, that's the end of the presentation. Thank you all. Council can now ask questions and open for public comments.

159
00:28:43.800 --> 00:28:46.710
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you very much. Yeah.

160
00:28:49.190 --> 00:28:50.130
Boardroom: Yes.

161
00:28:50.480 --> 00:28:56.989
Boardroom: Okay, so I will start with, questions from Council, please, starting with Councilmember Taplin.

162
00:28:57.700 --> 00:29:10.999

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Boardroom: Thank you very much, Madam Mayor, and thank you all for the presentation and your work to date on this project, and thanks to everyone for being here, for being here. Could we look at the slide again that shows where housing is concentrated throughout the city?

163
00:29:19.330 --> 00:29:20.699
Boardroom: Super sad.

164
00:29:21.680 --> 00:29:22.690
Boardroom: Dig out of this.

165
00:29:25.180 --> 00:29:26.129
Boardroom: So, thank you.

166
00:29:29.140 --> 00:29:35.590
Boardroom: Thank you. Yeah, so we're seeing housing concentrated downtown, Southside, Adeline, and San Pabel Avenue.

167
00:29:35.700 --> 00:29:39.369
Boardroom: And I note that in the staff report,

168
00:29:39.510 --> 00:29:51.009
Boardroom: It states that Solano Avenue has the highest rate of homeownership in the city, and it has produced the least amount of housing. And I'm wondering, from your, expertise, why that isâ€¦

169
00:29:59.070 --> 00:30:04.589
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember, for that question. Is it a problem? Yes, it is. Thank you.

170
00:30:04.780 --> 00:30:08.500
Boardroom: Yeah, I think that, you know, we've noted that,

171
00:30:09.000 --> 00:30:12.560
Boardroom: Solano Avenue is currently only zoned for 2 stories.

172
00:30:13.050 --> 00:30:14.230
Boardroom: Andâ€¦

173
00:30:14.480 --> 00:30:29.050

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Boardroom: it's justâ€¦ it's difficult for projects, for new housing projects toâ€¦ to pencil, withâ€¦ at those heights. You know, projects that, you know, most of the construction that we've seen over the lastâ€¦

174
00:30:29.330 --> 00:30:35.829
Boardroom: 15 years in Berkeley, ranges from 4 to 8 stories.

175
00:30:35.930 --> 00:30:43.940
Boardroom: And it's reallyâ€¦ it's difficult or impossible to hit those numbers with the existing zoning.

176
00:30:44.930 --> 00:30:52.220
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Can we revisit the slide with the demographic breakdown of the survey responses and the workshop presentation?

177
00:31:02.650 --> 00:31:04.520
Boardroom: He wanted a demographic.

178
00:31:07.430 --> 00:31:08.840
Boardroom: Here we go. Yeah.

179
00:31:11.690 --> 00:31:18.850
Boardroom: Thank you very much. I'mâ€¦ here, I'm curious as to why there's such aâ€¦

180
00:31:19.310 --> 00:31:23.080
Boardroom: A chasm between the renter versus owner.

181
00:31:23.490 --> 00:31:31.190
Boardroom: Participation, and similarly, why there is such a disparity between participants whoâ€¦

182
00:31:31.850 --> 00:31:37.259
Boardroom: identify as ethnically white versus Asian, Asian American, Hispanic, or Latino, Latinx?

183
00:31:40.260 --> 00:31:41.480
Boardroom: Anybody?

184
00:31:42.470 --> 00:31:45.809
Boardroom: Yeah, that's a great question. I think thatâ€¦

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185
00:31:47.010 --> 00:31:52.600
Boardroom: I think it's fair to say that, homeowners

186
00:31:53.960 --> 00:32:01.840
Boardroom: I tend to be more engaged inâ€¦ In planning and zoning issues.

187
00:32:02.520 --> 00:32:07.620
Boardroom: than renters. I think it's something that is not atypical.

188
00:32:07.820 --> 00:32:11.940
Boardroom: Andâ€¦

189
00:32:12.220 --> 00:32:24.040
Boardroom: I think that also, relates toâ€¦ to race and ethnicity as well. We see more white people, engaged,

190
00:32:25.240 --> 00:32:38.570
Boardroom: the age breakdown here, 18 to 54, is a pretty large block there, I'm realizing now, but if we saw that one broken down further, I suspect that we would see also theâ€¦

191
00:32:38.680 --> 00:32:41.219
Boardroom: the survey respondents

192
00:32:41.410 --> 00:32:51.780
Boardroom: are not representative of the Berkeley community by age as well, right? So I think what you're identifying is that the respondents to this survey

193
00:32:52.190 --> 00:32:58.939
Boardroom: theâ€¦ the response sample is skewed. It's not representative of theâ€¦

194
00:32:59.090 --> 00:33:05.570
Boardroom: owner versus renter makeup of the Berkeley community, which I think is closer to a 50-50 split, right? Yeah.

195
00:33:05.800 --> 00:33:11.950
Boardroom: Thank you very much, and, I just have, like, 3 more questions. Can we see the slide that compares,

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196
00:33:12.150 --> 00:33:16.109
Boardroom: The survey response rate across the corridors?

197
00:33:24.570 --> 00:33:34.339
Boardroom: Regarding North Shattuck, at the time of the survey, was UC Berkeley in session?

198
00:33:35.640 --> 00:33:37.720
Boardroom: It was.

199
00:33:37.920 --> 00:33:46.220
Boardroom: Can you describe efforts to engage the campus community, including students who are living along that corridor?

200
00:33:48.740 --> 00:33:51.839
Boardroom: I understand that they're renters, and that's why I'm asking. Thank you.

201
00:33:52.480 --> 00:34:02.999
Boardroom: So, we did reach out to student organizations. There was email blasts which were sent to multiple organizations in the city. They were part of it as well.

202
00:34:03.000 --> 00:34:13.340
Boardroom: we did not hear from them. Theyâ€¦ this organization, however, we also did share the survey, e-blast as well with them,

203
00:34:13.630 --> 00:34:26.429
Boardroom: Another initiative that we have, we're working on is our social media. So we do see a lot of younger folks engaged through our Instagram.

204
00:34:26.730 --> 00:34:28.139
Boardroom: For the project.

205
00:34:28.449 --> 00:34:31.830
Boardroom: And I will note, if you allow me to interject here, Utra.

206
00:34:32.150 --> 00:34:54.259
Boardroom: made a heroic effort to stand up an Instagram account for this project. It's the first time we've done that forâ€¦ for a planning project to useâ€¦ that's the first time we've used that channel, so,

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like, there was an attempt. We, you know, we don't have as many followers as we'd like, that's bad. You know, with the new account, there's aâ€¦ there's a ramp up, but, you know.

207
00:34:54.610 --> 00:34:59.399
Boardroom: I will be frank, it's a hardâ€¦ it'sâ€¦ historically, we haven't had

208
00:34:59.600 --> 00:35:11.729
Boardroom: as much success as I would like reaching the student population to the effect that their voices would be accurately represented in our surveys, at our meetings, etc.

209
00:35:12.100 --> 00:35:19.229
Boardroom: Thank you very much. I think this underscores the unrepresentative nature of the survey responses and workshop participants.

210
00:35:19.340 --> 00:35:21.350
Boardroom: Although itâ€¦

211
00:35:21.570 --> 00:35:31.079
Boardroom: The slide before us does seem to show that among those who did respond to the survey and participate, a majority do support

212
00:35:31.880 --> 00:35:33.899
Boardroom: One or several of the alternatives.

213
00:35:34.210 --> 00:35:43.920
Boardroom: Yes. Yes. So my final question is regarding, commercial retailâ€¦

214
00:35:44.800 --> 00:35:53.269
Boardroom: Is there a working definition that defines a distinction between retail and retail-ready space.

215
00:35:54.980 --> 00:35:55.730
Boardroom: Yeah, sure.

216
00:35:58.300 --> 00:35:59.769
Boardroom: Thank you.

217

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00:36:00.060 --> 00:36:13.170
Boardroom: it can mean multiple things, and we would get into the details in the next phase. The general purpose of having something retail-ready is that it canâ€¦ it has the proper plumbing.

218
00:36:13.350 --> 00:36:29.570
Boardroom: If we want to emphasize food and beverage, it has the proper ventilation, or easily adaptable to provide the proper ventilation. And the purpose for that would be to get spaces that, even though there may not be retail tenants

219
00:36:30.310 --> 00:36:39.179
Boardroom: Ready to move in, that at any time, that space can be easily converted without a very expensive, renovation.

220
00:36:39.480 --> 00:36:44.630
Boardroom: Thank you. As a follow-up, if someone were toâ€¦ if we were to adopt,

221
00:36:46.330 --> 00:36:54.050
Boardroom: a version of this would allow for the conversion of retail to residential. Howâ€¦ how feasible andâ€¦

222
00:36:54.780 --> 00:37:04.509
Boardroom: possible would it be for someone to acquire what was once a commercial ground floor space and convert it for residential use?

223
00:37:07.070 --> 00:37:17.689
Boardroom: I don't know if I have a good answer to that. We haven't really contemplated

224
00:37:18.510 --> 00:37:30.079
Boardroom: So much existing buildings being repurposed for ground floor residential. We've been more thinking about, like, are there places along the corridor that, if a project would redevelop.

225
00:37:30.290 --> 00:37:41.150
Boardroom: would it make sense for a 100% residential building as opposed to a conversion? So, I think I would need to, think about that more if that'sâ€¦

226
00:37:41.560 --> 00:37:46.070
Boardroom: Part of allowing a ground floor residential use that we may see conversions.

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227
00:37:46.310 --> 00:37:53.259
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Those are all my questions. Okay, thank you, Councilmemberâ€¦ Oops. Moving on to Councilmember O'Keefe.

228
00:37:54.560 --> 00:38:13.240
Boardroom: Thanks. First question, have you guys considered making, like, a TikTok account with some cool videos? I think that would be really great. I can see it. I can see it. That's my first question. Seriously, this is a very important, project to me as the council member representing two of the three districts.

229
00:38:13.470 --> 00:38:21.930
Boardroom: weâ€¦ together, we got North Static together, but I, this is near and dear to my heart, so I wanted to acknowledge that, so thanks for letting me go early.

230
00:38:22.910 --> 00:38:29.530
Boardroom: My staff and I, we've gotten a lot of emails. We have read all of them. Thank you very much.

231
00:38:29.590 --> 00:38:49.310
Boardroom: to the community for being so engaged on this. What we've done is I've looked through the emails carefully and tried to pull out themes for things that people are concerned about or have questions about. And so one main goal I have right now is to give voice to the concerns that have been expressed to my office.

232
00:38:49.510 --> 00:39:01.520
Boardroom: And so, I haveâ€¦ I ended up with quite a few questions. I'm going to ask 4 of them right now. I think other council members might be asking other ones that I want to ask, so I'm just gonna stick with 4, and thenâ€¦

233
00:39:01.660 --> 00:39:12.639
Boardroom: Mayor, I have 3 more after, and I'll let everyone else go, and then maybe if you feel like it, I could ask the other ones. But I'm gonna just ask 4 right now. Two are about the process, and two are about the zoning itself.

234
00:39:13.030 --> 00:39:29.430
Boardroom: Okay, so here we go. Your, great presentation, by the way, thank you, really informative. And it did already address this, but, it's about community engagement. And I'm wondering if you could speak a little more to the way that you engaged with small businesses.

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235
00:39:29.840 --> 00:39:42.169
Boardroom: You know, you mentioned you reached out to a few groups, but I know there's a little more detail there, if you could provide a little more detail on howâ€¦ who you talk to, and what methods you use to reach out. Yeah, thank you, Councilmember.

236
00:39:43.720 --> 00:39:59.129
Boardroom: Historically, from my experience, the most effective way to connect with small businesses is to partner with the organizations thatâ€¦ their member organizations, merchants associations, and business improvement districts in Berkeley, and we have a lot of them.

237
00:39:59.190 --> 00:40:04.690
Boardroom: And they're well-run, effective organizations, right? And soâ€¦

238
00:40:04.860 --> 00:40:14.990
Boardroom: So, the wayâ€¦ we start by reaching out to those organizations, and so Utra emailed the contacts forâ€¦

239
00:40:15.220 --> 00:40:27.350
Boardroom: The merchants' associations and business districts in these districts. As she mentioned, along with neighborhood associations, other organizations, and invited them to

240
00:40:27.730 --> 00:40:37.289
Boardroom: and ask them to invite us to their meeting so that we can meet with them where they're at, right? And we have that opportunity with two

241
00:40:37.290 --> 00:40:54.380
Boardroom: out of the three organizations, North Shaddock Association didn't initially respond, but now we are in touch with them, and we're scheduling a meeting for the first week of December. And I want to acknowledge, when they first got the email, maybe they didn't know what it was, andâ€¦

242
00:40:54.500 --> 00:40:57.560
Boardroom: I get it. I miss emails, too.

243
00:40:58.030 --> 00:41:11.410
Boardroom: So, there was that level of engagement. We also walked the corridors, and to talk to business owners, and to hand out flyers, and to invite them to attend our workshops. Andâ€¦

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244
00:41:11.720 --> 00:41:12.870
Boardroom: Many did.

245
00:41:13.120 --> 00:41:17.909
Boardroom: I personally spoke with many business owners at the three workshops.

246
00:41:18.010 --> 00:41:28.160
Boardroom: And I saw a bunch of others there that I know, that I didn't get to talk to, but I saw them talking to Justin, or Uthera, or Chris, other members of our project team. And soâ€¦

247
00:41:28.780 --> 00:41:31.870
Boardroom: We, we definitely engaged.

248
00:41:32.310 --> 00:41:34.269
Boardroom: I'm also hearingâ€¦

249
00:41:35.840 --> 00:41:46.080
Boardroom: and seeing quotes that there was no effort to engage, and so that's a little disheartening, to be honest with you, because there was an effort, but like I said in my opening comments.

250
00:41:46.080 --> 00:42:03.620
Boardroom: we are happy to engage more and make more of an effort, and I expect that will happen in the coming months. Great, yeah, thank you for making that clear, because I think that's the right answer. If someone didn't get the message yet to know that you're still absolutely willing to engage, I think that's important. And of course, tonight is also a way to engage.

251
00:42:03.660 --> 00:42:06.050
Boardroom: So, thank you. Next question.

252
00:42:06.350 --> 00:42:17.799
Boardroom: Some people feel that this process has been rushed, and I know you had the timeline up there, but if you wanted to add any more detail about, like, actually how long this has beenâ€¦

253
00:42:18.140 --> 00:42:24.120
Boardroom: And, like, what is the timeline, and howâ€¦ and what's typical for this kind of process?

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254
00:42:24.410 --> 00:42:28.900
Boardroom: Yeah, so I want to note that

255
00:42:28.900 --> 00:42:49.640
Boardroom: the germ of this project really came from the housing element, which itself was the subject to an over two-year public process, right? That included many meetings, many referrals from the City Council, a lot of input from Council about what Council wanted to see in the housing element.

256
00:42:49.640 --> 00:42:55.800
Boardroom: And one of the number one priorities that the Council expressed was to focus

257
00:42:55.840 --> 00:43:05.059
Boardroom: housing growth on the corridors that are well served by amenities and transit. That enables more walkable communities.

258
00:43:05.480 --> 00:43:09.189
Boardroom: And Council itself

259
00:43:10.030 --> 00:43:20.490
Boardroom: With encouragement, like, through the stateâ€¦ by the state, through the law, identified affirmatively furthering fair housing as one of the key priorities of the housing element.

260
00:43:20.760 --> 00:43:35.959
Boardroom: And so, when we were talking about different strategies to affirmatively further fair housing, creating opportunities for housing in neighborhoods that have high rates of home ownership, and that are higher income, and that have not historically produced housing.

261
00:43:36.220 --> 00:43:37.200
Boardroom: wasâ€¦

262
00:43:37.500 --> 00:43:50.680
Boardroom: a priority identified in the housing element. And so, that'sâ€¦ that wasâ€¦ that idea in itself was subject to multiple years of community process. So we launched this project, inâ€¦

263
00:43:51.370 --> 00:43:55.800
Boardroom: The middle of 2024, Is that right? Yeah.

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264
00:43:56.860 --> 00:44:11.380
Boardroom: Andâ€¦ and and we did our, you know, there was work that went into leading up to the public outreach that really began in earnest at the beginning of this calendar year. And as Uttara noted, we didâ€¦

265
00:44:11.510 --> 00:44:19.270
Boardroom: There have been two phases so far, there's at least one phase still to come. And so, I mean, I don'tâ€¦ that doesn't feel rushed to me.

266
00:44:19.580 --> 00:44:24.060
Boardroom: As I've noted, I think that we've tried to approach this

267
00:44:24.250 --> 00:44:30.489
Boardroom: thoughtfully, gradually, and deliberately. There are no plans or zoning amendments

268
00:44:30.990 --> 00:44:37.960
Boardroom: in front of you tonight for adoption, so it doesn't feel rushed to me, but I understand that some people feel differently.

269
00:44:38.810 --> 00:44:56.720
Boardroom: Thank you, and you actually partially answered, or maybe fully answered, my next question, which was, I was gonna ask you to speak to the greater context of meeting our housing goals, but I think you explained that pretty well with the housing element, and why we're doing this, soâ€¦ so thank you for answering that. My last question is if you could speak to,

270
00:44:58.690 --> 00:45:02.489
Boardroom: What you expect in terms of, the production of low-income housing?

271
00:45:02.740 --> 00:45:14.169
Boardroom: You know, you mentioned the density bonus, which comes with that, but if you could speak in a little more detail to how you expect that to play out. Sure. So, the City of Berkeley has a 20% inclusionary policy.

272
00:45:14.360 --> 00:45:28.510
Boardroom: That, that's not changing. That's not impacted by thisâ€¦ by this action. So 20% of new units, that 10â€¦ so half of that for low-income households, the other half for very low-income households.

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273
00:45:28.510 --> 00:45:35.599
Boardroom: What we've historically seen for most projects in Berkeley, most projects take advantage of the density bonus.

274
00:45:35.750 --> 00:45:46.789
Boardroom: At 50%. So, theyâ€¦ They include between 10 and 15% of the units on-site, usually all for

275
00:45:46.830 --> 00:46:02.979
Boardroom: very low-income households. Sorry, could you clarify that there's also a fee option? Yeah, yeah, I'm gonna get to that. Yeah, so, theyâ€¦ most projects take advantage of the density bonus, so they include 10-15% of the units on-site.

276
00:46:03.190 --> 00:46:19.300
Boardroom: And, asâ€¦ and then they make up the remainder by paying the in-lieu fee. That's what we mostly see, mixed compliance. In theory, a project could fee out altogether, and only pay the fee, and not provide any on-site units. The good thing about getting the fees

277
00:46:19.300 --> 00:46:31.059
Boardroom: is that the city, our Housing and Community Services Division has done a fantastic job at leveraging our Affordable Housing Trust Fund to attract outside funds from other sources.

278
00:46:31.090 --> 00:46:49.639
Boardroom: And our nonprofit development partners, so we use those funds to fund 100% affordable projects all around the city. Butâ€¦ so that's when we get the fees, but whenâ€¦ the benefit of the density bonus program, and when people do the on-site option, is that we get units right away.

279
00:46:49.680 --> 00:47:02.100
Boardroom: So, I expect that any projects that would result from this policy change would comply with our inclusionary housing requirements, so, in one of those ways.

280
00:47:03.070 --> 00:47:08.300
Boardroom: And have you run, I know you have some projected number of units that mightâ€¦

281
00:47:08.530 --> 00:47:14.809
Boardroom: be created under this? Do you have a similarly projected number of affordable units that might be created?

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282
00:47:16.070 --> 00:47:18.510
Boardroom: Assuming peopleâ€¦

283
00:47:18.650 --> 00:47:32.850
Boardroom: Yeah, apparently 15%. 15% ofâ€¦ so if it's $1,000, 15% of that. Yeah, and soâ€¦ And that's all on-site. Yeah, and then plus additional fees to our affordable housing trust fund, and it's hard to thenâ€¦

284
00:47:34.050 --> 00:47:52.259
Boardroom: translate how many other additional units. So when we say 15%, that doesn't include the other units that would result from the fees. Yeah, I appreciate that, although I do want to just, you know, it's not really editorializing time, but, it's especially important, to me at least, to have the affordable units be built on-site because of the equity issues at play, so Iâ€¦

285
00:47:52.260 --> 00:47:54.770
Boardroom: I'm glad it's, I'm glad you're expecting 15%.

286
00:47:54.990 --> 00:48:19.299
Boardroom: Okay, those are my four time, if youâ€¦ you have 1 minute, 45 seconds, if you want to ask. No, I think I want toâ€¦ because I picked the four that I like the best, and then other people are gonna ask other ones, and then if we have time, I'll come back. So thank you very much. I'll reserve the rest of my time. Sounds good. Thank you so much. Thank you. And I know someoneâ€¦ there's some folks who are putting up signs. If you could just keep them down so everyone can see, that would be great. You can put them on the side if you want, that's fine, but just,

287
00:48:19.300 --> 00:48:21.209
Boardroom: Just try not to block people's view.

288
00:48:21.330 --> 00:48:23.950
Boardroom: Thank you. Alright, so we're gonna go to Councilmember Trajka.

289
00:48:25.390 --> 00:48:31.560
Boardroom: Thank you so much, Madam Mayor. Thank you to staff for the presentation.

290
00:48:32.130 --> 00:48:38.950
Boardroom: And the community engagement to date. And thank you to the community for coming out.

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291
00:48:40.780 --> 00:48:56.459
Boardroom: As is my general policy and practice, it is my intent to listen to the community and keep an open mind on this proposal, and it is with that intent that I would like to ask the following questions.

292
00:48:56.840 --> 00:49:03.479
Boardroom: I will do them in rapid fire, just to try to help us save a little bit of time.

293
00:49:03.790 --> 00:49:06.190
Boardroom: Question one.

294
00:49:07.270 --> 00:49:08.280
Boardroom: What?

295
00:49:09.800 --> 00:49:11.390
Boardroom: mechanisms.

296
00:49:11.960 --> 00:49:15.570
Boardroom: Exist, or are being contemplated.

297
00:49:16.520 --> 00:49:28.109
Boardroom: to protectâ€¦ Community-serving uses, such as our small businesses, Andâ€¦ How does that interplay?

298
00:49:28.740 --> 00:49:31.369
Boardroom: with what protections?

299
00:49:32.320 --> 00:49:41.409
Boardroom: can, be legally allowed by the state constitution, for example, unlike residential.

300
00:49:41.420 --> 00:49:54.819
Boardroom: We're not able to have commercial rent control, but can you talk about, the report mentioned, a fund to support businesses in, with relocation expenses?

301
00:49:54.920 --> 00:49:59.709
Boardroom: What protections, if any, could be deemed possible?

302

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00:49:59.970 --> 00:50:06.210
Boardroom: Around them coming back at a comparable rent, and so forth.

303
00:50:06.320 --> 00:50:08.430
Boardroom: Question number one,

304
00:50:09.450 --> 00:50:22.399
Boardroom: Question number two are what safeguards are being proposed to prevent stalled projects, vacant lots, and long-term cold-shelled buildings, and how will the community be protected if market conditions shift?

305
00:50:23.160 --> 00:50:27.660
Boardroom: I'm sorry, could youâ€¦ I didn't catch that one, could you restate that? Yeah. Whatâ€¦

306
00:50:28.770 --> 00:50:33.730
Boardroom: Safeguards are being proposed to prevent stalled projects, vacant lots.

307
00:50:34.030 --> 00:50:41.679
Boardroom: And long-term cold-shelled buildings? And how will the community be protected if market conditions shift?

308
00:50:46.310 --> 00:50:49.840
Boardroom: Hopefully that will not count towards my time.

309
00:50:50.480 --> 00:51:01.839
Boardroom: A third question is, you, you talked about the 50%, density bonus. Can you talk about the interplay between,

310
00:51:01.840 --> 00:51:13.549
Boardroom: Can you talk about, for the 75% or the 100% density bonus scenario, what would be required of the developer,

311
00:51:13.640 --> 00:51:23.169
Boardroom: And, how does that impact, or could that impact the affordability mix?

312
00:51:23.520 --> 00:51:32.870
Boardroom: My next question is, have, the extent to which live-work and flexible mixed-use models

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313
00:51:33.110 --> 00:51:41.489
Boardroom: Been fullyâ€¦ been evaluated as tools to add housing, while also strengthening local business activity and street life.

314
00:51:41.930 --> 00:51:53.930
Boardroom: And my last question, and I really appreciate the survey, I was curious, what the, if you could talk about theâ€¦

315
00:51:54.140 --> 00:52:01.199
Boardroom: the thinking that went into, I noticed that there was a 36-year, age gap.

316
00:52:01.310 --> 00:52:04.670
Boardroom: In the fourth category. I believe theâ€¦

317
00:52:04.790 --> 00:52:23.060
Boardroom: 18 to 54, and then the next one was, I think 9 years. And I just wanted to, understand the thinking behind it, but also, if there are going to be further surveys done,

318
00:52:23.160 --> 00:52:32.189
Boardroom: Would consideration be given, or could it, to other, delineations, you know?

319
00:52:32.500 --> 00:52:36.650
Boardroom: Around age and or other factors. Thank you.

320
00:52:40.710 --> 00:52:49.029
Boardroom: All right. Thank you, Councilmember Tragu. I think we'll team up on this, but,

321
00:52:49.650 --> 00:53:04.130
Boardroom: So your first question, what mechanisms exist or are being contemplated to protect small businesses? How does that interplay with what protections could be legally allowed by the state constitution? And you mentioned a couple things. I want to talk about the existing protections first. And soâ€¦

322
00:53:04.130 --> 00:53:10.589
Boardroom: Currently, when projects happen, there are conditions placed on development projects.

323

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00:53:10.610 --> 00:53:23.210
Boardroom: to require them to minimize impacts on the surrounding community. From noise, dust, vibration. They're also required to institute, they're also

324
00:53:23.210 --> 00:53:35.039
Boardroom: required to submit a traffic control plan to ensure that the surrounding areas will still be accessible to people on all modes of transportation. So, I think that that will be especially important.

325
00:53:35.040 --> 00:53:49.089
Boardroom: And, our transportation division works regularly to make sure those TCPs are adequate and that they're being enforced. And so, I think that'll be especially important, when we see development happen on these corridors.

326
00:53:49.360 --> 00:53:51.620
Boardroom: I also want to note that,

327
00:53:53.350 --> 00:53:59.110
Boardroom: Well, let meâ€¦ I wannaâ€¦ I wanna talk about small business displacement.

328
00:54:01.120 --> 00:54:04.849
Boardroom: So, generally, when development happens, it happens onâ€¦

329
00:54:05.300 --> 00:54:20.559
Boardroom: Vacant lots, lots that are underutilized. That's what's typical, right? When a property has an active business tenant, it is producing revenue for the owner, and it's less likely to be developed.

330
00:54:21.380 --> 00:54:28.629
Boardroom: So I just want to note that. Now, I'm not saying that small business displacement doesn't happen, because it does.

331
00:54:29.120 --> 00:54:30.149
Boardroom: But it's rare.

332
00:54:30.460 --> 00:54:48.630
Boardroom: It doesn't happen a lot. Folks, please, hey, excuse me! Please be respectful. I'm justâ€¦ Folks, he's sharingâ€¦ I'm just speaking the facts from my experience. Thank you. As your staff member. Right?

333

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00:54:48.700 --> 00:54:56.729
Boardroom: Hey, please, you're really being at that point right now, let him finish. So it does happen, right? When it happens, thankfully, we haveâ€¦

334
00:54:57.330 --> 00:55:09.980
Boardroom: A talented Office of Economic Development, small but mighty, as they've also often been noted, right? And they work directly with small businesses to support them.

335
00:55:09.980 --> 00:55:21.010
Boardroom: Whether that means connecting them with spaces, with commercial brokers, helping them come up with a plan. We have financing resources, we have the city.

336
00:55:21.100 --> 00:55:31.469
Boardroom: Not all cities Berkeley size have their own revolving loan fund, but we do, and that helps small businesses cover capital costs.

337
00:55:31.740 --> 00:55:36.479
Boardroom: Related to New START, including costs related to moving.

338
00:55:36.610 --> 00:55:43.499
Boardroom: It's an eligible expenditure for our RLF, right? So we have some support programs in place.

339
00:55:44.120 --> 00:55:47.689
Boardroom: As, as has been noted several times.

340
00:55:47.940 --> 00:55:55.389
Boardroom: what more couldâ€¦ like, we want to know what more could we be doing. And, like, what other policy options

341
00:55:56.100 --> 00:56:02.509
Boardroom: Could we be imposingâ€¦ Please. That aren't preempted by state law.

342
00:56:02.870 --> 00:56:03.620
Boardroom: Right?

343
00:56:03.870 --> 00:56:15.550

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Boardroom: And I don't have the answer to that yet. Thankfully, we have one of the most talented economic development planning firms in California that is working on this.

344
00:56:15.690 --> 00:56:26.230
Boardroom: Strategic Economics, a Berkeley-based firm, actually, is doing a survey. They're looking at existing provisions of state law.

345
00:56:26.430 --> 00:56:33.330
Boardroom: We're surveying other cities in California, They're conducting case studies.

346
00:56:33.780 --> 00:56:35.790
Boardroom: And looking into best practices.

347
00:56:36.400 --> 00:56:43.580
Boardroom: they're gonna be sending a report back to us that I'm hoping we will publish in January.

348
00:56:43.810 --> 00:56:49.480
Boardroom: And, as I noted up front, that is going to be shared with policymakers, certainly.

349
00:56:49.700 --> 00:56:57.570
Boardroom: well in advance of advancing any zoning amendments for adoption. So, I will have a better answer for you in a few months.

350
00:57:00.270 --> 00:57:11.320
Boardroom: To answer some of your other questions, well, one, in the full survey report, we do have a deeper demographic breakdown, soâ€¦

351
00:57:12.350 --> 00:57:22.909
Boardroom: 3% from the age of 18 to 24, 9.5% from 24 to 34, and then 19% from

352
00:57:24.030 --> 00:57:33.830
Boardroom: 35 to 44. So that'sâ€¦ that's where that breakdown is. We did ask that question, and just simplified it for the presentation.

353
00:57:34.170 --> 00:57:38.339
Boardroom: Speaking to the density bonus question.

354

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00:57:38.700 --> 00:57:51.809
Boardroom: One, I would like to point out, the density bonus is a moving target. It is subject to the whims of Sacramento and the state, and it changes over time.

355
00:57:51.990 --> 00:57:55.800
Boardroom: For a long period of time, the maximum bonus was about 35%.

356
00:57:55.950 --> 00:58:03.340
Boardroom: Over the last, 5-10 years, I think even more so in the last 2 to 3 years.

357
00:58:03.660 --> 00:58:06.249
Boardroom: The density bonus keeps on moving up.

358
00:58:06.500 --> 00:58:26.379
Boardroom: So now there's the first stage that allows you to get to that 50% bonus. There's a number of ways, it's a big calculation, but very simply, one of the easiest ways to get to the 50% bonus, as this slide shows, is by providing 15% of units at very low income.

359
00:58:26.850 --> 00:58:45.519
Boardroom: And then, there's a second round of bonus that, again, is a sliding scale, but if you provide 30% total on-site, that 15% very low income, and then an additional 15% at moderate income, you would hit that 100% density bonus.

360
00:58:46.950 --> 00:58:51.990
Boardroom: And then, to yourâ€¦ I believe yourâ€¦ yourâ€¦

361
00:58:52.110 --> 00:59:04.660
Boardroom: Other question, yes, we will be looking in more detail at ground floor standards, and, we will be looking at, you know, the potentially of live work.

362
00:59:04.960 --> 00:59:07.070
Boardroom: You know, howâ€¦

363
00:59:07.380 --> 00:59:21.029
Boardroom: Like, if we require, like, retail ready across the whole quarters, like, is there a way for them to be residential at times, commercial at times? Those are things that we'll look at in more detail in the next round.

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364
00:59:26.220 --> 00:59:32.390
Boardroom: Were there other questions thatâ€¦ I'm not sure if I fully answered your second question.

365
00:59:32.650 --> 00:59:44.910
Boardroom: I talked about it a little bit, what safeguards to prevent stalled projects, and how would the community be protected if market conditions shift? You know, I want to note that,

366
00:59:45.390 --> 00:59:53.769
Boardroom: I acknowledge we have a couple of very visible stall projects in downtown Berkeley, and it's frustrating. It's frustrating for me, too, right?

367
00:59:54.360 --> 01:00:03.260
Boardroom: Iâ€¦ I think that, there are particular market conditions of the last few years. Very high interest rates.

368
01:00:03.630 --> 01:00:08.380
Boardroom: a, increasingâ€¦ Labor and construction costs.

369
01:00:08.650 --> 01:00:13.769
Boardroom: rents that have flattened, in part because of the new housing production in Berkeley.

370
01:00:14.000 --> 01:00:23.630
Boardroom: That have led to a couple ofâ€¦ to particularly the high-rise projects that are generally a higher cost per square foot of construction.

371
01:00:23.890 --> 01:00:26.310
Boardroom: Those high-rise projects that

372
01:00:26.540 --> 01:00:36.079
Boardroom: that were entitled, and, and even one of them, even one that entered, that started construction, being stalled.

373
01:00:36.740 --> 01:00:40.300
Boardroom: Itâ€¦ itâ€¦ so we have these visible examples.

374
01:00:41.030 --> 01:00:56.540

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Boardroom: But if you go further back, I don'tâ€¦ it hadn'tâ€¦ there aren't many more examples of that, and so it hasn't previously been identified as a priority by the City Council for us to work on.

375
01:00:56.820 --> 01:00:57.520
Boardroom: Right?

376
01:00:57.690 --> 01:01:06.739
Boardroom: We haveâ€¦ I have started talking to staff about it, and, it's something I'm interested in working on.

377
01:01:07.290 --> 01:01:09.780
Boardroom: And would welcome a referral about it.

378
01:01:12.440 --> 01:01:18.289
Boardroom: More soon. Thank you. Okay, I'm gonna move us on to Councilmember Humbert.

379
01:01:20.220 --> 01:01:25.190
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor. I saw I was number 3, so I figured I had a couple more.

380
01:01:25.190 --> 01:01:40.369
Boardroom: Alright, I'm moving so you all are connected, your questions. Yeah, that makes sense. I signed up, to ask some of the questions compiled by Councilmember O'Keefe's staff, and then I have a couple of my own. These, the ones compiled byâ€¦

381
01:01:40.370 --> 01:01:42.450
Boardroom: Councilmember O'Keefe's staff work.

382
01:01:42.560 --> 01:01:51.909
Boardroom: kind of summaries of, of areas of concern that we heard from, many people, who sent in emails.

383
01:01:53.880 --> 01:02:12.100
Boardroom: concern. The concern is that we've built enough units. The question that flows from that is, some Berkeley residents are under the impression that we have built enough units, and indeed, over the last 10 years, we've added thousands. Can you speak to the idea that we have built enough?

384
01:02:21.080 --> 01:02:23.450

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Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember.

385
01:02:24.060 --> 01:02:31.040
Boardroom: We certainly, should be proud, I think, of the housing production numbers we have here in town.

386
01:02:31.530 --> 01:02:34.210
Boardroom: And whether we areâ€¦

387
01:02:35.080 --> 01:02:40.619
Boardroom: The main thing for the corridors, I should say, for the corridors, project within the housing element.

388
01:02:40.830 --> 01:02:49.370
Boardroom: is that the Corridors project is actually identified as part of the package of projects and policies that we have to affirmatively further fair housing.

389
01:02:49.820 --> 01:02:57.549
Boardroom: So, partâ€¦ the main, intent behind the corridor project is to address

390
01:02:57.850 --> 01:03:00.070
Boardroom: The history of exclusionary zoning in our town.

391
01:03:00.340 --> 01:03:09.009
Boardroom: And to advance the city's strategic priority of racial and income equity in our city.

392
01:03:09.240 --> 01:03:18.319
Boardroom: And so, although theâ€¦ although the upzoning will, hopefully, result in the construction of additional housing units.

393
01:03:18.490 --> 01:03:29.979
Boardroom: the project is not specifically targeted to meet our targets. As you know, we've done upzoning in the south side, we've done upzoning in, the middle housing zoning project.

394
01:03:30.120 --> 01:03:34.090
Boardroom: We've, zoning for the BART stations.

395
01:03:34.360 --> 01:03:53.030

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Boardroom: We're doing zoning in the San Pablo Avenue, so there are many, many areas of the city that have been upzoned, and, this is not the first place that we've looked at to upzone, but it is one of the ones that's identified in the housing element to do so. So, it will contribute to the housing supply, but it's not just

396
01:03:53.130 --> 01:03:58.390
Boardroom: a housing production policy approach. It has an equity component as well.

397
01:03:58.500 --> 01:04:16.709
Boardroom: Thank you, Mr. Horner. And I guess a little follow-up question I would have is that there's a general impression that, you know, that there are a lot of vacant apartments out there. But in fact, Berkeley Side recently published an article, and they did an analysis of that, and

398
01:04:16.710 --> 01:04:21.750
Boardroom: And, correct me if I'm wrong, they determined that, in fact, there's a veryâ€¦

399
01:04:21.750 --> 01:04:46.090
Boardroom: relatively low vacancy rate, is that correct? Yeah, that's correct. Yeah, yeah, so the data, they were drawing on data, related to the new vacancy tax that's in place, so looking for long-term vacancies, and we found that there are very few long-term vacancies in Berkeley. I think that there's this perception

400
01:04:46.090 --> 01:04:54.599
Boardroom: Because when people see, particularly on the new buildings that are big buildings, they seeâ€¦ there's always that for rent sign up.

401
01:04:54.670 --> 01:05:12.000
Boardroom: Right? But that, I think, in part, reflects housing mobility. So if there'sâ€¦ if there are, 87 units in a project, there are gonna be at least one or two that are vacant at any given time. Andâ€¦

402
01:05:12.220 --> 01:05:19.689
Boardroom: But just because there's, that vacant for rent sign always stays up doesn't mean that there's a high number of vacancies.

403
01:05:19.820 --> 01:05:31.860
Boardroom: No, I appreciate that, and it's also important, is it not, thatâ€¦ that there is some level of vacancy to allow for mobility, for people to move up from a cheaper apartment to a more expensive apartment, orâ€¦

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404
01:05:32.030 --> 01:05:46.059
Boardroom: And we're only talking about rental, obviously. That's correct. I mean, some economists, housing economists, consider a 4-6% vacancy rate to be healthy. Okay. Yeah. Thank you.

405
01:05:47.770 --> 01:05:51.150
Boardroom: Let me ask a couple more questions.

406
01:05:53.800 --> 01:06:09.770
Boardroom: I guess one question that came up repeatedly is, how do you address the concern over the loss of parking in some of these new developments? And can you speak to the state law that now prohibits cities from establishing minimum parking requirements?

407
01:06:10.690 --> 01:06:12.110
Boardroom: The forecasted.

408
01:06:12.910 --> 01:06:15.179
Boardroom: So the City of Berkeley,

409
01:06:15.310 --> 01:06:19.079
Boardroom: Has already adopted, policies that,

410
01:06:19.760 --> 01:06:33.740
Boardroom: the minimum off-street parking requirement for residential projects, and in some areas has instituted parking maximums for certain, residential projects. State law has also,

411
01:06:34.540 --> 01:06:51.439
Boardroom: preempted the city from establishing, parking minimums along most, commercial corridors in Berkeley, because we're fortunate enough to have, frequent transit service, and so in areas with frequent transit service, the state,

412
01:06:51.680 --> 01:06:54.720
Boardroom: Preamps our ability to require off-street parking minimums.

413
01:06:56.550 --> 01:07:01.569
Boardroom: Yeah, thank you. I appreciate that. And then, now some of my questions.

414

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01:07:01.870 --> 01:07:15.210
Boardroom: You know, and these are just some things that I want all of us to keep in mind, because this is a process, but it's a process over which we haveâ€¦ we don't have perfect control.

415
01:07:15.440 --> 01:07:23.899
Boardroom: Development standards that we might put in place, with, the inclusion of affordable housing and density bonuses.

416
01:07:23.960 --> 01:07:37.380
Boardroom: They can be waived, right? Often. Is that correct? That's correct. The projects that qualify for the state density bonus can use waivers and concessions, too. Concessions. And can you talk just a little bit more about waivers and concessions?

417
01:07:37.380 --> 01:07:51.369
Boardroom: Sure. You know, just in general terms, I realize it's complicated. So, yeah, waivers are generally waivers of development standards that would preclude the project for existing physicallyâ€¦ from existing physically, soâ€¦

418
01:07:51.390 --> 01:07:59.620
Boardroom: That could include height, setbacks, other physicalâ€¦ requirements. Concessionsâ€¦

419
01:07:59.800 --> 01:08:03.670
Boardroom: Areâ€¦ if the, the developer,

420
01:08:04.040 --> 01:08:19.709
Boardroom: asserts that a regulation would render a project economically infeasible, then they could avoid compliance with, other regulations aside from

421
01:08:19.779 --> 01:08:27.020
Boardroom: physical developments. Right. So, historically, concessions were used

422
01:08:27.510 --> 01:08:32.080
Boardroom: Often to avoid compliance with parking minimums.

423
01:08:32.590 --> 01:08:35.679
Boardroom: Okay, we no longer have parking minimums, they're precluded.

424

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01:08:36.330 --> 01:08:38.210
Boardroom: Prohibited by state law.

425
01:08:38.350 --> 01:08:52.390
Boardroom: So it, it varies. We, we see, recently, more recently, we've seen developers use concessions to avoid compliance with our public art and private development requirement.

426
01:08:52.870 --> 01:08:59.830
Boardroom: Okay. Thank you. And, and something that, that I think Councilmember Trigoub

427
01:09:00.020 --> 01:09:15.089
Boardroom: touched upon, which is commercial rent control. So, a program, if we had sought to institute a program that required a right of return at the same rent that the tenant experienced prior to being displaced temporarily.

428
01:09:16.100 --> 01:09:26.029
Boardroom: That's not permissible, is that correct, under state law? We can't have commercial rent control, is that correct? Maybe I should be directing this to the city attorney.

429
01:09:27.779 --> 01:09:41.490
Boardroom: That is my understanding as well. Okay. And in fact, I think it had to do with an attempt in the 80s by Berkeley to pass commercial rent control, and the state came in andâ€¦

430
01:09:41.810 --> 01:09:43.729
Boardroom: stomped on us.

431
01:09:44.470 --> 01:09:53.020
Boardroom: And here's another issue, and, you know, I'm thinking particularly of the Elmwood, and I know also on Solano. There areâ€¦

432
01:09:53.220 --> 01:09:56.190
Boardroom: Very small merchants.

433
01:09:56.550 --> 01:10:03.159
Boardroom: That have, you know, that may not be terribly profitable, you know, they're somewhat, you know, economically strapped.

434
01:10:03.490 --> 01:10:07.670

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Boardroom: And is there some way, and to the extent that they

435
01:10:08.180 --> 01:10:11.110
Boardroom: Are displaced, or their business is interrupted.

436
01:10:11.140 --> 01:10:30.620
Boardroom: there's a high chance that that would be mortal for them. That would be the end of their business. Is there something we can do to really focus on protecting those, sort of, super vulnerable tenants? I'm thinking about that. There are all these beautiful little shops in the Elmwood, and, you know, Iâ€¦

437
01:10:30.750 --> 01:10:34.909
Boardroom: Knock on wood, they're rocking along, but I don't think they're making millions.

438
01:10:35.910 --> 01:10:42.639
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember. I mean, this gets to the work that we've asked Strategic Economics to complete.

439
01:10:42.960 --> 01:10:51.799
Boardroom: and that we're talking to our Office of Economic Development about to thinkâ€¦ to try to answer that question as best we can. Okay. Thank you, that'sâ€¦ that's all I have.

440
01:10:53.190 --> 01:10:55.899
Boardroom: Thank you, folks, please.

441
01:10:56.040 --> 01:10:58.290
Boardroom: If you guys keep learning, we're not gonna

442
01:11:02.170 --> 01:11:05.399
Boardroom: Thank you. Peter. Thank you, Peter.

443
01:11:06.320 --> 01:11:23.780
Boardroom: Sorry, so anyway, we are going on to Councilmember Barlett. Thank you so much. I appreciate you and your flexibility. Of course, thank you. Thanks so much, Madam Mayor. And thank you, the wonderful team, for your work, again, as usual. It's nice to be not in the hot seat this time.

444
01:11:23.820 --> 01:11:37.189

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Boardroom: It's been on Adeline a lot of times. So that being said, forgive me, Councilmember Humber Humbert, I'm gonna talk about your district a little bit. Which we share, basically, you know.

445
01:11:38.060 --> 01:11:53.899
Boardroom: So, you know, I'm thinking about, Oakland just recently, upzoned College Avenue in the Rockridge area, right? I'm curious, were there any, I guess, any adverse effects from that so far?

446
01:11:56.040 --> 01:11:57.540
Boardroom: So,

447
01:11:57.960 --> 01:12:11.480
Boardroom: So, I believe, that College Avenue in Oakland had, since the mid-70s, been zoned forâ€¦ at 35 feet height, which isâ€¦

448
01:12:12.270 --> 01:12:22.220
Boardroom: higher than Elmwood, College Avenue and the Elmwood currently. That's roughly what we're proposing under Alt 1. Okay. Right? And,

449
01:12:22.650 --> 01:12:28.350
Boardroom: Yeah, I think it was November of 2023 that, that that wasâ€¦

450
01:12:28.460 --> 01:12:31.800
Boardroom: Changed from 35 feet to 55 feet.

451
01:12:32.150 --> 01:12:36.650
Boardroom: Which is higher than what we're proposing, for the Elmwood.

452
01:12:37.000 --> 01:12:46.050
Boardroom: My understanding, and we've recently been in touch with the City of Oakland staff about this, is that there haven't yet been any projects proposed.

453
01:12:48.430 --> 01:12:55.250
Boardroom: Admittedly, it's a down cycle right now, and so that could change, but I do think it kind ofâ€¦

454
01:12:55.360 --> 01:13:08.169
Boardroom: goes to the point that change doesn't happen overnight, it happens over decades. Okay. And can you putâ€¦ can we put on the screen theâ€¦ the streets, the three-quarter salon on North Shattuck in College, so we can see?

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455
01:13:08.390 --> 01:13:22.389
Boardroom: Causeâ€¦ It'll highlightâ€¦ theâ€¦ The map one. There we go. I think the number 9, possibly. The colâ€¦

456
01:13:22.950 --> 01:13:29.380
Boardroom: The College Avenue section to be upzoned appears to beâ€¦

457
01:13:29.910 --> 01:13:34.669
Boardroom: pretty small, right? Theseâ€¦ are these just a couple of blocks?

458
01:13:34.910 --> 01:13:40.440
Boardroom: That's right. Yeah? And so, I'm curious, though, why so small?

459
01:13:42.090 --> 01:13:46.230
Boardroom: Well, we've been focusing on the CE zoning.

460
01:13:47.020 --> 01:13:56.289
Boardroom: the, you know, the north and south of College Avenue are zoned R2A, which was just recently upzoned, just went into effect.

461
01:13:57.250 --> 01:14:04.380
Boardroom: On Saturday. So, we're just following the contours of the existing zoning district.

462
01:14:05.330 --> 01:14:14.609
Boardroom: Okay, and is it true thatâ€¦ well, I guess when Solano, North Shattuck, and College, do you have a rough estimate of number of units anticipated?

463
01:14:15.470 --> 01:14:16.339
Boardroom: We'll get to that.

464
01:14:17.150 --> 01:14:26.220
Boardroom: Yes, can you repeat your question? Are you asking for each quarter? Yeah, this is how many apartments doâ€¦ that we're projecting on each one?

465
01:14:26.450 --> 01:14:30.470
Boardroom: Yeah, so, I willâ€¦

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466
01:14:30.600 --> 01:14:35.040
Boardroom: I will give the number forâ€¦ First.

467
01:14:35.520 --> 01:14:43.890
Boardroom: Alt 1, and then Alt 2 for each, each one. So, for Solano, under Alt 1, you know.

468
01:14:44.460 --> 01:14:51.439
Boardroom: Our estimate is, you know, if everythingâ€¦ if a lot of the things go maybe 400 to 550 units.

469
01:14:51.570 --> 01:15:03.429
Boardroom: And then in Alt 2, it goes up to 450 to about 650 units. On North Shattuck, our estimate is, for Alt 1, about 650 to 850 units.

470
01:15:03.460 --> 01:15:12.480
Boardroom: And, about 750 to 1,000 under Alt 2. And then for College Avenue, under Alt 1,

471
01:15:13.030 --> 01:15:14.940
Boardroom: You know, we would expect,

472
01:15:15.080 --> 01:15:18.110
Boardroom: Maybe 50 to 80 units total.

473
01:15:18.500 --> 01:15:22.499
Boardroom: And then under Alt 2, maybe 80 to 130 units.

474
01:15:23.330 --> 01:15:24.250
Boardroom: Okay.

475
01:15:24.980 --> 01:15:32.960
Boardroom: Pretty, pretty big discrepancy. It's a small area, and the sites are very, very tough for redevelopment, for sure.

476
01:15:34.640 --> 01:15:36.959
Boardroom: Okay, and in terms of,

477
01:15:38.120 --> 01:15:49.860

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Boardroom: you know, the North Shattuck area, I reallyâ€¦ I see it, it reminds me of the Adeline District a bit. It's, neighbors aren't so impacted by it, it's a larger, larger footprint. I'm wondering,

478
01:15:49.920 --> 01:16:04.350
Boardroom: And this goes back to the equity argument, just to keep in mind and think about this. In the last 50 years or so, how manyâ€¦ if you know, how many low-income units have been built in, each of the three corridors?

479
01:16:06.270 --> 01:16:09.659
Boardroom: If you don't know, you can get back to me later, or you can guesstimate.

480
01:16:09.800 --> 01:16:18.560
Boardroom: Yeah. There hasn't been a project on college hasn'tâ€¦ Right. So there hasn't been a project on college.

481
01:16:19.190 --> 01:16:23.990
Boardroom: In 50 years. On Solano.

482
01:16:24.420 --> 01:16:30.459
Boardroom: Yeah, it's certainly not in theâ€¦ I mean, we showed you the map of the lastâ€¦

483
01:16:30.860 --> 01:16:34.560
Boardroom: 20â€¦ 10 or 15 years, but,

484
01:16:35.310 --> 01:16:37.720
Boardroom: Gosh, I can't think of a project on Solano.

485
01:16:37.900 --> 01:16:45.050
Boardroom: prior to that. So, on North Chattuck, we have two projects in process now.

486
01:16:45.260 --> 01:16:51.230
Boardroom: And I should say, we have one project in process for college with fourâ€¦ 4 units?

487
01:16:51.710 --> 01:16:54.550
Boardroom: Yeah, 6, apparently.

488

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01:16:55.930 --> 01:17:04.320
Boardroom: So, yeah, not many. And you asked the number of low-income units. I would expect that theâ€¦

489
01:17:04.950 --> 01:17:10.730
Boardroom: I, I believe the, the two, no shattuck projects are both density bonus projects.

490
01:17:11.750 --> 01:17:28.639
Boardroom: Yeah, and so each of them will have a handful of, of, you know, they're not huge projects, but I imagine there's probably about, between 10 and 20 total low-income units that are coming to North Shattuck. But I think the answer's probably zero.

491
01:17:29.000 --> 01:17:45.029
Boardroom: Okay, let's, write that down. And last question, and this is, also very important, the, the retail aspect, right? So much of our efforts here are imagining ways to keep our local economy vibrant, people walking into stores.

492
01:17:45.030 --> 01:17:56.470
Boardroom: Frank services. I know that college, I believe, has a retail formula. I wonder if it still does. It's gone. It's gone. Are there any retail formulas in any of the corridors at this point? No?

493
01:17:56.520 --> 01:18:00.010
Boardroom: No, there wasâ€¦ there wereâ€¦ theyâ€¦ they were graduallyâ€¦

494
01:18:00.380 --> 01:18:09.690
Boardroom: and kind of, college was the last holdout, but then it, it was, it was eliminated within the last 5 or 10 years. Okay, and, and is itâ€¦

495
01:18:10.130 --> 01:18:14.690
Boardroom: And my understanding is, something I'm wrong, probably city attorney here,

496
01:18:15.530 --> 01:18:18.940
Boardroom: If there's any discretionary review that's granted.

497
01:18:19.440 --> 01:18:26.289
Boardroom: To a developer, then we can contract with them around the retail,

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498
01:18:26.510 --> 01:18:38.259
Boardroom: retail setup thatâ€¦ thatâ€¦ that they have to come back to. Like, if we letâ€¦ if we use our discretion to grant them something, we can negotiate, some sort of a retail lease agreement, right?

499
01:18:39.030 --> 01:18:43.080
Boardroom: I feel like we've done this. I would need to look into it,

500
01:18:43.660 --> 01:18:49.010
Boardroom: In more detail, but what comes to mind is through a development agreement, if that is aâ€¦

501
01:18:49.160 --> 01:18:54.869
Boardroom: That's a vehicle that could be used to accomplish what you're describing.

502
01:18:55.160 --> 01:18:56.730
Boardroom: Okay.

503
01:18:56.980 --> 01:19:01.859
Boardroom: I'll add to that, like, if any project was more, or

504
01:19:02.550 --> 01:19:11.110
Boardroom: More than two-thirds residential, which just about any mixed-use project would be, then there is no discretionary review.

505
01:19:11.280 --> 01:19:12.000
Boardroom: Okay.

506
01:19:12.520 --> 01:19:13.930
Boardroom: Alright, that's it, thank you.

507
01:19:14.140 --> 01:19:21.220
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Okay, so just soâ€¦ it's 723, I'm just doing a time check for us. So, I've got,

508
01:19:22.080 --> 01:19:39.690
Boardroom: 1, 2, 3, 3 more council members, and then myself for questions. I would like to get through our questions if we can, and then what I really want to do, because I see there are some families with young children here, I'd like to take their questions and then take our break.

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509
01:19:39.690 --> 01:19:48.479
Boardroom: And then we'll hear the rest of the public comment. But just because it is getting a little bit later. So we are gonna move on to Councilmember Blackaby.

510
01:19:48.530 --> 01:19:49.890
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor.

511
01:19:49.970 --> 01:19:57.469
Boardroom: I just want to thank Jordan, Justin, Uthra, and Chris for being here, for all your work, and for bringing this to us tonight. Thank you.

512
01:19:58.850 --> 01:20:06.400
Boardroom: You know, we've heard a lot of discussion about small business. I will say that, as a council member, protecting small business, enhancing it.

513
01:20:06.400 --> 01:20:22.859
Boardroom: growing our local economy, it'sâ€¦ all theseâ€¦ these areâ€¦ it's one of my top priorities. I mean, maybe other than public safety and wildfire safety, which obviously have been big issues in D6, thinking about the future of our city, economic development in our city, is hugely important to me. So I take these concerns really seriously.

514
01:20:22.860 --> 01:20:30.109
Boardroom: You know, we need new housing, but we also need local jobs and economic development, and we need to make sure we maintain that balance.

515
01:20:30.130 --> 01:20:48.200
Boardroom: So I just want to thank you for what I think, you know, up till this point, has been a very careful, balanced approach. You're trying to weigh those interests, and they're not necessarily competing interests, but they are standalone interests that we need to sort of manage, appropriately. So, you know, one question for you is, how do we make sure, as we continue this process.

516
01:20:48.250 --> 01:20:54.560
Boardroom: That we continue to achieve that balance all the way through to the end. That we make sure that we'reâ€¦ that we're trying to do both.

517
01:20:54.790 --> 01:21:00.049

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Boardroom: Do you have any thoughts about how, you know, how can we do that in the process, and how can we make sure that whatever we end up with

518
01:21:00.200 --> 01:21:02.210
Boardroom: Really reflects both those priorities.

519
01:21:03.950 --> 01:21:22.750
Boardroom: I can address it from the development standard, standpoint. I think where it is decided that we really want to concentrate retail, we want to really create development standards that ensures a largely continuous retail frontage.

520
01:21:22.850 --> 01:21:26.499
Boardroom: Andâ€¦ and also to provide, you know.

521
01:21:26.920 --> 01:21:41.719
Boardroom: A higher density of businesses per block, that adds vibrancy. But, you know, there is obviously a concern that, you know, as things become mixed use, there's things as lobby and other fire exits and needs.

522
01:21:41.720 --> 01:21:47.690
Boardroom: So, we'll be working on developing objective development standards that really try to

523
01:21:47.710 --> 01:21:53.849
Boardroom: maximize, active storefronts in the right locations. Great. Thank you.

524
01:21:55.450 --> 01:22:06.540
Boardroom: Councilmember Bartlett mentioned the Rockridge example. I'm really interested, I know we've talked about this a little bit in the past, but I'm interested in finding other case studies of places where we think this has been done well.

525
01:22:06.540 --> 01:22:16.570
Boardroom: There may be other case studies where we think this has not been done well, so that we can sort of learn from that, and I wonder if you could suggest any of those here. I mean.

526
01:22:16.570 --> 01:22:17.350
Boardroom: We're notâ€¦

527

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01:22:17.350 --> 01:22:27.709
Boardroom: you know, we are pioneering some of these things for Berkeley, but we're also following other examples, and can we look to some of those for some learnings, and have you thought about that? How is that going to play into this process?

528
01:22:30.760 --> 01:22:35.930
Boardroom: Chris, do you have examples of other communities you work in with, so, for WDS.

529
01:22:38.120 --> 01:22:39.800
Boardroom: I meanâ€¦

530
01:22:40.020 --> 01:22:47.739
Boardroom: I mean, San Francisco, I think, in a way, has been a pioneer in this, and they've,

531
01:22:47.740 --> 01:23:06.240
Boardroom: you know, they've worked through their mixed-use zoning to make sure to get the appropriate size spaces, high floor-to-floor on the ground floor. You know, they've also, you know, they've had a priority to restrict, chain development in different areas. So, I thinkâ€¦

532
01:23:06.260 --> 01:23:23.240
Boardroom: you know, they're an example, as you, you know, you look at places like the Excelsior or some of the outer neighborhoods, that they've been able to bring in new development and kind of add to the vibrancy of these communities.

533
01:23:23.480 --> 01:23:25.240
Boardroom: That isâ€¦

534
01:23:25.430 --> 01:23:35.329
Boardroom: one I'm thinking ofâ€¦ Yeah, I mean, related to that, they're actuallyâ€¦ they currently are grappling with a lot of the same issues we are right now on a rezoning project,

535
01:23:35.330 --> 01:23:58.909
Boardroom: they'reâ€¦ they're obligated under their housing element to, to adopt a rezoning project by January 31st, so they're ahead of us. Weâ€¦ and they're looking at these small business protection issues specifically, so I think we'll have the benefit of being able to see what ultimately gets adopted in the city of San Francisco. Great. I just encourage, keep these front and center, at least if we've got other examples we can look to. And then also.

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536
01:23:58.910 --> 01:24:08.429
Boardroom: lift up, kind of, where we're trying to go. The vision of where we're trying to go, and maybe other people that have gotten to that place, so we have those other positive examples that people can respond to and say, this isâ€¦

537
01:24:08.450 --> 01:24:20.490
Boardroom: This is what we're trying to do. So anyway, I find that helpful. So it's out of the language of just zoning standards and also to, you know, real pictures and real examples of people who've done this well.

538
01:24:20.490 --> 01:24:31.800
Boardroom: One thing we haven't talked about as much tonight, and I saw it in the previous presentations, if you look at the rezoning plans, you look at the whole corridor, and as you draw it on the map, it looks like the whole thing is orange, or the whole thing is yellow.

539
01:24:31.800 --> 01:24:49.960
Boardroom: And I know in previous conversations, you've said, you know, realistically, there's actually a small percentage of those areas that are really likely hospitable to development. It's a handful of parcels in each case. Could you share a little bit more of that with us, and why you think that's the case? I know you alluded to it earlier, but why do you think it's the case that

540
01:24:49.960 --> 01:24:55.420
Boardroom: We're not talking about a massive redesign of these areas, but sort of, you know, in spots.

541
01:24:56.350 --> 01:25:00.969
Boardroom: Yeah, I mean, there's a lot of different factors that go into,

542
01:25:01.110 --> 01:25:10.019
Boardroom: You know, whether a property owner decides to redevelop, and the opportunity costs toâ€¦ To add units, and,

543
01:25:10.550 --> 01:25:13.399
Boardroom: Our team with Strategic Economics.

544
01:25:13.500 --> 01:25:25.569

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Boardroom: Like, one thing we realized really early on is, you know, development in these areas is difficult. You have small parcels, you have a lot of different,

545
01:25:25.850 --> 01:25:40.350
Boardroom: ownerships, like, almost, you know, almost every different building along a lot of these corridors is a different owner. And there'sâ€¦ there's an economy of scale, when you're looking at redevelopment.

546
01:25:40.350 --> 01:25:53.909
Boardroom: And you pretty much need to get close to that, like, 10,000 square foot site. Now, I admit, in Berkeley, especially on the south side, you're getting smaller parcels where you're looking at

547
01:25:53.910 --> 01:26:02.420
Boardroom: dense student housing, but typically what we see is you need that larger site, and there aren't that many of them. And thenâ€¦

548
01:26:02.420 --> 01:26:14.719
Boardroom: you know, as Jordan alluded to earlier, there are a lot of businesses that are making money and paying good rent, and so the opportunity costs to redevelop that, lose that rent.

549
01:26:14.780 --> 01:26:16.270
Boardroom: And then lookâ€¦

550
01:26:16.450 --> 01:26:35.740
Boardroom: longer term over, making money on a residential project isâ€¦ is difficult. So, in the alternatives report, we have a more detailed analysis of, you know, how many, like, what percentage of units that

551
01:26:36.120 --> 01:26:38.409
Boardroom: Or what percentage of parcels

552
01:26:38.920 --> 01:26:57.059
Boardroom: that we think might redevelop, but I think over all three quarters, it was, like, something like 42%, and then, like, you know, it was a very small percentage along College, and more on, North Shattuck and Solana, where you do get some bigger parcels that areâ€¦

553
01:26:57.150 --> 01:27:13.879
Boardroom: You know, there are things like BanksOn, which, you know, we know we seeâ€¦ we've seen a lot of change in the banking industry,

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lately. So, you know, those are sites that weâ€¦ the types of sites that we identified as more likely.

554
01:27:15.080 --> 01:27:34.380
Boardroom: One of the concerns I know, particularly when we talk about people and the shop owners and people who are concerned about small business, is what happens if we redevelop, areas, and now that land is more valuable, and because land is more valuable, rents go up? Like, that's kind of the, that's one of the economic arguments.

555
01:27:34.490 --> 01:27:37.860
Boardroom: The part we haven't talked about quite as much is

556
01:27:38.490 --> 01:27:51.889
Boardroom: land values go up, rents go up, may go up, over time at some point, right? But if we also build more housing, and we spendâ€¦ we send several hundred more people or families into these neighborhoods, and they're living in places where they can then shop and frequent these stores.

557
01:27:51.890 --> 01:28:00.439
Boardroom: There's also some economic benefit to the existing businesses, right, that has more walk-up traffic. They have more people that are consuming the products.

558
01:28:00.660 --> 01:28:09.469
Boardroom: will you be able to model that? Like, help us think aboutâ€¦ because there's sort of two different factors going on. There's sort of aâ€¦ the cost of land, cost of rent may go up.

559
01:28:09.470 --> 01:28:23.709
Boardroom: But then, over time, you may have more businesses, more customers, more walk-up traffic. How do those factors play out? Will you be able to model that in this economic process? I mean, that is very difficult to model, and I would say it'sâ€¦

560
01:28:23.710 --> 01:28:29.140
Boardroom: Probably even more difficult in these three quarters to model that,

561
01:28:29.340 --> 01:28:36.619
Boardroom: Like, effectively, because each of these corridors, they not only draw from the people that live

562

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01:28:36.830 --> 01:28:48.979
Boardroom: like, near them. But they'reâ€¦ all three of them are at least city draws, if not regional draws. So, you know, it's really hard toâ€¦

563
01:28:49.160 --> 01:28:57.390
Boardroom: to model, like, the exact effect that that will have. Now, more customers definitely can support more businesses.

564
01:28:58.800 --> 01:29:11.960
Boardroom: So, you know, from that aspect, we do think that, you know, bringing more customers to each of these areas will support. You know, in each of the quarters, you know, we've seen businesses

565
01:29:12.270 --> 01:29:31.929
Boardroom: go out of business nicely. Books Inc, for example, that's in my neighborhood. Like, you know, that's, was a cherished part of the neighborhood. And, you know, there's, you know, the retail industry is changing a lot, and so more people generally does mean more demand for services.

566
01:29:32.470 --> 01:29:40.629
Boardroom: Last chunk of questions. We've talked a lot about the housing, how much, how big, how dense.

567
01:29:40.760 --> 01:29:55.170
Boardroom: We've talked about the impact on small businesses, but what I really like, and I know we're talking about the San Pablo plan later, but there's a huge part of the San Pablo plan that's also talking about these public realm policies. You know, like, how do we activate these public spaces? How do we make them

568
01:29:55.170 --> 01:30:05.449
Boardroom: more engaging? How do we make them places that are gonna draw more people from the neighborhood and from across the city to, like, spend time in those places? Each of these three neighborhoods, these quarters that we're talking about.

569
01:30:05.470 --> 01:30:08.449
Boardroom: Already do that and have the potential to do much more of that.

570
01:30:08.450 --> 01:30:27.629
Boardroom: So my question for you is, how do we make sure in this process, we're also thinking about the street-level activation, you know, creating more parklets, creating more places for people to spend time,

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for families to come, make them places that are desirable, and even more desirable when there are more people who are there, that make it even more desirable for businesses to be than they are now.

571
01:30:27.630 --> 01:30:34.680
Boardroom: How do we bake that into this process? Because Iâ€¦ it feels like we haveâ€¦ we canâ€¦ there's a lot more on that that is not just about

572
01:30:34.680 --> 01:30:41.550
Boardroom: How do we zone, and what's happening to businesses, but activating these spaces in a much more creative way. There's a 25 to 50

573
01:30:41.740 --> 01:30:43.120
Boardroom: your opportunity.

574
01:30:43.590 --> 01:31:02.030
Boardroom: Yes, I think that's a really great question, and while this project is really focused on public property, right, that is the scope of this work, as we start to look at objective design standards, and I think the Planning Commission gave very good and clear direction.

575
01:31:02.080 --> 01:31:15.420
Boardroom: that we can look at how do you provide that flexibility, but also the standards to ensure an active ground floor, and one that's appropriate to the corridor. So, for instance, if we allow ground floor residential.

576
01:31:15.670 --> 01:31:32.900
Boardroom: How do we think about a building setback that allows that privacy for a potential ground floor unit, or if it's a live-work unit that is flexible to turn to retail? Like, how do you provide that space that you're creating a positive and,

577
01:31:32.900 --> 01:31:41.709
Boardroom: and pleasant environment. And then in the commercial areas, how do you think about, well, like, one, we have to balance that

578
01:31:41.840 --> 01:31:55.530
Boardroom: A lot of these projects will be small infill, where other projects are right up to the property line in the backup walk, but how do you provide that flexibility, or maybe even provide standards for larger projects

579

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01:31:55.550 --> 01:31:57.929
Boardroom: To require,

580
01:31:57.930 --> 01:32:18.420
Boardroom: a ground floor setback that allows more space for outdoor dining, landscape, and other amenities. So those are all, objective design standards that we look forward to digging into in the next phase. Great, my time's up, and I just hope we can continue to center that, because that's really important to me in this process as well. Thank you. Thank you so much. Councilmember Lunapara?

581
01:32:18.420 --> 01:32:31.010
Boardroom: Thank you so much. I first wanted to say thank you for your work in trying to get, outreach to students for the survey. Our office is also always happy to help, if that'sâ€¦

582
01:32:31.090 --> 01:32:34.840
Boardroom: helpful. Iâ€¦ Iâ€¦ it's really important that weâ€¦

583
01:32:35.020 --> 01:32:43.940
Boardroom: do this outreach, because students are an integral and permanent part of our city and our neighborhood. I also wanted to say that

584
01:32:44.090 --> 01:32:58.140
Boardroom: for the record, I think TikTok is actually not the best way to reach people in a small geographic area. But I amâ€¦ Iâ€¦ we are happy to help. My first question is if you,

585
01:32:58.630 --> 01:33:07.489
Boardroom: In your experience, what is the most efficient way that a city in California can increase its total deed-restricted-restricted affordable units?

586
01:33:11.510 --> 01:33:22.469
Boardroom: Gosh, you know, in Berkeley, we've had the luxury of, of, Measure O,

587
01:33:22.700 --> 01:33:30.460
Boardroom: That's produced a huge amount of units. That's been the most effective way to produce units in Berkeley over the last decade, for sure.

588
01:33:30.650 --> 01:33:38.249

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Boardroom: I really think it'sâ€¦ I think that cities are in a place right now, particularly with the state and federal budget.

589
01:33:38.670 --> 01:33:49.670
Boardroom: you know, and policy direction the way it is. Where municipalities, it's like an all-hands-on-deck approach. Like, every strategy we can use, we need to use.

590
01:33:49.810 --> 01:34:00.179
Boardroom: Andâ€¦ I mean, historically, inclusionary has been an important part of that strategy for us, right? When we see

591
01:34:00.600 --> 01:34:10.440
Boardroom: when we see market rate development, we getâ€¦ we either get on-site units, or we get a payment to our housing trust fund, which we can leverage for other outside funding. So, that'sâ€¦ that'sâ€¦

592
01:34:10.870 --> 01:34:27.220
Boardroom: That's the strategy, I would say, the most cost-effective strategy for the City of Berkeley, right? Where our voters or, you know, our property owners and residents don't have to make upfront payment in order to get the units.

593
01:34:28.670 --> 01:34:30.400
Boardroom: Thank you.

594
01:34:30.830 --> 01:34:38.400
Boardroom: this kind of ties into a similar question, but I'm curious how our requirements to meet our RENA numbers, affect

595
01:34:38.400 --> 01:34:55.239
Boardroom: this process, or how that fits into the whole thing? Yeah, you know, Justinâ€¦ Justin's answer earlier about, like, why we're doing this project, and it's, like, and you heard Chris go through the numbers of the units. It's notâ€¦ we're not talking about huge numbers here, right? I will say, everyâ€¦

596
01:34:55.530 --> 01:35:14.859
Boardroom: everything counts. Right now, we, you know, 8934? Is thatâ€¦ is that for the, for the sixth cycle? And I think that we permitted about, about 1,200 units over the first quarter, the first two years, so we're not on track.

597
01:35:14.860 --> 01:35:38.180

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Boardroom: Right? And ultimately, the, you know, the consequence of not hitting our RENA numbers means that we could have less discretion over future housing and permitting, right? And so, so we're mandated to do what we can to hit that, and this is, even though we're not talking about huge numbers here, this is definitely part of it.

598
01:35:38.180 --> 01:35:42.309
Boardroom: That's why it's a program of the housing element, so I do think it matters.

599
01:35:43.550 --> 01:35:45.470
Boardroom: Thank you.

600
01:35:45.850 --> 01:36:03.800
Boardroom: This is a kind of separate question, but I'm curious about what you think about the idea of also rezoning the directly adjacent blocks around the commercial nodes to encourage kind of slowly stepping back into the neighborhood. We've heard that from a couple groups, and I just want to ask to hear your opinion on it.

601
01:36:05.570 --> 01:36:15.930
Boardroom: Yeah, that hasn't been part of the scope of this project, but it's certainly something that we can look at. I mean, the challenge for,

602
01:36:16.560 --> 01:36:26.560
Boardroom: the way our zoning is set up now is that, you know, commercial uses, many commercial uses are allowed by right on the ground floor, right?

603
01:36:26.600 --> 01:36:41.630
Boardroom: And so, if we're gonna extend that commercial zoning into the residential districts, it could introduce some areas where, you know, might be perceived as conflict, where there's kind of noise or

604
01:36:41.860 --> 01:36:57.590
Boardroom: are other impacts that are generated by customer visits, so another way we could look at it would be potentially, like, further up-zoning the residential uses along the edges of the commercial districts. So that's not part of the scope of this project, but something we might consider in the future.

605
01:36:59.170 --> 01:37:08.459
Boardroom: That makes sense. They asked me to say also middle housing, which, yeah, right, which is certainly relevant here, which just went into effect, yeah. Great, thank you.

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606
01:37:09.080 --> 01:37:19.279
Boardroom: And the final question isâ€¦ is, kind ofâ€¦ it's been touched on already, and it's kind of a direct response to some of the feedback that we've been hearing aroundâ€¦

607
01:37:20.140 --> 01:37:23.749
Boardroom: The idea that upzoning can,

608
01:37:24.360 --> 01:37:32.090
Boardroom: kind of, like, destroy a neighborhood that is currently beautiful, because these neighborhoods are beautiful. Andâ€¦

609
01:37:32.340 --> 01:37:37.229
Boardroom: We've, as we've seen Rockridge, Upzoned in the past couple of years.

610
01:37:37.590 --> 01:37:44.830
Boardroom: I think it's still beautiful. I also think that our neighborhoods that have new housing are also beautiful.

611
01:37:44.980 --> 01:37:56.509
Boardroom: I guess my question is more specific around how you've seen the upzoning affect Rock Ridge, if you want to discuss it a little more. Yeah, you know, I mentioned up front, I feel like

612
01:37:56.740 --> 01:38:06.949
Boardroom: our experience and our observation is that zoning changes neighborhoods gradually over the course of decades.

613
01:38:07.340 --> 01:38:16.270
Boardroom: I would note that often, like, reinvestment in a neighborhood is a positive thing, right? Ifâ€¦

614
01:38:16.380 --> 01:38:33.100
Boardroom: a singleâ€¦ development often happens at underutilized and vacant single-story commercial buildings that feel like blight in a neighborhood, or an eyesore in the neighborhood. And if it's older building stock, rather than

615
01:38:33.380 --> 01:38:45.910

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Boardroom: be re-tenanted or invested in. It's just, it will sit vacant, or if the conditions are right, and if the regulatory conditions allow for it, it can be rezoned, it can be redeveloped into

616
01:38:46.120 --> 01:39:00.370
Boardroom: a building that brings new residents, new spending power in the district, and newâ€¦ brand new commercial space. And so that feels like actually contributing to theâ€¦ to the neighborhood and to the vitality of the district.

617
01:39:01.630 --> 01:39:05.070
Boardroom: Great, thank you so much, and thank you all for your hard work.

618
01:39:05.850 --> 01:39:07.789
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember Kessarwani?

619
01:39:08.130 --> 01:39:19.950
Boardroom: Yes, thank you very much, Madam Mayor. Thank you, Director Klein, and thank you to our team, for your presentation. I, wanted to ask a question about height.

620
01:39:20.090 --> 01:39:26.090
Boardroom: Because I know that, obviously, if there is a state density bonus that's used.

621
01:39:26.730 --> 01:39:30.729
Boardroom: There's aâ€¦ there's a potential to exceed the base zoned height.

622
01:39:30.800 --> 01:39:49.029
Boardroom: I also want to note, in asking this question, that we have seen a number of high-rise proposals that have recently sought or received a land use entitlement in our downtown, over, you know, the last decade, and yet none of those high-rises have been built.

623
01:39:49.030 --> 01:40:08.470
Boardroom: I think because the financing is difficult. Can you talk about the likelihood of development exceeding 8 stories, under Alternative 2? And, when you talk about that, can you explain how building materials and costs change once you exceed 8 stories?

624
01:40:10.020 --> 01:40:17.770

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Boardroom: I can go first, and then Chris can jump in if you like. Yeah, we noted on some of the slides that particularly if, in Alt 2,

625
01:40:18.510 --> 01:40:33.389
Boardroom: if a project did seek a 100% density bonus, then projects could go to 8, 9, 10, 11 stories, in theory. Shh, folks, please. In practice.

626
01:40:33.500 --> 01:40:52.299
Boardroom: it'sâ€¦ as you've noted, it's, it's very difficult for those projects to ever materialize. The cost per square foot of construction goes up dramatically above, and there's a bigâ€¦ there's actually a big cutoff at 85 feet, specifically, because, above that.

627
01:40:52.460 --> 01:41:12.119
Boardroom: height, the building code requires that you switch to steel-framed construction, and it places other requirements related to life safety and fire suppression that dramatically increase the cost per square foot. So, we don't reallyâ€¦ we don't see, really, even in our downtown.

628
01:41:12.720 --> 01:41:32.269
Boardroom: the vast majority of the new projects citywide, even where we allow the highest heights citywide, projects tend to max out at 8 stories. Okay, thank you, and I think we also saw that at the North Berkeley BART station, where the development team could have exceeded 8 stories with

629
01:41:32.310 --> 01:41:45.489
Boardroom: the density bonus, but chose not to, and that is the highest height that we will have at that station. The next question I had, I know Councilmember Bartlett had asked for the expected number of units.

630
01:41:45.490 --> 01:41:54.110
Boardroom: for each corridor, and that's in the report. Can you just explain the methodology around those numbersâ€¦

631
01:41:54.500 --> 01:42:01.650
Boardroom: because I think to Councilmember Blackaby's point, it doesn't assume that every single parcel that's upzoned gets redeveloped, correct?

632
01:42:04.710 --> 01:42:11.560
Boardroom: Yeah, that is correct. Soâ€¦ you know,

633

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01:42:14.950 --> 01:42:24.630
Boardroom: Let's seeâ€¦ In general, we categorized each parcel across, like, 5 different levels, right? Fromâ€¦

634
01:42:24.790 --> 01:42:34.810
Boardroom: Theâ€¦ the most likely, the higher redevelopment, potential, to modest redevelopment potential, to, you know.

635
01:42:34.920 --> 01:42:44.190
Boardroom: historic buildings, you know, probably not gonna go. Like, so we had this 5 levels, and for theâ€¦

636
01:42:44.400 --> 01:42:46.480
Boardroom: The highestâ€¦

637
01:42:46.660 --> 01:43:00.060
Boardroom: redevelopment potential. Now, again, these are the larger sites, you know, like the bank sites, sites that are 9,000 square feet or more, generally, that have that potential.

638
01:43:00.440 --> 01:43:02.990
Boardroom: For a larger project.

639
01:43:03.220 --> 01:43:10.430
Boardroom: We assumed about 50-70% of those would redevelop, and then for the modest.

640
01:43:10.600 --> 01:43:26.269
Boardroom: redevelopment potential, we looked at more to 20 to 40%, and then we also provided, like, a range of densities across that. So, you know, it's aâ€¦ it's a really broad, look, but that'sâ€¦

641
01:43:26.320 --> 01:43:39.190
Boardroom: Of those parcels that we looked at for high redevelopment potential, again, we assumed maybe 50% to 70% would go, and then 20% to 40% for the modest.

642
01:43:39.440 --> 01:43:49.860
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. So, I think that's important, because as Councilmember Blackaby had noted, just because we are considering a rezoning of

643
01:43:50.160 --> 01:44:06.539

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Boardroom: the, you know, sort of the length of the corridors, as shown on this slide, it does not mean that every single parcel will be transformed. And, you know, do you have an expectation over what time period we might, see those,

644
01:44:06.630 --> 01:44:14.400
Boardroom: estimated units get billed. Yeah, I mean, in looking at this, we'reâ€¦ we're looking, kind of.

645
01:44:14.620 --> 01:44:22.589
Boardroom: like, longer term, like, you know, at least 10 years, and it, I mean, it really depends onâ€¦ on market cycle.

646
01:44:22.830 --> 01:44:32.450
Boardroom: Right. Like, there can be times where things are going, and there can also be times like now, where, you know, with construction

647
01:44:32.550 --> 01:44:37.730
Boardroom: Costs andâ€¦ and interest rates, where there can be long.

648
01:44:38.390 --> 01:44:51.959
Boardroom: down periods where no development happens. So, it's largely based on not only the microeconomics here in Berkeley, but also the national picture. Okay, thank you very much.

649
01:44:52.910 --> 01:45:07.250
Boardroom: Thank you. I just have 3 questions. I'm curious, I know there's concern about this density bonus piece. Can you tell us, has there everâ€¦ has the city ever permitted a 100% density bonus project in Berkeley? Not building permits, no.

650
01:45:07.440 --> 01:45:13.649
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. 100%.

651
01:45:15.730 --> 01:45:25.549
Boardroom: Is it 100%? I think so. Okay. Chris is telling me that the project on North Shattuck is a 100%.

652
01:45:25.550 --> 01:45:37.869
Boardroom: intensity bonus, so I stand correct. Okay. Folks, pleaseâ€¦ Okay, soâ€¦ so one is what the answer is. There may be more than one, but yes, like, there areâ€¦ there areâ€¦

653

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01:45:38.080 --> 01:45:52.089
Boardroom: So, there's at least one, and Iâ€¦ I mean, I willâ€¦ I will note that, you know, again, the state density bonus law continues to change, and the 50% and 100% bonuses haveâ€¦

654
01:45:52.240 --> 01:46:07.089
Boardroom: come in pretty recently, I think, asâ€¦ asâ€¦ 2024. Yeah, 2023, 2024 is when, the state density bonus law changed quite a bit to allow higher density bonuses.

655
01:46:07.610 --> 01:46:17.770
Boardroom: Thank you. And can you explain the pros and cons, and maybe the process briefly, of doing a zoning overlay for specific opportunity sites?

656
01:46:20.610 --> 01:46:26.240
Boardroom: it versus reason. Versus upzoning a corridor in its entirety.

657
01:46:27.510 --> 01:46:31.389
Boardroom: I mean, I think itâ€¦ I think it's hard to,

658
01:46:33.770 --> 01:46:47.100
Boardroom: I think it's hard for a city to decide what parcels they think are right for redevelopment, and, you know.

659
01:46:47.180 --> 01:46:54.370
Boardroom: Not give the property owner next to them the same opportunity as a site that you deem

660
01:46:54.560 --> 01:47:02.360
Boardroom: like, more likely toâ€¦ to redevelop, or that you want to redevelop. You know, we call that kind of spot zoning.

661
01:47:02.560 --> 01:47:11.139
Boardroom: And so, like, there's definitely an equity, an equitable piece to it, to the property next to them.

662
01:47:12.030 --> 01:47:19.339
Boardroom: Yeah, yeah. Another way to put that is, like, how do weâ€¦ how do we define the criteria for which sites get upzoned and which sites don't?

663
01:47:19.530 --> 01:47:27.149

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Boardroom: And the other thing I would note is that's not how we'veâ€¦ pursued zoning amendments in Berkeley.

664
01:47:27.340 --> 01:47:31.140
Boardroom: just not how we pursued the Adeline Corridor Plan.

665
01:47:31.550 --> 01:47:33.880
Boardroom: It's not what's proposed for San Pablo Avenue.

666
01:47:34.620 --> 01:47:46.120
Boardroom: Thank you. And, regarding the definition of ground floor retail, I know this has been touched on, but I just want to confirm, would that also include customer focuses like medical services, art studios, things like that?

667
01:47:46.490 --> 01:47:56.730
Boardroom: Yes, generally. When we say retail, we're using that as a proxy for, a broad set of personal services as well, food and beverage services, and

668
01:47:56.730 --> 01:48:06.670
Boardroom: And actually, it is part of the scope of this project to consider the levels, the permitting levels required for those types of uses along each of these corridors.

669
01:48:06.670 --> 01:48:25.120
Boardroom: That's great, thank you very much, I appreciate it, and thank you all very much also for the presentation, and just the time. I did see the Instagram, so, and I, so I do, like I said, I want to allow for the public comment for some of the folks who have young children here. I at least know there's two.

670
01:48:25.120 --> 01:48:28.919
Boardroom: I think. Yeah, so I'm gonna let you all go, and then we're gonna take a 10-minute break.

671
01:48:34.240 --> 01:48:37.050
Boardroom: Go ahead, I know there's a lot of people, make your way through.

672
01:48:39.330 --> 01:48:40.499
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor.

673

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01:48:41.330 --> 01:48:47.790
Boardroom: Council, my name is Alana Kinrich. I am very privileged to have the resources to be an Elmwood homeowner.

674
01:48:48.160 --> 01:48:56.959
Boardroom: I'm asking you to provide more opportunities for young families and lower-income people to live in my neighborhood by maximizing allowed housing.

675
01:48:57.750 --> 01:49:02.420
Boardroom: When I sat down in the front of this room tonight, I was told that I should sit in the back.

676
01:49:02.560 --> 01:49:05.350
Boardroom: Because breastfeeding my baby would be distracting.

677
01:49:05.830 --> 01:49:15.359
Boardroom: Councilmember Taplin was just shouted at for daring to ask about renters, about students, about people who can't afford to spend hours in this room.

678
01:49:15.660 --> 01:49:21.520
Boardroom: An anti-family and anti-renter sentiment feels very strong in this room tonight.

679
01:49:22.440 --> 01:49:34.300
Boardroom: I come here before you as a representative of people with young children who are unable to come to a Lung City Council meeting at this time, and who desperately need additional housing options in my neighborhood.

680
01:49:34.580 --> 01:49:41.800
Boardroom: I hope you will ask staff to study the maximum amount of housing possible in the Elmwood. Thank you. Thank you.

681
01:49:46.570 --> 01:49:54.639
Boardroom: Hello, council members. My name is Theo Gordon. I'm asking you and staff to study six stories throughout the corridors and include neighboring streets, especially those like Ashby.

682
01:49:54.960 --> 01:50:09.189
Boardroom: There's gonna be lots of talk tonight about preserving the Elmwood as what it has been, but I'm here as an Elmwood homeowner with 27 years left on my mortgage, which I think makes me a long-time resident,

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to ask you to think about what the future can be, and if it includes little guys like this.

683
01:50:09.720 --> 01:50:15.060
Boardroom: Or only includes people who bought their homes before I, and most of you, were bornâ€¦ sorry, Mark.

684
01:50:15.110 --> 01:50:25.239
Boardroom: During Halloween, I was at a gathering of 5 other Elmwood families with small babies. Every other one of those families was living in their parents' backyard.

685
01:50:25.240 --> 01:50:39.030
Boardroom: What's going to happen when those families move away because they can't afford to stay? What will our neighborhood be without kids for playdates, or teachers in our schools, or customers in our stores? If we want to preserve our neighborhood as a place where families can live, then we desperately need more housing.

686
01:50:39.030 --> 01:50:46.039
Boardroom: Homes are what give a neighborhood character, not obscure step-down requirements or exclusionary height restrictions. Please make a plan that builds the homes we need.

687
01:50:46.220 --> 01:50:47.860
Boardroom: Thank you.

688
01:50:54.230 --> 01:50:55.210
Boardroom: Hey.

689
01:50:55.540 --> 01:50:56.720
Boardroom: Test.

690
01:50:56.960 --> 01:51:06.839
Boardroom: Yeah, so I, don't have anything prepared, I probably should have. But, yeah, I liveâ€¦ I've been a Berkeley resident for about 15 years.

691
01:51:06.990 --> 01:51:11.080
Boardroom: 10 of those years, we lived in rent-controlled apartments.

692
01:51:11.300 --> 01:51:13.310
Boardroom: In the North Shattuck neighborhood.

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693
01:51:13.830 --> 01:51:16.240
Boardroom: And for close to the last 5,

694
01:51:16.640 --> 01:51:19.920
Boardroom: We've been fortunate enough to become homeowners,

695
01:51:20.030 --> 01:51:23.280
Boardroom: closer to here in North Berkeley, Iâ€¦

696
01:51:23.840 --> 01:51:29.210
Boardroom: Strongly support, building more housing, especially in these corridors.

697
01:51:30.630 --> 01:51:38.209
Boardroom: I never thought that I would be able to be along, you know, permanentâ€¦ homeowner in Berkeley, and

698
01:51:38.320 --> 01:51:45.369
Boardroom: Fortunately, weâ€¦ weâ€¦ have made it. I'd love to continue to be able to afford my mortgage.

699
01:51:45.550 --> 01:51:49.490
Boardroom: But, yeah, likeâ€¦ I'd love for myâ€¦

700
01:51:49.830 --> 01:51:54.570
Boardroom: other family to be able to afford to live out here. I want my children to be able to

701
01:51:55.010 --> 01:51:59.830
Boardroom: live here as well, so, yeah, that's it. Thank you.

702
01:52:04.220 --> 01:52:06.550
Boardroom: You can move the microphone, by the way.

703
01:52:08.110 --> 01:52:15.599
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Rohini. I have two kids not here at home. They claim they don't have homework. I find that unlikely.

704
01:52:15.810 --> 01:52:32.030

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Boardroom: I live in North Shattuck. I would love to welcome, other families with kids into my neighborhood, to explore the businesses we have. We have icons like Cheeseboard, Chepenisse, as you guys know. We also have small businesses that I use all the time, like Image Beauty Salon and So Clean.

705
01:52:32.030 --> 01:52:41.989
Boardroom: Kim and Image Beauty Salon, and Eunice at So Clean, two Asian American women, completely blindsided, no information about the upselling process.

706
01:52:42.010 --> 01:53:00.149
Boardroom: So, please consider pausing, before we go forward. Upzoning, from what I can hear, it adds housing, but with a trickle-down assumption, so add lots of luxury units, but only 10% affordable. No talk about home ownership, either. None of these developments seem to have any aspect of

707
01:53:00.150 --> 01:53:06.720
Boardroom: condo development where people can buy in. Please consider pausing.

708
01:53:06.720 --> 01:53:28.989
Boardroom: Please consider just involving businesses. Thank you. Sorry, my intention was for folks who had children here. I'd let you finish your comment, but it wasâ€¦ so that you could, you know, but I understand. Yeah, yeah, yeah, I hear what you're saying. Yeah, yeah, no, it's okay, you gave your comment. Alright, don't worry, don't worry about it. Am I good? Okay. Yeah. Am I done? You're done, yeah, thanks. Thank you. Okay, so we're gonna take our 10-minute break.

709
01:53:29.100 --> 01:53:31.950
Boardroom: And we will come back in 10 minutes. Thank you all.

710
01:53:43.980 --> 01:53:45.040
Boardroom: Okay!

711
01:53:45.490 --> 01:53:53.960
Boardroom: Folks, please quiet down! Oh, oh yeah, I know, we're gonna do my school teacher thing. If you can hear me clap once!

712
01:53:54.290 --> 01:53:55.890
Boardroom: If you can hear me clap twice!

713

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01:53:56.100 --> 01:53:58.059
Boardroom: If you can hear me, clap 3 times!

714
01:53:58.720 --> 01:54:02.519
Boardroom: Oh, we need to do that again. If you can hear me clap 3 times!

715
01:54:03.560 --> 01:54:16.030
Boardroom: Okay, it works in the classroom, so here we are. Okay. All right, folks, please, please, please, quiet down. We're starting this meeting again. Okay, soâ€¦

716
01:54:16.480 --> 01:54:25.489
Boardroom: We're gonna have public comment. I'm sure many folks know, but in case you don't already know this about me, I am a real sickler for time, so you will have one minute.

717
01:54:25.650 --> 01:54:29.429
Boardroom: Not a little more, not a little less, you'll have exactly a minute.

718
01:54:29.720 --> 01:54:40.670
Boardroom: And if you would like to give your minute to somebody, you can do that. Up toâ€¦ it would be up to 4 minutes total. That includes that person's minute, and then 3 people that would be giving their time.

719
01:54:41.040 --> 01:54:50.839
Boardroom: I would love if you could organize that beforehand, just so you're not standing up there trying to figure out whose minute you're getting. That would be great. I know some folks are doing that already, and that will really help us move along.

720
01:54:50.840 --> 01:55:01.170
Boardroom: I'm sure nobody wants to be here past midnight, so let's make this efficient, let's listen to everyone, let's be respectful, and, we're gonna start with our first speaker.

721
01:55:01.270 --> 01:55:02.100
Boardroom: Go ahead.

722
01:55:02.880 --> 01:55:10.340
Boardroom: Folks, please quiet down, because when they're speaking, I really want people to be respectful. Folks in the back, I know there are people in line talking. Thank you.

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723
01:55:11.390 --> 01:55:16.609
Boardroom: Hi, Mayor Ishii and Council Members. My name is Nama Firestone.

724
01:55:16.710 --> 01:55:33.220
Boardroom: And, I've been an architect, a low-income housing developer. I really support high-density housing and buildings and low-income housing. That's been my life pursuit. But I think that something has gone really wrong here.

725
01:55:33.420 --> 01:55:48.879
Boardroom: I'm seeing this pant-up frustration from people, and that's because we have not been given the chance to actually be part of the process of deciding how Berkeley will best implement high-density.

726
01:55:48.880 --> 01:55:53.829
Boardroom: housing, and developments. All of us want Berkeley to thrive.

727
01:55:53.830 --> 01:56:12.910
Boardroom: And the way this has been going on, it's kind of like, if you would allow me to use a metaphor, it's kind of like saying to me, okay, what's for dinner? You're getting chicken. And I would love to get dinner, I want all of us to eat dinner, but I don't want chicken. But not a single

728
01:56:12.960 --> 01:56:15.889
Boardroom: time. Thank you. Thanks for your time. Thank you.

729
01:56:22.350 --> 01:56:36.920
Boardroom: Madam Mayor, I'm gonna have 4 minutes, and we've got 3 people, soâ€¦ cards, 1, just hold on, 1, 2, and 3, if you could hold up your cards. 1, 2, and 3. Thank you. All right, perfect. They don't need to be in line, it's okay. Go ahead. Okay, excellent.

730
01:56:37.120 --> 01:56:52.610
Boardroom: Yes, my name is Donald Simon. I'm a construction attorney based downtown, and I live in Benvenue, right behind all the shops. I'm one of the organizers of Save Berkeley Shops, and you see us in the crowd here today. We're a coalition of businesses and residents

731
01:56:52.610 --> 01:57:00.699
Boardroom: who call these places home. I'm also a real YIMBY. I have two apartments in my backyard, and so do all my neighbors throughout the Elmwood.

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732
01:57:01.350 --> 01:57:09.359
Boardroom: This isn't about if we have additional housing in these three neighborhoods. We all support that. The question is how.

733
01:57:09.790 --> 01:57:16.479
Boardroom: These shopping districts are home to the most endangered business species in America today.

734
01:57:16.480 --> 01:57:31.410
Boardroom: Small, locally owned, independent retail stores. They survived COVID, they're somehow surviving Amazon, and now we want to put this on them, and the reason they're all here is because they are fearing for their future, and we are along here with them.

735
01:57:31.520 --> 01:57:49.770
Boardroom: Other cities would give their eye teeth to have these amazing shopping districts that we have, but now it seems the city's just taking it for granted. So the question is, must we really destroy these shopping districts, some of which are a century old, in order to achieve our housing objectives that we all want to see succeed?

736
01:57:49.770 --> 01:57:51.650
Boardroom: Because that's exactly what will happen.

737
01:57:51.990 --> 01:57:57.559
Boardroom: If you signal approval for this, real estate speculators will swoop in.

738
01:57:57.710 --> 01:58:14.260
Boardroom: They will secure rights to buy contiguous parcels, either through options, most likely so they can purchase in the future, they'll wait for the market to turn, and then they'll consolidate the lots and develop them themselves, or sell them to someone else who will. And when that first huge project breaks ground.

739
01:58:14.260 --> 01:58:19.420
Boardroom: The noise and disruption is gonna scare the customers away, and the rest of the businesses are gonna suffer.

740
01:58:19.420 --> 01:58:24.059
Boardroom: And so these businesses that are teetering are gonna teeter-totter off.

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741
01:58:25.010 --> 01:58:32.359
Boardroom: That is how you kill shopping districts that have taken generations to become the sustainable retail ecosystems they are.

742
01:58:32.720 --> 01:58:39.730
Boardroom: We're told that this is only going to facilitate the development of a few target lots. There's been a lot of talk about that.

743
01:58:39.940 --> 01:58:48.949
Boardroom: That's just simply not credible to us. If that was the objective, you could use spot zoning and variances under the law today, or you could make those

744
01:58:49.150 --> 01:59:01.930
Boardroom: more allowable under the law today. Why, if it's just gonna be a go-slow approach, and just a few target priority properties are gonna get developed, why then are we gonna change the zoning for the entire blocks?

745
01:59:02.080 --> 01:59:03.839
Boardroom: That just doesn't make sense.

746
01:59:04.030 --> 01:59:07.960
Boardroom: More importantly, the developers are not asking for this at this point.

747
01:59:08.000 --> 01:59:25.309
Boardroom: We have entitled projects that we've already talked about that are not getting built, that are eyesores and creating blight. Exhibit A, Center Street. Then, go where I work out at the YMCA and look at the open hole in the ground. There are a lot of ways to increase housing without destroying these shopping districts.

748
01:59:25.560 --> 01:59:41.530
Boardroom: We saw surveys talking about what people's preferences were. Those are rather dubious. Why? Because there was no effort made to confirm that those people responding were actually Berkeley residents. If you had an email address and you could get that URL, you could go on and you could be from Timbuktu.

749
01:59:42.080 --> 01:59:44.999
Boardroom: But the biggest issue here is engagement.

750

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01:59:46.210 --> 01:59:57.680
Boardroom: If you're going to do something like this, the democratic approach would be to engage with us and explore the range of different options for how you could house into our neighborhood.

751
01:59:59.370 --> 02:00:08.240
Boardroom: But instead, planning met only with developers, and guess what? The single choice we've been presented, our chicken on the dinner menu.

752
02:00:08.240 --> 02:00:20.929
Boardroom: Or happens to be the project type that will earn the developers the maximum profit, and put the most money in the planning department, which is 75% funded from fees that these developers and contractors pay.

753
02:00:23.330 --> 02:00:36.910
Boardroom: At a minimum, we would expect that we would be told what's happening. We've heard a little bit about outreach here today. The fact of the matter is, not a single letter went out to residents. Not a single letter went out to all these businesses. There was aâ€¦

754
02:00:37.140 --> 02:00:42.190
Boardroom: I have 4 minutes. Thank you. You had 4 minutes. That was 4 minutes, but thank you for your comment. Thank you.

755
02:00:55.970 --> 02:00:57.310
Boardroom: Okay.

756
02:00:59.420 --> 02:01:10.169
Boardroom: Okay, I'm Barbara, here's, like, my wife, Christine. I want to say, like, I'm Brazilian, I'm an immigrant, and I left Brazil, like, 8 years ago.

757
02:01:10.220 --> 02:01:25.839
Boardroom: To live here, my dreams, because, like, my dreams were just notâ€¦ I was afraid to live in Brazil and tell my family I'm a lesbian, and without knowing any English, I, like, just rope, like, my life up, like, here, my history up.

758
02:01:25.950 --> 02:01:31.759
Boardroom: And now, my wife and I, we are, like, owner of a small business in Elmwood.

759

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02:01:31.760 --> 02:01:48.589
Boardroom: And for the first time, I feel, like, really afraid not to sit. I feel afraid, like, just lost everything we are investing, and, like, we just, like, kind of stop, like, growing our business because we don't know what's gonna happen, because I don't think that's a good future.

760
02:01:48.590 --> 02:01:53.790
Boardroom: for a small business, and, like, people, like, who really loves Elmwood, like us.

761
02:01:53.920 --> 02:01:59.319
Boardroom: like, shouldn't be feeling like that. Like, we should have more answers than, like, just questions.

762
02:02:06.020 --> 02:02:18.689
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Christine. We recently took over Berkeley Organic Market in Elmwood. I myself am in, hopefully, the final stages of my PhD at Cal.

763
02:02:18.810 --> 02:02:33.219
Boardroom: we likely will not be able to afford to live in the new units that are built in college. I've been a renter in Berkeley since 2016. I expect to be a renter

764
02:02:33.640 --> 02:02:42.029
Boardroom: forever in Berkeley. And this project and all projects that don't include affordable condos won't change that.

765
02:02:42.700 --> 02:02:45.939
Boardroom: That said, I do want to see more housing.

766
02:02:47.210 --> 02:03:00.229
Boardroom: And I know that it's not the Council's job to care about my particular small business. That's my job. But I do think the Council does care, collectively, about the general health of the commercial districts that are being upzoned.

767
02:03:00.410 --> 02:03:14.130
Boardroom: And part of the whole vision is for people to live near commercially and culturally vibrant areas that are walkable. Can I get one more? Thank you. Okay. Number 4, go ahead.

768
02:03:16.400 --> 02:03:31.120

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Boardroom: I wish, when we got to the meeting about, the city planning came and told us that this would be good for small businesses, because there would be more foot traffic. And the thought seems to be that more density will help small businesses.

769
02:03:31.400 --> 02:03:40.499
Boardroom: Keteris Paribus, that would be true. I wish it were true, but all things do not stay the same. Ground floor retail and new developments is a trap.

770
02:03:40.760 --> 02:03:47.690
Boardroom: It is next to impossible for small owners to get in to those with the build-outs and collateral required.

771
02:03:48.770 --> 02:04:02.700
Boardroom: And even the investment-backed chains have taken a while to move into some of the prime retail spaces right on Bancroft. There's something going on there, and I really think that the city would be in everyone's interest to study that more.

772
02:04:02.810 --> 02:04:06.419
Boardroom: And, so, please, also.

773
02:04:06.770 --> 02:04:20.350
Boardroom: you know, I'm glad to hear there's a consulting thing going on about small businesses, but you can also talk to me, I'm free. And I love to talk about this, and I want to thank you all. I want to thank you all for your time and service. Thank you.

774
02:04:26.970 --> 02:04:28.450
Boardroom: Hello, everybody.

775
02:04:28.530 --> 02:04:35.179
Boardroom: Thank you for your time. Looking atâ€¦ my name is Ariane, and I'm a small business owner on North Shattuck.

776
02:04:35.180 --> 02:04:57.880
Boardroom: I'm just looking at the whole situation here at the most positive way, but we recently have moved our location 30 seconds walking distance, and it hurt our business in the most dramatic way possible, and this is whatever happens with whatever support that everybody would give us here, changing a location for

777
02:04:57.900 --> 02:05:09.600

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Boardroom: small businesses hurts the business the most, and if this happens again, we are not gonna be able to survive, and we are going to lose our businesses. We've been there for 30-plus years, andâ€¦

778
02:05:09.600 --> 02:05:27.809
Boardroom: A bank used to own our property, and they kicked us out after 30 years without even letting us know that they're even planning on selling the building. And changing a location for small businesses is the worst thing that could happen, and none of the businesses would survive if this happens.

779
02:05:27.810 --> 02:05:29.770
Boardroom: Thank you.

780
02:05:33.790 --> 02:05:36.560
Boardroom: We need, 5, 6, and 7.

781
02:05:37.110 --> 02:05:38.070
Boardroom: Excellent.

782
02:05:38.310 --> 02:05:53.609
Boardroom: Good evening. I missed 5, sorry. Oh, 5 is inâ€¦ oh, in the back, thank you. Thank you for the opportunity to speak and address Council. My name is David Salk. I've owned and operated a Berkeley Business Focal Point for 50 years.

783
02:05:54.040 --> 02:06:07.549
Boardroom: I've served on the board of the Elmwood Merchants, was president for a number of years, but most importantly and relevant, since 1990, I've been the president of the Elmwood theater Foundation, which is a nonprofit that restored the theater

784
02:06:08.040 --> 02:06:18.129
Boardroom: After the fire in 1988, we worked closely with the City of Berkeley, from the Mayor to the Office of Economic Development. Jordan, thank you.

785
02:06:18.390 --> 02:06:22.180
Boardroom: And created a viable project working together.

786
02:06:22.290 --> 02:06:27.730
Boardroom: And that's what I want to emphasize to you all tonight, is the Elmwood Theater is a statue

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787
02:06:27.950 --> 02:06:30.100
Boardroom: working together.

788
02:06:31.540 --> 02:06:44.640
Boardroom: When I learned about the August meeting at St. John's, I learned about it two days before. Now, I'm not saying that there wasn't some attempt to do reach out, but there clearly wasn't enough. But more importantly, at the presentation.

789
02:06:44.720 --> 02:06:54.650
Boardroom: in August, there was no mention by anyone about the fact that there were possibly other options, nor was there any mention about the idea

790
02:06:55.020 --> 02:06:55.880
Boardroom: thatâ€¦

791
02:06:55.910 --> 02:07:15.140
Boardroom: businesses were going to be displaced. If these projects were going to get built, you can't build a 5-story, 6-story building on top of an existing business. They get displaced. They either move, or they close. And the idea that moving is gonna be something that can be assisted with, with low-interest loans and mitigation.

792
02:07:15.140 --> 02:07:28.180
Boardroom: is just utter nonsense. Those businesses will notâ€¦ first of all, they will likely not find other places to move to, and even if they do, the amount of debt they're going to incur in rehabbing the spaces and moving.

793
02:07:28.260 --> 02:07:30.259
Boardroom: Forget it. It won't happen.

794
02:07:30.600 --> 02:07:38.499
Boardroom: So, what strikes me about this, though, is that I appreciate the fact that there were these presentations by the planning department when theâ€¦

795
02:07:38.700 --> 02:07:41.950
Boardroom: When the city was laying out the two options.

796
02:07:42.110 --> 02:07:46.330

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Boardroom: But they could have anticipated that business owners would have panicked.

797
02:07:46.410 --> 02:07:59.459
Boardroom: They could have anticipated that business owners would have come to that meeting and thought, what are the implications of this for my business? And there was no attempt to be proactive about getting in front of that and saying to the community.

798
02:07:59.460 --> 02:08:16.170
Boardroom: We know that some of you are going to be unhappy because this could potentially mean the displacement and relocation or closure of legacy businesses. And College Avenue is filled with businesses that have been there 20, 30, 40, and in my case, 50 years.

799
02:08:16.310 --> 02:08:24.939
Boardroom: I've got 10 employees, they depend on me. I've got a family that depends on me. What about all that? What are we doing to protect that?

800
02:08:26.070 --> 02:08:26.960
Boardroom: Soâ€¦

801
02:08:28.840 --> 02:08:40.320
Boardroom: I want to say, this isn't a case of NIMBYism, this is a case of smart planning. And I don't want to see this turn into an adversarial conversation between young, old.

802
02:08:40.410 --> 02:08:52.899
Boardroom: racial issues, all of this. It's not necessary for us to go down that path. We can work together, we can talk over these problems, we can meetâ€¦ I'm heartened by the fact that we've been talking about

803
02:08:53.000 --> 02:09:00.259
Boardroom: more collaboration and reaching out. This is the first time that I've heard that, you know, we're not deciding anything tonight.

804
02:09:00.550 --> 02:09:02.830
Boardroom: But, you know, when I heard yourâ€¦

805
02:09:02.830 --> 02:09:27.110
Boardroom: comments at the State of the State of the City Address. I was really heartened by your comments, Mayor Ishii, when you said Berkeley has had a reputation of not being a business-friendly city, and I want to

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turn that reputation around, and my office understands the direct connection between the success of our local businesses with our local economy, jobs, and the unique culture of Berkeley. And to that, I say.

806
02:09:27.230 --> 02:09:28.760
Boardroom: Bravo.

807
02:09:31.630 --> 02:09:43.290
Boardroom: I'm asking for you to show us the respect that we deserve. Social justice is about housing, but it's also about protecting our small businesses. Thank you very much. Thank you.

808
02:09:49.240 --> 02:09:57.020
Boardroom: And, let's seeâ€¦ I think we're at 7, 8? We just did 7, so 8â€¦ Okay, thank you!

809
02:09:57.200 --> 02:09:59.290
Boardroom: So you will have 3 minutes.

810
02:10:00.470 --> 02:10:12.420
Boardroom: Thank you so much for giving me an opportunity to speak with you tonight. My name is Vanessa Vichett-Vatican. I am one of the 50 worker owners of the Cheese Board Collective.

811
02:10:16.840 --> 02:10:33.049
Boardroom: I am here tonight because we are the owners of the building that stretches from 1500 to 1512 Shattuck Avenue, and is going to abut any building that is built in the space where the Bank of America building

812
02:10:33.340 --> 02:10:37.740
Boardroom: currently stands, so it's obvious that we're concerned about

813
02:10:37.930 --> 02:10:57.520
Boardroom: whatâ€¦ how that will affect us. Andâ€¦ I don't know, because we haven't gotten any information, really. We were lucky that a neighbor sent us an email, letting us know that the construction was an actual plan in the neighborhood, and that's how we found out, maybe 3 weeks ago. Soâ€¦

814
02:10:59.320 --> 02:11:06.330
Boardroom: You're taking her time. So, thank you. Iâ€¦ I'm here to ask

815

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02:11:07.100 --> 02:11:22.100
Boardroom: you and us to work with the cooperative lens on. This is howâ€¦ this is how we operate, and this is how we've stayed in business for 58 years today. This is our birthday today.

816
02:11:23.930 --> 02:11:35.019
Boardroom: So what that means for me and for us, I think I can speak for the cooperative when I say that this involves really good, clear, frequent, and good communication.

817
02:11:35.180 --> 02:11:41.710
Boardroom: This involves transparency, honesty, andâ€¦ cooperation. It'sâ€¦

818
02:11:42.850 --> 02:11:55.859
Boardroom: Sounds kind of simple, it's a little bit difficult sometimes, but it's how we've lasted this long, it's how democracy lasts and endures. We have to practice it to keep it alive.

819
02:11:56.600 --> 02:11:59.019
Boardroom: Yeah, I think thatâ€¦

820
02:11:59.070 --> 02:12:18.760
Boardroom: there was a question about the timeline of things feeling like they're going really fast, and someone over here, I believe, said, actually, the timeline doesn't seem that fast, but when you're a small business who's about to be shadowed by a building, that might or might not be a good thing. I don't know.

821
02:12:18.760 --> 02:12:24.359
Boardroom: Because we don't have the information. But, once we do, we'll know. But weâ€¦

822
02:12:24.530 --> 02:12:38.890
Boardroom: that timeline feels a lot faster when you're about to be in that shadow. So, I want to echo what I've heard before, which is, please involve us in the communication and theâ€¦

823
02:12:38.940 --> 02:12:51.270
Boardroom: And the process. We are here to do that. This, this is what we do. The cheese board is all about that. So, thank you for your time, and thank you for this opportunity.

824
02:12:51.760 --> 02:12:52.930

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Boardroom: Thank you.

825
02:12:57.830 --> 02:12:59.010
Boardroom: 10 and 11.

826
02:12:59.950 --> 02:13:01.929
Boardroom: We have 11. 12.

827
02:13:03.760 --> 02:13:06.940
Boardroom: See, 11 is over here, so 10 and 11.

828
02:13:07.520 --> 02:13:14.450
Boardroom: Hello, Ms. Mayor, City Council members, consultants, and fellow Berkeley business owners.

829
02:13:15.110 --> 02:13:19.169
Boardroom: City Council, thank you for your efforts to address our housing crisis.

830
02:13:19.300 --> 02:13:30.269
Boardroom: I'm Mike Apti, I'm a retired LB&L scientist. I'm now the manager of Apti Family Properties, LLC, a task left me by my late father.

831
02:13:30.540 --> 02:13:43.610
Boardroom: We own two commercial buildings in Berkeley. We have Berkeley Business License to operate both properties. The CZU directly involves our property at 1519 and 1521 Shattuck Avenue.

832
02:13:44.020 --> 02:13:46.110
Boardroom: We've owned that for 45 years.

833
02:13:46.620 --> 02:13:56.369
Boardroom: You may know it as the 94709 post office. We have several other tenants, including Chezonis offices, jewelers, and 3 therapists.

834
02:13:56.630 --> 02:14:13.689
Boardroom: As a landlord, I take the responsibility of caring for and protecting the interests of our tenants seriously. When major issues such as possible rezoning of the neighborhood come up, I need to know about it, because it likely has major downstream effects on both my business and that of my tenants.

835

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02:14:14.010 --> 02:14:27.630
Boardroom: That is why I was appalled when I attended the Ramey Associates workshop in the North Berkeley Senior Center. I found out about this meeting as a local citizen from a neighbor, not as a local business owner. The workshop

836
02:14:27.630 --> 02:14:38.869
Boardroom: proved to be an attempt to stifle real community input, with no real options offered. Questions to the presenters were quashed, and the poster board voting was merely a show

837
02:14:38.920 --> 02:14:53.629
Boardroom: of a choice between a couple of design elements for one rezoning outcome. Little or no consideration was provided on how local businesses would be protected from the disruption caused by implementation of this one basic approach.

838
02:14:53.990 --> 02:15:00.470
Boardroom: We are not given a chance to discuss, explore, or offer other possible approaches to development of new housing.

839
02:15:01.200 --> 02:15:02.869
Boardroom: Why does this bother me?

840
02:15:03.120 --> 02:15:19.200
Boardroom: My business has never received any communication by any means from the city to elicit our ideas or otherwise participate in planning. As a licensed business owner, we have been let down by the city by its lack of notification and invitation to participate.

841
02:15:19.570 --> 02:15:32.010
Boardroom: Having personally walked and contacted all the local stores along North Shattuck corridor, I can confirm that not a single shopkeeper has received an invitation to participate in developing strategies to create

842
02:15:32.050 --> 02:15:47.810
Boardroom: create more local housing. It's shameful that the city thinks that it can get away with a taxation without representation scheme. Our business urges the City Council to slow down and bring us to the planning table. Thank you.

843
02:15:48.810 --> 02:15:49.740
Boardroom: Thank you.

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844
02:16:00.920 --> 02:16:09.889
Boardroom: Oh, 12? So, we have now 12, and 13, there we go. And 14. Okay.

845
02:16:10.490 --> 02:16:13.870
Boardroom: Do you need them? Yeah. Okay. Do you need 4 minutes?

846
02:16:15.080 --> 02:16:21.699
Boardroom: She's gonnaâ€¦ Okay, who knows? Alright, I'm gonnaâ€¦ you'll have 3 minutes then, so 12 and 13, plus yours.

847
02:16:24.610 --> 02:16:30.409
Boardroom: Hello, members of the City Council and Mayor. My name's Mary Orem.

848
02:16:30.980 --> 02:16:33.759
Boardroom: own a real estate business that Iâ€¦

849
02:16:33.969 --> 02:16:45.350
Boardroom: had with my husband until he retired, and it's been in the Elmwood neighborhood for 40 years. I also live in the Willard neighborhood. I walk to work almost every day.

850
02:16:45.660 --> 02:16:50.529
Boardroom: My concern is that in considering what you'reâ€¦ what you're planning on doing.

851
02:16:50.650 --> 02:17:00.230
Boardroom: it's going to sow the seeds of the destruction of these small commercial districts in Berkeley. Not tomorrow, but gradually over time.

852
02:17:00.370 --> 02:17:01.230
Boardroom: theâ€¦

853
02:17:01.530 --> 02:17:09.940
Boardroom: The problem is that there are two conflicting groups. There are the property owners and the business owners, and they have different

854
02:17:10.150 --> 02:17:28.479
Boardroom: goals. The property owner, of course, wants to maximize their income. The business owner wants to continue their business and maximize their income. In changing the zoning, you will dramatically change the incentive of the property owner to sell

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855
02:17:28.480 --> 02:17:34.759
Boardroom: the property. Because the bigger the building, you can build on these lots.

856
02:17:34.760 --> 02:17:57.140
Boardroom: the more valuable the lot will be. And so, as it currently stands, there's kind of a balance between the commercial rent and the return that the property owner is getting. When you increase the potential for many more rents by building many more housing units, it's going to dramatically increase the value of the lot. And so.

857
02:17:57.139 --> 02:17:59.909
Boardroom: Perhaps the current owner has someâ€¦

858
02:18:00.120 --> 02:18:10.340
Boardroom: a good relationship with their business tenant, but if that current owner's circumstances change, or if their family inherits, that

859
02:18:10.930 --> 02:18:29.079
Boardroom: imbalance is going to come forward. And that's when those properties are going to be sold, and that's when the existing businesses are going to beâ€¦ have to leave, and that's when the property's going to be torn down, and something's going to be built in its place, and it's gonna be very disruptive. I live across the street from Willard Park.

860
02:18:29.200 --> 02:18:47.150
Boardroom: And a couple years ago, they started buildingâ€¦ they tore down the old clubhouse, and they built this community center. It took a year and a half. Now there's only houses on one side of the street, but the construction people took the parking on both sides of the street all day. They took, I think.

861
02:18:47.770 --> 02:18:54.070
Boardroom: an equal amount of land in the park for staging the construction. And so.

862
02:18:54.070 --> 02:19:13.490
Boardroom: I'm very concerned that this, the little former dry cleaners on College Avenue is going to be rebuilt, because there's no room for the construction workers to park. There's no room to store the construction materials. I think it's going to be devastating to the businesses that are on either side, to say nothing of the traffic on College Avenue, because

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863
02:19:14.010 --> 02:19:25.969
Boardroom: I figured they're gonna have to close off a lane at times. The AC Transit bus goes there, the 51B, it's gonna be a mess. Andâ€¦ I thinkâ€¦

864
02:19:26.219 --> 02:19:27.719
Boardroom: Those are my concerns.

865
02:19:33.709 --> 02:19:36.249
Boardroom: Gotta keep our line moving.

866
02:19:37.139 --> 02:19:39.230
Boardroom: Yeah, okay, distribution.

867
02:19:40.320 --> 02:19:42.050
Boardroom: So she's giving a second minute.

868
02:19:43.650 --> 02:19:44.620
Boardroom: Thank you.

869
02:19:44.930 --> 02:19:47.320
Boardroom: Thank you.

870
02:19:47.870 --> 02:20:01.960
Boardroom: Thank you. My name is Margo Smith, and I've lived in Berkeley since 1969. And I speak for the Berkeley voters who oppose the upstilling plans for three Berkeley business districts, North Shattuck, Solano, and the Elmwood.

871
02:20:01.960 --> 02:20:16.459
Boardroom: These vital commercial districts now allow small businesses to flourish and shoppers to buy near their neighborhoods. I can walk to shops from my home to take care of my daily needs. Unfortunately, it seems that

872
02:20:16.460 --> 02:20:41.119
Boardroom: There's some commitment to allowing massive housing in my neighborhood that will destroy this vile commercial district. And not only that, as a social scientist, I can tell you that the city upzoning survey was poorly written and will give Council misinformation. It only allowed opinions on new proposals, not other options. And not only that, you had 1,200 respondents in a city of

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873
02:20:41.120 --> 02:20:45.259
Boardroom: thousand people. That's veryâ€¦ not very representative.

874
02:20:45.620 --> 02:20:46.670
Boardroom: I hope youâ€¦

875
02:20:49.880 --> 02:21:08.449
Boardroom: I hope you will ignore this survey and look for something more, with better reality. The city plan for upzoning will permit the building of massive structures that will displace many small businesses and uproot our successful local business community.

876
02:21:08.450 --> 02:21:18.680
Boardroom: We can see the future in the row of high-riseâ€¦ high-rent vacant shops in downtown and elsewhere. Center Street and Poyo, and I meanâ€¦

877
02:21:18.680 --> 02:21:32.099
Boardroom: You don't have to look far for this. We've been building housing here in Berkeley for the last 30 years, and the rents have not gone down, and we haven't provided more housing for low-income people. What do you think that thisâ€¦

878
02:21:32.100 --> 02:21:51.450
Boardroom: trickle of low-income housing is going to do for the future here. I'd like to think that our council members cherish our charming and unique Berkeley, value its small business and active commercial districts, support low-income housing and rent control, and listen to constituents and respect their concerns. Thank you.

879
02:22:02.270 --> 02:22:08.720
Boardroom: Hello, Mayor, Council people. My name is Drew Detsch. I'm here to,

880
02:22:09.050 --> 02:22:23.820
Boardroom: Talk about what everyone else is talking about here, and all you council people do know, you've all walked these neighborhoods. You know we actually have really vital neighborhoods. These things work. Most planners would give their eye teeth to develop something with that much

881
02:22:24.060 --> 02:22:30.199
Boardroom: texture, life. These are fabulous places, but they're very fragile.

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882
02:22:30.350 --> 02:22:41.019
Boardroom: And yes, we need housing, but housing has to be thought of in an appropriate way, in appropriate areas. Absolutely important we have adequate housing.

883
02:22:41.510 --> 02:22:49.349
Boardroom: Thisâ€¦ what we had here, you've heard of it before, the process was skewed. Working in urban planning for 40 years.

884
02:22:49.350 --> 02:23:03.949
Boardroom: When you have a workshop, you present things to people, you get their input, you show opportunity, you show options, you show alternatives, and let peopleâ€¦ you inform people and get their informed opinions. This didn't happen.

885
02:23:04.120 --> 02:23:05.480
Boardroom: Thank you.

886
02:23:12.040 --> 02:23:17.320
Boardroom: I have someone giving me a minute in the back. Stephanie? Okay.

887
02:23:17.870 --> 02:23:29.559
Boardroom: Pardon? I have twoâ€¦ Okay, so you have two minutes. Go ahead. That's up to you. You can keep your mask on if you want, whatever'sâ€¦ Well, I have a dad with dementia and a sister with cancer, so I try to be super careful.

888
02:23:31.320 --> 02:23:35.070
Boardroom: Good evening, Council, Mayor, and staff.

889
02:23:36.130 --> 02:23:55.230
Boardroom: My name is Moni Law, I'm a resident of Berkeley. Mayor, Council, I appreciate your stated goal of adding more housing with a goal of equity and affordability. To those formidable goals, I have questions and concerns. I'm a Cal alum, I've owned 3 homes, I'm starting my nonprofit business, and I'm fortunate to live in a rent-controlled apartment in Berkeley.

890
02:23:55.270 --> 02:24:02.150
Boardroom: I love and support businesses in all three corridors, includingâ€¦ I love Saul's, And their matzo ball soup.

891

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02:24:02.350 --> 02:24:25.599
Boardroom: Since 1978 to 87, and the last 15 years, one, has the city conducted an audit, a comprehensive study of how many current housing units are actually empty, or being Airbnb'd, which is just as well be empty, because they're there for a couple weeks and gone? I've had Cal parents and students tell me that many units are empty. Shattuck Avenue, University Avenue, new buildings now charge $3,500 for one bedroom.

892
02:24:25.600 --> 02:24:33.880
Boardroom: 4,500 and up, two bedrooms, and many new buildings are charging students by the bed, $1,200. And these are not rent-controlled units.

893
02:24:34.880 --> 02:24:52.190
Boardroom: 2. Is the town and gown coordinating as we build? UC went decades without building, as did the city fail to build affordable units despite its nexus studies confirming 20%, not just 10%, and they stuck on that. So ABAC cited us for failing to increase affordable units.

894
02:24:52.360 --> 02:24:59.340
Boardroom: My alma mater just bought the Marriott Hotel on Center Street, gutted People's Park and killed over 50 trees.

895
02:24:59.860 --> 02:25:07.370
Boardroom: And the last open space that was in South Berkeley. 3. Is the Council passing a community benefits ordinance to require diversity hiring, local hires.

896
02:25:07.530 --> 02:25:24.620
Boardroom: Public art, affordable childcare, free conference rooms, etc. Four, and final, what steps are being taken to increase the number of Black, Brown, and Indigenous tenants to these new units? Equity for Black Berkeley preference points were created after extensive workshops, legal research, and Jack McCormick and the Mayor Ergane.

897
02:25:24.620 --> 02:25:36.139
Boardroom: an awesome team and healthy black families to try to turn around the displacement and gentrification of 42% of South Berkeley used to be black, and now it's only 7%. Thank you. Thanks.

898
02:25:43.940 --> 02:25:45.129
Boardroom: Who am I going to?

899
02:25:57.010 --> 02:26:16.060

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Boardroom: Hi, I'm Sonia Trouse, and I live right here on Browning, sorry, about a block and a half away. I support the upzoning. We definitely need more housing, we definitely do not have enough housing. We're renting, actually, in a triplex, so some little multi-family zoning, and it's working, so that's good.

900
02:26:16.160 --> 02:26:30.989
Boardroom: I think there are definitely creative and fascinating ways to solve all of the real problems that people are, presenting here. Small businesses are super important, and they definitely do need support from their local governments.

901
02:26:30.990 --> 02:26:40.119
Boardroom: And I think there are people who are sincere in their concern about small business, so I hope that they spend all of their energy thinking about solutions to the problems.

902
02:26:40.120 --> 02:27:00.229
Boardroom: I am a professional organizer, and so I would like for everyone to know that you never have to wait for the city to ask you for an idea. You can always have an idea on your own and bring it to them. This is part of the housing element, which was passed in, like, February of 2023, and it's now 2025, which is 2 years.

903
02:27:00.230 --> 02:27:04.119
Boardroom: Thank you. So, it's notâ€¦ shouldn't be a surprise. Thank you.

904
02:27:04.330 --> 02:27:08.309
Boardroom: We're my blog?

905
02:27:11.310 --> 02:27:19.490
Boardroom: Hi, thank you. My name is Julia. I, am an owner of Navalon Bakery in Elmwood.

906
02:27:20.810 --> 02:27:32.600
Boardroom: And I am here to say, nobody who works at my bakery can afford to live in Berkeley. Low-income housing is a joke here. Think about what minimum wage is.

907
02:27:32.950 --> 02:27:44.680
Boardroom: And think about how much people make when they make your food, and that is low-income housing. And if you can't provide that, we don't want it.

908

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02:27:51.570 --> 02:27:56.880
Boardroom: Good evening. I'm Dr. Steven Alpert. I live 300 feet from Solano Avenue.

909
02:27:57.020 --> 02:28:11.439
Boardroom: At the second Solano Avenue workshop on August 27, the presenter assured the audience that applicants would most likely request only 50% density bonus, which allows for 8-story buildings if up zoning is enacted.

910
02:28:11.450 --> 02:28:29.269
Boardroom: Accordingly, every single slide displayed showed building heights of only 8 stories. In fact, 11-story structures are permitted on Solano, with a 100% density bonus, as documented on page 19 of the August 18 Berkeley Quarters Alternative Report, shown here.

911
02:28:29.530 --> 02:28:45.389
Boardroom: At a meeting of the Berkeley Design Review Committee on August 16, a developer, what do you know, requested a 100% density bonus to allow for his proposed 23-story building on 2029 University Avenue.

912
02:28:45.670 --> 02:28:55.750
Boardroom: Could the city be any more duplicitous and deceptive regarding upzoning? Do you absolutely refuse to address 100%â€¦ Thank you. â€¦density bonus? Thank you.

913
02:28:59.200 --> 02:28:59.909
Boardroom: I have toâ€¦

914
02:29:00.070 --> 02:29:06.159
Boardroom: I just have to say that we did actually address that. That was one of the questions I asked, so just to be clear, go ahead.

915
02:29:06.630 --> 02:29:22.309
Boardroom: Hi, I'm Dr. Celeste Marks. Planners mislead us by saying upvoting would improve housing equity. Most of the units built will be market rate. The private real estate industry is not going to build

916
02:29:22.570 --> 02:29:42.200
Boardroom: Housing for people of modest means, because it doesn't yield the profit they, their creditors, and their investors demand. What if a developer evicts the tenants, retail and residential, and then decides not to build? That's what happened to the once vibrant row of restaurants

917

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02:29:42.200 --> 02:29:49.989
Boardroom: On Center Street in downtown, please pause this process and engage with us.

918
02:29:50.930 --> 02:29:53.830
Boardroom: Bravo. Thank you!

919
02:29:55.740 --> 02:29:56.429
Boardroom: Come on up.

920
02:30:01.070 --> 02:30:03.749
Boardroom: Feel free to move the mic, yeah. Thanks.

921
02:30:04.030 --> 02:30:20.719
Boardroom: I'm Michael Hammersley, I was born in the Bay, went to school and college here. I live on the edge of Berkeley and Oakland with my wife and daughter. We also pay way too much in rent. Our rent is 60% of the median Berkeley salary, and my landlord is still terrible, because there isn't enough housing in the Bay. We need more at any price.

922
02:30:20.810 --> 02:30:36.359
Boardroom: I'm worried we won't be able to afford to raise our first child here, let alone the second or third we'd like to have. I'm also one of the lucky ones. I haven't been pushed out yet. But, many of my friends have already left for less expensive places, and my rent keeps going up to subsidize the status quo.

923
02:30:36.370 --> 02:30:48.199
Boardroom: So on behalf of all the folks who are spending tonight either working or raising their kids, I respectfully request that instead of adding only 2 or 3 stories in each corridor, let's explore 5, or 7, or 23.

924
02:30:48.310 --> 02:30:54.380
Boardroom: And, let's keep it retail-ready, but let's minimize, if not eliminate setbacks.

925
02:30:54.690 --> 02:31:08.630
Boardroom: Let's study upzoning not just along the corridor, but for several blocks parallel to it on either side. Please make Berkeley affordable for its young people who want to raise their families here. More housing cannot wait. Housing delayed is housing denied. Thank you.

926
02:31:10.990 --> 02:31:12.020

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Boardroom: Folks.

927
02:31:12.180 --> 02:31:20.989
Boardroom: Please don't boo. It's okay if you clap, be aware you're taking up some of their time when you're doing that, but please no booing. Okay, go ahead. Yeah, Halloween's over.

928
02:31:21.130 --> 02:31:24.090
Boardroom: Second minute, please? Yeah, 14.

929
02:31:25.260 --> 02:31:26.190
Boardroom: Alright.

930
02:31:30.480 --> 02:31:32.140
Boardroom: Steve Tracy.

931
02:31:32.570 --> 02:31:33.650
Boardroom: Good evening.

932
02:31:34.120 --> 02:31:38.190
Boardroom: When I walk from Euclid, to North Shattuck.

933
02:31:38.970 --> 02:31:46.039
Boardroom: And get some exercise, but yesterday, I drove to Elmwood. I had to carry stuff back with my car.

934
02:31:46.760 --> 02:31:52.640
Boardroom: And I paused and looked at shops I'd never seen before, and realizedâ€¦

935
02:31:52.940 --> 02:31:54.880
Boardroom: This is part of the culture.

936
02:31:57.700 --> 02:32:01.080
Boardroom: This is part of the DNA of the city.

937
02:32:02.150 --> 02:32:12.130
Boardroom: So I'm asking, you, Council, tonight, to please consider what you can do to support small businesses Andâ€¦

938
02:32:12.540 --> 02:32:18.250

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Boardroom: That housing element has kind of paid for this. Can we see that? You don't need to see me.

939
02:32:18.950 --> 02:32:21.500
Boardroom: That way, this way.

940
02:32:23.300 --> 02:32:34.840
Boardroom: May, consent calendar item authorizedâ€¦ We can't hear you in theâ€¦ yeah. May, a quarter million dollars was authorized on the consent calendar.

941
02:32:35.000 --> 02:32:41.289
Boardroom: to study small businesses. I think that's part of the 600 grand for the current study. Oh, thank you.

942
02:32:41.540 --> 02:32:44.799
Boardroom: Can'tâ€¦ it's out of the camera, though.

943
02:32:45.010 --> 02:32:53.490
Boardroom: There were specific directives, 6â€¦ I didn't practice this partâ€¦ 6 specific directives, three of them about housing.

944
02:32:53.650 --> 02:33:05.890
Boardroom: But 3 that haven't been addressed by the current study. So it would be nice if the current study addressed these items 4, 5, and 6 to support the, sustainability of small businesses.

945
02:33:07.010 --> 02:33:10.719
Boardroom: Please pause.

946
02:33:11.650 --> 02:33:16.110
Boardroom: Think about option 3, not just Option 1 and 2 that are laid out.

947
02:33:16.120 --> 02:33:35.300
Boardroom: And then, go drive down Shattuck and go look at 2109 Virginia. 92% density bonus is already under current law, 8 stories. At Francisco, 7 stories under construction. Thank you. Under current density bonus.

948
02:33:35.300 --> 02:33:42.409
Boardroom: Okay. A minute has been given to you. Go ahead. I wish I had better pictures. You can put that down.

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949
02:33:42.680 --> 02:33:46.790
Boardroom: I wish I had better pictures from my silly cell phone.

950
02:33:47.290 --> 02:33:49.470
Boardroom: What is mixed use?

951
02:33:49.590 --> 02:33:57.260
Boardroom: Guys, hold up the number of fingers. What percent needs to be commercial to be mixed-use? It only takes two hands.

952
02:33:57.750 --> 02:34:05.559
Boardroom: Because this project at 2109 Virginia is 6% commercial.

953
02:34:05.910 --> 02:34:16.620
Boardroom: 94% housing. So we took out all those businesses. Poulet is gone. We took out those businesses, and we're putting in 1,200 square feet.

954
02:34:19.540 --> 02:34:24.720
Boardroom: The second building that's under construction at Francisco, you need two more fingers.

955
02:34:25.250 --> 02:34:28.110
Boardroom: 12% commercial.

956
02:34:28.390 --> 02:34:29.979
Boardroom: That's a big one.

957
02:34:31.540 --> 02:34:41.210
Boardroom: Those hit the 10,000 square foot bonus that you guys were talking about to make it viable. Thank you. They're already there. Thanks.

958
02:34:45.310 --> 02:34:46.920
Boardroom: Come on up, please, come.

959
02:34:52.230 --> 02:35:00.399
Boardroom: Hello, my name is Joan Etlinger. I actually live in Oakland, on the border, and I shop in the Elmwood all the time, which is why I'mâ€¦

960

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02:35:00.630 --> 02:35:09.749
Boardroom: making the time to come to this meeting. What really concerns me more than anything is that upzoning is the height of the buildings.

961
02:35:09.750 --> 02:35:24.429
Boardroom: College Avenue is a narrow two-lane street. It's very easy to walk across it. The pedestrian-scale nature of the buildings, one and two stories, is what makes it so very enjoyable to walk there and shop there.

962
02:35:24.450 --> 02:35:31.050
Boardroom: And toâ€¦ Build at the scale that is being considered.

963
02:35:31.150 --> 02:35:43.129
Boardroom: takes away from that. I think of it as the Manhattanization of College Avenue. But, to the extent that I've been around long enough to know how these things go.

964
02:35:43.460 --> 02:35:56.709
Boardroom: When you start allowing construction of these buildings, please consider anything over 3 stories, which they will beâ€¦ Thank you. Setbacks. Thanks.

965
02:36:00.660 --> 02:36:02.350
Boardroom: 15, and 16.

966
02:36:04.080 --> 02:36:06.150
Boardroom: Alright, there you go.

967
02:36:08.080 --> 02:36:16.249
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Caitlin Randolph, and I am the owner of Imagine It on College Avenue. Go ahead and pull it closer to you. Yeah.

968
02:36:16.600 --> 02:36:29.790
Boardroom: And I'm also a homeowner in the Elmwood neighborhood. I'm pro-housing, especially affordable housing. I want to live, raise my kids, and run my business in a vibrant and diverse neighborhood. However.

969
02:36:29.790 --> 02:36:36.729
Boardroom: I am opposed to the corridor project. This proposal will be catastrophic to the economic health of our local businesses.

970
02:36:36.730 --> 02:36:49.040

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Boardroom: We have not, as of yet, been provided any meaningful outreach, data, resources, or any sort of reassurance to local business owners about how upzoning would impact us.

971
02:36:49.070 --> 02:37:02.970
Boardroom: To think our businesses could ever survive the building which we rent being sold to corporate developers, who will have to demolish and start a years-long process of installing a mixed-use high-rise is completely out of touch with reality.

972
02:37:03.480 --> 02:37:22.630
Boardroom: The proposal itself specifies that this is not a mandate to build, and by their own estimates could take anywhere from 15 to 20 years to play out. So why are we spending so much money, time, and resources on a project that might yield results in a decade or two, when we could be making more thoughtful and strategic moves that get us housing sooner?

973
02:37:26.600 --> 02:37:39.950
Boardroom: I understand that this proposal is a result of a measure to add more housing to high-resource areas, but could it not be argued that the reason why these areas have become so successful is directly tied to their local businesses? Yet.

974
02:37:39.950 --> 02:37:59.129
Boardroom: Me and my fellow business owners don't feel supported by our city planners, and instead, we just feel shut out of the conversation entirely. I urge us to take a pause, collaborate, and get back to the drawing board. This is Berkeley. The amount of brainpower and innovative thinking in this room alone is insane. Like, the mayor's right there.

975
02:37:59.410 --> 02:38:07.879
Boardroom: Let's use it and come up with some ideas we can all be proud of that are allâ€¦ that are in support of both housing and small businesses. Thank you.

976
02:38:09.090 --> 02:38:10.130
Boardroom: Thank you.

977
02:38:14.020 --> 02:38:16.670
Boardroom: Okay, 17, 18, 19.

978
02:38:17.650 --> 02:38:19.440
Boardroom: Alright. Okay.

979

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02:38:21.730 --> 02:38:37.979
Boardroom: Hi, Mayor Ishii and wonderful Berkeley City Council and staff and consultants. I'm a Berkeley kid. I grew up here, went to Malcolm X, went to West Campus. This used to be our cafeteria, except for it had pizza on the floor.

980
02:38:37.980 --> 02:38:51.810
Boardroom: I am a pro-housing dude. I am a pro-housing guy. I am a transit-oriented development guy. My dad was a nationally famous housing economist and planner. I have lived this stuff my entire life.

981
02:38:52.790 --> 02:39:12.470
Boardroom: I'm also interested in having housing in the right locations. We do not put tall apartment buildings in the Rose Garden. We do not put tall apartment buildings on San Pablo Park. We do not put tall apartment buildings right over here on Strawberry Creek Park. We also don'tâ€¦

982
02:39:12.470 --> 02:39:24.850
Boardroom: Put tall apartment buildings in the middle of a contiguous, two-block-long street of precious 19-teens to 1930s glassy shop fronts that are robust.

983
02:39:24.850 --> 02:39:40.300
Boardroom: That are occupied by thriving businesses. And we don't jack them up by putting some giant, crazy apartments in the middle and ruining, as one of the other speakers said, a beautiful amenity that people travel from all over the region to come to.

984
02:39:40.300 --> 02:39:42.150
Boardroom: And that is what will happen.

985
02:39:44.250 --> 02:39:46.639
Boardroom: Iâ€¦ I have to say thatâ€¦

986
02:39:47.500 --> 02:39:51.189
Boardroom: Even more importantly than all of those strong feelings.

987
02:39:51.580 --> 02:39:56.200
Boardroom: about, you know, place and about the built environment. There's alsoâ€¦

988
02:39:56.980 --> 02:40:09.579

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Boardroom: as a Berkeley native, as somebody who went to Berkeley High and heard people talk about democracy, who heard people talk about citizen participation, we live in the birthplace of free speech.

989
02:40:10.950 --> 02:40:15.160
Boardroom: This process is so far engaged inâ€¦ with developers.

990
02:40:15.600 --> 02:40:26.250
Boardroom: This process has engaged with paid consultants, well-meaning, no doubt, but paid consultants, and we were funneled into a process that literally had us

991
02:40:26.620 --> 02:40:43.919
Boardroom: putting yellow and blue stickers on predetermined choices in so-called workshops. We were asked to fill out surveys, which also had predetermined choices on them toward outcomes that were either, you know, do you want your broccoli on a blue plate or a green plate?

992
02:40:44.550 --> 02:40:47.160
Boardroom: This is not democracy.

993
02:40:49.840 --> 02:40:55.229
Boardroom: I love, I love, love, love what the woman from theâ€¦

994
02:40:55.600 --> 02:40:58.340
Boardroom: Cheese Board brought up about, you know.

995
02:40:58.340 --> 02:41:17.530
Boardroom: the history of collective action, the history of talking to each other, the history of working together. We need that here. We need that. That's what you folks were brought in as representatives of your constituencies and your neighborhoods to do, is engage with people, not just take the paid consultants and the planning staff.

996
02:41:17.600 --> 02:41:32.979
Boardroom: the nice, large planning staff, and take their recommendations and go with that. With that in mind, I would like to make a motion, or have you guys make a motion on behalf of the beautiful Save Berkeley Shops Consortium and community.

997
02:41:33.940 --> 02:41:51.849
Boardroom: This is Berkeley, California, one of the smartest communities in the world, birthplace of the free speech movement. We can do better than this, and that's why we're here. To ask you, our elected leaders, to

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right this wrong. We ask that you hit the pause button and engage with us by adopting the following motion.

998
02:41:52.360 --> 02:42:00.760
Boardroom: City staff and consultants, excuse me, 1. City staff and consultants shall pause development in the corridor's zoning update.

999
02:42:01.250 --> 02:42:03.779
Boardroom: Two, the planning department shall

1000
02:42:03.780 --> 02:42:26.640
Boardroom: mail notices of its current proposals and future proposals to all businesses within the three quarters and all residents within 1,000 feet. And three, most importantly, City Planning and Economic Development Department shall engage corridor businesses and residents in a collaborative analysis on ways we can increase housing in these neighborhoods without displacing existing businesses. Thank you.

1001
02:42:31.820 --> 02:42:37.890
Boardroom: Okay, Iâ€¦ Folks, I wannaâ€¦ I wantâ€¦ Excuse me!

1002
02:42:38.020 --> 02:42:50.489
Boardroom: I just want to remind folks that there is no action being taken today. This is a workshop, so we're receiving information, so we're not taking any votes, just so you understand. Okay, go ahead, next person.

1003
02:42:54.170 --> 02:42:57.359
Boardroom: Hi, good evening, Council. Hi, everybody.

1004
02:42:57.720 --> 02:43:00.760
Boardroom: Delighted to be in your company. Thank you.

1005
02:43:02.710 --> 02:43:09.740
Boardroom: Four minutes. My name is Amy Thomas, I'm the owner of Pegasus Books. I have two stores in Berkeley and one in Oakland.

1006
02:43:09.960 --> 02:43:28.440
Boardroom: Just for the record, our store is operated in the Solano Avenue location for 42 years, our Shattuck store for nearly 30 years, and our oldest store has been in Oakland for 56 years. What we are asking you to do is pause this decision so we can have some time to really discuss the implications of it.

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1007
02:43:28.440 --> 02:43:38.390
Boardroom: No one from the city has reached out to me for my input, not, you know, whatever. Sending an email out of Zoom doesn't cover it, since the implications are so great.

1008
02:43:38.480 --> 02:43:52.380
Boardroom: Having a meeting that turns out to be a presentation by people who have already sold themselves on the zoning change is not getting input. What I see is the city giving permission for building owners and developers to build taller buildings, and it will be a gold rush.

1009
02:43:52.900 --> 02:43:56.660
Boardroom: With only vague offers of oversight and community input.

1010
02:43:58.020 --> 02:44:04.170
Boardroom: I see no vision for what this will actually look like. Will it be independent stores, larger national chains?

1011
02:44:05.040 --> 02:44:09.359
Boardroom: If you want to fill up a lot of little expensive spaces with retail, who have you got?

1012
02:44:13.440 --> 02:44:37.600
Boardroom: There's no vision, whatever, except what the developers come up with, and they have only one goal, and that is to maximize their profits. And they will say anything now to get what they want. I offer you a few examples of what has happened when the City Council demonstrates both recklessness and naivete when it comes to city planning. In 2001, the Gaia building was put up with the promise of making a community space with the input from the Gaia bookstore.

1013
02:44:37.800 --> 02:44:55.729
Boardroom: The bookstore did notâ€¦ the building went up, the bookstore did not survive the recession, the space did not materialize, but the building is called Gaia. In 2002, the Fine Arts Theater on Shattuck was evicted, and the building was torn down. The developer there promised that the theater would move back in.

1014
02:44:55.770 --> 02:45:15.729
Boardroom: But it didn't. No fine arts theater, but the building is the Fine Arts Building. So, on both Centerâ€¦ we don't have to talk about Center Street and Harold Way, but it's dismaying. Myâ€¦ one of my stores is at the corner of Shattuck and Durant, and I'm just dismayed by the mess. It's a right mess down there, guys. On Solano Avenue.

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1015
02:45:16.010 --> 02:45:28.149
Boardroom: Oaks Theater was sold and left empty and boarded up for 10 years. A huge drain on my business. When that theater closed, my business dropped 20%. It took years to get that back.

1016
02:45:28.960 --> 02:45:45.869
Boardroom: These are the people you were living the vision to. I am so disappointed that you keep going down this road of getting involved with these developâ€¦ for-profit developers for a tiny amount of actual affordable housing. Like, what's a creative solution? How aboutâ€¦

1017
02:45:45.870 --> 02:45:55.459
Boardroom: A lot of smaller buildings built in conjunction with non-profit developers with 100% affordable housing.

1018
02:45:56.110 --> 02:46:02.699
Boardroom: priorâ€¦ It required developers to offer apartments that, say, my employees could afford.

1019
02:46:02.700 --> 02:46:20.849
Boardroom: Will you require them to create affordable commercial spaces on the ground floor? Do you know how congested Solano Avenue is currently? Do you know that there have been two traffic fatalities on Upper Solano in the last few years? Do you know how many years it takes to bring a retail business to profitability and keep it there?

1020
02:46:21.210 --> 02:46:23.430
Boardroom: We have been through the wars.

1021
02:46:23.770 --> 02:46:25.750
Boardroom: as retailers.

1022
02:46:26.190 --> 02:46:30.779
Boardroom: It's hard. The scars are there. We're fragile.

1023
02:46:31.180 --> 02:46:36.369
Boardroom: Business is up now, but it's, oh my god, I don't have fingernails because of this.

1024
02:46:38.150 --> 02:46:42.300
Boardroom: I don't know if you know specifically what it costs the retail sector to get through the plague.

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1025
02:46:43.010 --> 02:46:52.340
Boardroom: We are asking you to delay this decision until real vision is laid out, and not at the busiest time of the year, fourth quarter. Thank you.

1026
02:46:57.310 --> 02:46:58.580
Boardroom: Thank you.

1027
02:47:06.840 --> 02:47:15.060
Boardroom: Hello, hello to all of you. I'm Sue Johnson of Sue Johnson Custom Limbs and Shades.

1028
02:47:17.230 --> 02:47:23.390
Boardroom: on Solana Avenue, on the corner of Ensenada, which is one of the targeted buildings.

1029
02:47:24.430 --> 02:47:26.619
Boardroom: I'm so glad to be here tonight.

1030
02:47:27.380 --> 02:47:28.839
Boardroom: To hear from you.

1031
02:47:29.460 --> 02:47:33.340
Boardroom: Because I haven't heard anything before.

1032
02:47:34.450 --> 02:47:37.209
Boardroom: And my heart is just sinking.

1033
02:47:37.540 --> 02:47:40.160
Boardroom: Butâ€¦ I love what I do.

1034
02:47:40.760 --> 02:47:43.379
Boardroom: I'd love to share my ideas with you.

1035
02:47:43.840 --> 02:47:47.339
Boardroom: As you've been sharing your ideas with me tonight.

1036
02:47:49.210 --> 02:47:54.860
Boardroom: The Solana Stroll was started by three of us, on Solano.

1037

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02:47:56.020 --> 02:47:57.639
Boardroom: In the mid-70s.

1038
02:47:58.210 --> 02:48:01.070
Boardroom: I'veâ€¦ my shop has been there

1039
02:48:01.540 --> 02:48:09.480
Boardroom: for 53 years. And the Solana Stroll brings 250,000 people

1040
02:48:09.760 --> 02:48:18.830
Boardroom: Sorry, I can't see who's talking. Okay, thank you. 250,000 people to Solano.

1041
02:48:19.590 --> 02:48:23.990
Boardroom: And that is a vibrant, lively group of people.

1042
02:48:27.110 --> 02:48:36.900
Boardroom: I do aâ€¦ for the stroll, I do aâ€¦ Treasure Hunt.

1043
02:48:38.040 --> 02:48:43.939
Boardroom: And I have over 250 people who come in and fill out a form to do the treasure hunt.

1044
02:48:44.530 --> 02:48:45.930
Boardroom: Tiny children.

1045
02:48:47.120 --> 02:48:49.490
Boardroom: and adults. We're a community.

1046
02:48:50.970 --> 02:48:53.429
Boardroom: You and I are a community, too.

1047
02:48:53.930 --> 02:48:58.899
Boardroom: And I want to be with you in community. I want to hear more.

1048
02:48:59.100 --> 02:49:00.890
Boardroom: about alternatives.

1049
02:49:01.490 --> 02:49:10.699
Boardroom: An 8-story high building on Solano is just a dead space. We don't need dead spaces. We need spaces that are alive.

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1050
02:49:10.900 --> 02:49:16.599
Boardroom: And I want to study that with you. I want to share my ideas, and I want to hear yours.

1051
02:49:16.780 --> 02:49:18.730
Boardroom: Thank you.

1052
02:49:25.790 --> 02:49:27.860
Boardroom: 23 and 24, please.

1053
02:49:28.620 --> 02:49:30.420
Boardroom: 23 and 24?

1054
02:49:30.570 --> 02:49:33.080
Boardroom: It's 23 still, okay, 25.

1055
02:49:33.320 --> 02:49:36.839
Boardroom: I think it's 23 and 24, so we're stillâ€¦ we're 23 and 24.

1056
02:49:37.770 --> 02:49:43.829
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Fern Solomon, and I am the owner of Fern's Garden on Solano Avenue.

1057
02:49:44.030 --> 02:49:44.940
Boardroom: I amâ€¦

1058
02:49:45.140 --> 02:49:50.430
Boardroom: I am also the new chair and commissioner for the City of Berkeley for the Solano Avenue bid.

1059
02:49:50.800 --> 02:50:04.169
Boardroom: and a member of the Solano Avenue Association. Today, I am speaking for myself and my business. I chose Upper Solano 9 years ago to build my business because of the walkable charm of the street.

1060
02:50:04.230 --> 02:50:13.800
Boardroom: We feel very lucky to have a store on Upper Solano. Our customers are totally devoted and come from every part of Berkeley.

1061
02:50:13.800 --> 02:50:25.790

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Boardroom: And beyond. It's amazing how far they come. I've become a destination store here in Berkeley. Recently, I have been completely overwhelmed

1062
02:50:25.790 --> 02:50:41.789
Boardroom: by my customers, because they're so upset about the upzoning proposals. They are concerned that their neighborhood will be turned into something that's completely unrecognizable. They love the century-old charm of the street.

1063
02:50:42.260 --> 02:50:48.070
Boardroom: When Pete's closed down last month for just 3 weeks, to remodel.

1064
02:50:48.220 --> 02:50:58.990
Boardroom: all the businesses around me took quite a big dip in sales. Our sales have been doing terrific. Pete's closed down, the trucks lined the street.

1065
02:50:59.110 --> 02:51:11.149
Boardroom: I am very concerned about construction on our narrow street on Solano Avenue. I can't even imagine how it could happen, andâ€¦

1066
02:51:11.730 --> 02:51:20.370
Boardroom: I'm so happy to be here tonight, and I can't believe the community outreach. Thank you guys so much for coming.

1067
02:51:20.520 --> 02:51:25.100
Boardroom: It's so hard to make a small business work.

1068
02:51:25.340 --> 02:51:34.439
Boardroom: And I have somehow created a business, 2,000 little square feet, that attracts people from all over the world now.

1069
02:51:34.550 --> 02:51:47.859
Boardroom: And I'm on the board for Visit Berkeley, and I'm working hard to create a more permanent vision so that people who visit Berkeley can visit all the independent shops with a map, with a way toâ€¦

1070
02:51:47.860 --> 02:52:02.500
Boardroom: to help people understand that there are so many incredible Pegasus, Sioux, I mean, we have amazing people that have been here for a long, long time. Thank you so much for all you guys do, I really appreciate it.

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1071
02:52:03.950 --> 02:52:05.270
Boardroom: Thank you, Fern.

1072
02:52:12.790 --> 02:52:24.990
Boardroom: Thanks. Good evening. I'm, William Torsiana, and I live by the College Avenue corridor. Given that I have 54 seconds, I'll keep it short and just make, 3 quick points.

1073
02:52:25.130 --> 02:52:36.510
Boardroom: First of all, the College Avenue corridor is one of the most vibrant and diverse in Berkeley. It represents an enormous value for the city, and we'd be absolutely foolish to wreck it.

1074
02:52:36.790 --> 02:52:40.190
Boardroom: Second, I disagree strongly with Mr. Klein.

1075
02:52:40.380 --> 02:52:53.639
Boardroom: Once you start ripping at the fabric of a low-scale, architecturally cohesive area like this, the impacts happen very, very quickly, and not over decades. And once you lose a neighborhood like this, you don't get it back.

1076
02:52:54.180 --> 02:53:08.239
Boardroom: Third, the meeting materials clearly show already that the College Avenue corridor is heavily oriented towards rental housing, primarily younger tenants. There are 100 empty apartments on Zillow on College Avenue as of this morning.

1077
02:53:08.260 --> 02:53:18.199
Boardroom: We absolutely need to address housing affordability, but you don't do it by destroying a commercial district and giving it away to the real estate industry. Thank you.

1078
02:53:24.850 --> 02:53:29.680
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Nancy Fasher, I live off of Solano, and thank you all for your service.

1079
02:53:29.680 --> 02:53:54.330
Boardroom: My comments tonight are focused on Solano. I'm not really, suited to speak for the other neighborhoods. I've been a homeowner for 31 years. I'm a social worker, married to a lifelong BUSD teacher, and I've had the privilege of raising my children in Berkeley. Unfortunately, they

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can't afford to live here, and I really strongly believe we have to increase the housing stock as one solution to a very complex

1080
02:53:54.330 --> 02:54:19.099
Boardroom: complex problem. We do know that increasing supply does show a modest impact on housing prices. Just like the neighbors who live around Solano, we all read that article about Thousand Oaks, Solano itself has aged in place. Buildings are old, the foot traffic is down, and as a result, we have lost many cherished small businesses that can't afford to make ends meet. There's an ever-increasing number of vacant storefronts. I'm in favor of the higher density that will

1081
02:54:19.100 --> 02:54:26.900
Boardroom: allow businesses to thrive. And, of course, our shops will need care and attention during the transition, which will happen

1082
02:54:27.390 --> 02:54:29.220
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you.

1083
02:54:33.830 --> 02:54:45.540
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Glenn Wokenfeld. I'm 63 years old, I'm a Berkeley homeowner, and I live 2 blocks north of Solano Avenue. I spent 27 years as a science teacher at Berkeley High School.

1084
02:54:45.540 --> 02:55:09.779
Boardroom: Democracy is about electing people who can make wise decisions, and that's what we've done. So I'm hoping that you have the courage to know that many of us support upzoning. We do have to take care of our local businesses 100%, but for anyone who opposes upzoning in the Solano corridor, try this. On a Saturday night at about 9pm, go to the corner of Solano

1085
02:55:09.780 --> 02:55:32.149
Boardroom: and Colusa, and you can lie down in the middle of the street. Nobody is there. Solano's dying. It's the central corridor that only worksâ€¦ central corridor of a retirement home that only works for privileged old folks. We need more foot traffic. Let him finish his comments. Because of our anti-zoning history, my adult children

1086
02:55:32.150 --> 02:55:37.650
Boardroom: We can't live here. We need more housing to lower prices. Thank you. Thank you. Thanks.

1087
02:55:37.850 --> 02:55:56.890

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Boardroom: Just want to make sure folks know it's not safe to lie down in the middle of the street. Your point is taken, but justâ€¦ just to kind of put that out there. Thank you, though, for your comment. Please just be safe on the streets. Okay, go ahead. I've got a minute fromâ€¦ A minute from this person over here. Okay. Someone waving. On the far right. Okay.

1088
02:55:57.500 --> 02:56:07.129
Boardroom: Good evening, my name is Todd Darling, I live in District 3, where we have been dealing with upzoning for years. I would like to talk about our future, and about where we're going.

1089
02:56:07.900 --> 02:56:18.350
Boardroom: First, we should recognize whence this plan emanates, Berkeley's Planning Department. Salaries for this department come from developer fees. The citizens of Berkeley do not pay their salaries.

1090
02:56:18.750 --> 02:56:34.219
Boardroom: The biggest lobby backing up zoning is YIMBY. Yes, in my backyard. Ostensibly organized to promote housing, this is not a grassroots organization. YIMBY funding comes from big tech founders of Facebook, Yelp, Stripe, and venture capitalists like Ron Conway.

1091
02:56:34.560 --> 02:56:48.190
Boardroom: They will not engage in questions of who the housing is for, where it is built, or how it is built, and if it is affordable. These vital questions are ignored and insulted. IMBI's prime product is displacement.

1092
02:56:49.250 --> 02:57:08.749
Boardroom: And they have a lot of money to do it. As of 2023, various YIMBY California organizations have $20 million in assets, with revenues of over $8 million. Their CEO earned $333,000, and local director Matthew Lewis earned $153,000. These figures are from their tax reports.

1093
02:57:09.080 --> 02:57:23.730
Boardroom: YIMBY believes in trickle-down economics, a theory just proven back in the Reagan administration. They believe in deregulation of industry, and deregulation is evident in this upzoning plan. They don't care what developers build or where they do it.

1094
02:57:24.150 --> 02:57:43.930
Boardroom: And Berkeley has obliged them. Thousands of new units, but the units are too small for families, most of the buildings appear half-empty, and the rents are definitely not affordable. YIMBY is a political project, and YIMBY cash has flooded California politics. Our current

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state senator, our current assembly member, all received their endorsements and their money.

1095
02:57:44.040 --> 02:58:01.740
Boardroom: Our former mayor, our current mayor received their endorsements. Two current city council members have long career YIMBY endorsements and regularly attend their events. A lot of us feel like this came out of nowhere. This is a setup. Thanks for your comments.

1096
02:58:09.010 --> 02:58:10.280
Boardroom: Next personâ€¦

1097
02:58:20.130 --> 02:58:45.079
Boardroom: I've been waiting for a couple of minutes. I'm just waiting for my minutes. Wait, wait, we did 25â€¦ I had 25 already, butâ€¦ I thought we had 25 already, no? Jane? Did you not give your minute? Okay, alright, alright, 25, 26, 7, so you'll haveâ€¦ so you'll have 4 minutes, then. 25, 26, 27? 3. I'm gonna go for 3, throw in 4â€¦

1098
02:58:45.080 --> 02:59:04.290
Boardroom: I need them. Okay, 25 and 26. Okay, go ahead. My name is Claudia Hunka, I am the owner of Your Basic Bird. I've never lived in the Elmwood, but I've grown up in the Elmwood, because my business has been there for 44 years. I support housing that is in scale with commercial districts.

1099
02:59:04.290 --> 02:59:08.980
Boardroom: The proposed plan would disfigure our historic neighborhood corridors.

1100
02:59:08.980 --> 02:59:19.819
Boardroom: displace independent merchants, and forever alter the character of Berkeley. This plan was created without any study of the economic and social impacts

1101
02:59:19.820 --> 02:59:42.910
Boardroom: on the businesses, many in the Elmwood, who have been serving this neighborhood for 25 to 50 years. The loss of any business impacts an entire commercial district. We share customers. We all lose customers, even when one business closes. What about the loss of the jobs of over 400-plus employees in the Elmwood, not included?

1102
02:59:42.910 --> 02:59:43.910
Boardroom: Not including me.

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1103
02:59:43.910 --> 03:00:02.560
Boardroom: other areas. In two months, the Elmwood merchants and residents have collected over a thousand signatures in opposition to the upzoning. Minor changes in the zoning in these corridors could allow for housing without creating 6 to 11-story buildings.

1104
03:00:02.560 --> 03:00:17.140
Boardroom: Meaningful conversation or consideration for the businesses that will be impacted by these proposals has not occurred. Options and other considerations are not possible without this communication. We urge the city to engage

1105
03:00:17.140 --> 03:00:39.409
Boardroom: directly with local merchants and residents in each corridor to create responsible, balanced zoning that promotes housing without destroying local businesses. Studio Session, Sense by the Bay, Mihero, Pretty Penny, Old Salt Merchants, Worthy, Elmwood Laundry, Palmese, Imagine It, Casa de Chocolate.

1106
03:00:39.410 --> 03:00:44.569
Boardroom: State Flower Shop, Elmwood Copy. These representâ€¦

1107
03:00:44.700 --> 03:01:04.310
Boardroom: These are new businesses that are just investing their lives in the Elmwood. They represent everything that makes Berkeley unique, creativity, diversity, and community connection. I want to see them grow up in the Elmwood, and have the same potential which I have had.

1108
03:01:04.330 --> 03:01:11.369
Boardroom: I ask everyone in the audience who is opposed to this to please hold up their signs.

1109
03:01:11.720 --> 03:01:26.420
Boardroom: Mayor Ishii, and Council Members, we request that you please pause this and engage with us.

1110
03:01:27.510 --> 03:01:42.550
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you for your time. Oh, I have 20 more minutes. Anybody else want to talk? 20 more seconds, sorry. Counting was never a high. Thank you.

1111
03:01:42.930 --> 03:01:43.930
Boardroom: Okay.

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1112
03:01:50.300 --> 03:02:09.769
Boardroom: Good eveningâ€¦ oh, am I ready? Good evening, and thank you. My name is Alice Giroux. I moved to Berkeley in 1975 to go to architecture school, and I'm still here. I live in District 3, and I shop in all three of the, commercial areas, but most often the Elmwood, because it's closest to where I live.

1113
03:02:10.110 --> 03:02:25.790
Boardroom: As many other people have said, Berkeley's neighbourhood commercial districts are a treasure. They are thriving, they're busy every day of the week, with unique small businesses that are a key part of Berkeley's economic health and cultural vibrancy.

1114
03:02:26.010 --> 03:02:29.719
Boardroom: In contrast, look at our downtown, once bustling.

1115
03:02:29.980 --> 03:02:37.459
Boardroom: Now with much of it cleared out and empty, waiting for mega-housing projects that may take years to come.

1116
03:02:37.460 --> 03:02:53.139
Boardroom: Deregulation and upzoning for market rate units is not a housing solution. It will not guarantee affordable housing, but it may very well kill small businesses. And by the way, there is literally an ADU in my backyard.

1117
03:02:53.140 --> 03:02:54.919
Boardroom: Thank you.

1118
03:02:59.280 --> 03:03:00.010
Boardroom: Come thumbs!

1119
03:03:01.800 --> 03:03:03.870
Boardroom: Nope, 2 minutes for the bus.

1120
03:03:04.240 --> 03:03:23.690
Boardroom: Sorry, soâ€¦ This is my husband? Is he gonna give you his minute? Yes. Okay, so yeah, so you'll have 2 minutes then. Go ahead. Hello, I'm Renee Coppolis, and this is my husband, Edwin Gamez. We own Elmwood Laundry in the Elmwood, and as Claudia mentioned, we are new business owners. We, invested our savings

1121
03:03:23.710 --> 03:03:31.560

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Boardroom: That we've worked for, to buy the laundromat, in 2021â€¦ 2022.

1122
03:03:31.650 --> 03:03:47.149
Boardroom: And we have a lot of customers, like Claudia and other people have mentioned too, our businesses are all codependent. Most of our customers, if not all, are also customers of everyone else in our neighborhood's businesses.

1123
03:03:47.170 --> 03:03:53.799
Boardroom: a large portion of the community in the Elmwood also do not have longer,

1124
03:03:54.010 --> 03:04:00.510
Boardroom: Washers and dryers in their homes, and they use the laundromat on a weekly or even more often basis.

1125
03:04:00.660 --> 03:04:12.080
Boardroom: And, we are just devastated because this project will, as our council member said, will be mortal to us, to our business.

1126
03:04:12.220 --> 03:04:30.500
Boardroom: And I think that once theâ€¦ if the upzoning project goes through, it actually will be mortal to the Elmwood in general as well. It's never going to be the same historic, charming neighborhood that it is today. And it's sad to know that

1127
03:04:30.710 --> 03:04:38.960
Boardroom: we are such a wonderful destination. People from the outer community come, visit the Elmwood, they do the laundry at our laundromat.

1128
03:04:38.960 --> 03:04:57.309
Boardroom: We met a person from Fremont who came with her husband this weekend, and they spent the whole day in Yalmwood shopping, doing laundry, eating, and, you know, they comeâ€¦ we have customers from the city, from San Francisco, who eitherâ€¦ they come out here to work or do other things, and they want to,

1129
03:04:57.310 --> 03:05:07.610
Boardroom: enjoy what we have, because it doesn't exist anywhere else anymore, and it's very important to preserve. And by not going through with this project, our neighborhood will be preserved.

1130
03:05:09.270 --> 03:05:10.719
Boardroom: Thank you.

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1131
03:05:20.390 --> 03:05:21.980
Boardroom: Hi,

1132
03:05:22.160 --> 03:05:29.650
Boardroom: One minute. Can you just talk in the mic? One minute to talk about protecting a unique

1133
03:05:29.950 --> 03:05:33.520
Boardroom: And wonderful commercial shopping center.

1134
03:05:33.720 --> 03:05:35.180
Boardroom: Cold Elmwood.

1135
03:05:35.650 --> 03:05:41.349
Boardroom: I think that's a metaphor for what's been going on recently with this project.

1136
03:05:41.540 --> 03:05:51.299
Boardroom: One minute, and I know the time constraints, but one minute to talk about protecting a 100-year-old, thriving commercial district.

1137
03:05:52.790 --> 03:06:02.070
Boardroom: I want to be a little pragmatic. Everyone's said many things, and I agree with almost everything. But the one thing is, we're talking about 80 units.

1138
03:06:02.210 --> 03:06:07.519
Boardroom: Based on discussions, with the, with the CETI staff.

1139
03:06:07.890 --> 03:06:11.449
Boardroom: 80 units, and you could destroy the Elmwood.

1140
03:06:11.830 --> 03:06:23.579
Boardroom: for the future. We talk about children. And first of all, housingâ€¦ housing is absolutely critical. But we want to preserve the Elmwood for the fuâ€¦ for children of the future.

1141
03:06:23.940 --> 03:06:25.280
Boardroom: Thank you.

1142

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03:06:32.740 --> 03:06:43.699
Boardroom: Hello, my name is Arnold Mamrella. I live in the Solano Avenue area. I'm an architect and an urban planning consultant. I work for several cities in the Bay Area on these type of projects, among other housing things.

1143
03:06:43.700 --> 03:06:53.490
Boardroom: And what I want to say is, first of all, all three of these districts are different, they should be approached differently to what works for each district. I think that's a big point that's notâ€¦

1144
03:06:53.490 --> 03:06:54.689
Boardroom: Been talked about yet.

1145
03:06:54.810 --> 03:07:13.469
Boardroom: The other thing I want to say is we've got to see what we can get out of this. We need more imagination, more nuance, more creativity. There's something missing here in this process. It's not a choice between 8-story buildings with small apartments, or nothing. We need to find another way. We need to look for better examples, like.

1146
03:07:13.470 --> 03:07:27.059
Boardroom: like Market Hall in Rockbridge. Look at that project. Look at it on Google closely. Look how the upper floors were actually, you can't even tell, there's a village up there. They're small offices, but they were originally planned as possibly housing units.

1147
03:07:27.540 --> 03:07:41.260
Boardroom: We need to think differently, and in a minute I can't go over everything. Also, one more thing, we need to keep more than 35% of theâ€¦ Thank you. Thanks for your comment. I'm sorry your time's up. Thank you. So, just so I have a sense, Iâ€¦

1148
03:07:41.790 --> 03:07:56.889
Boardroom: If you are not making public comment, if you're finished with your public comment, can you please sit down or move away from this wall? Because I'm trying to keep track of how many people are here, and I think the line gets a little confusing. Okay, and then also, if you are still making a comment, can you just give meâ€¦ raise your hand?

1149
03:07:57.160 --> 03:08:01.199
Boardroom: So I can see. If you'reâ€¦ are folks in the back here making comments?

1150
03:08:01.890 --> 03:08:07.660

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Boardroom: Woman in the blue hat? Okay, could you sit down or move away from the line, please? Because I think it's confusing aboutâ€¦

1151
03:08:07.880 --> 03:08:12.219
Boardroom: So, none of these people here, no one here is past the doors making a comment?

1152
03:08:13.790 --> 03:08:20.279
Boardroom: No. Okay, so, Brandon, you're the last one. No? There's somebody here?

1153
03:08:20.410 --> 03:08:24.660
Boardroom: Sure, that's fine. Okay, so where is your spot in line?

1154
03:08:25.730 --> 03:08:28.849
Boardroom: No, you don't have to stand, I'm just curious whereâ€¦ sorry, where are you?

1155
03:08:29.160 --> 03:08:36.899
Boardroom: After Brandon. Okay, there's someone, and Kelly's after that. Okay.

1156
03:08:37.210 --> 03:08:42.549
Boardroom: All right. I think I'm clear. Patrick, are you getting in line right now? Okay.

1157
03:08:42.950 --> 03:08:49.730
Boardroom: Okay, so there are two people in front of you, and then Brandon, and then Patrick, and thenâ€¦ anyone else?

1158
03:08:51.280 --> 03:08:53.270
Boardroom: Okay. Yeah.

1159
03:08:53.620 --> 03:09:00.129
Boardroom: Alright, go ahead, sorry, I'm just trying to get a clear sense ofâ€¦ I'm trying to figure out breaks, and we have online comments, so go ahead.

1160
03:09:00.290 --> 03:09:10.879
Boardroom: Hi, my name is Jacob Dadman. I live in District 3, and I'm here to ask the city to fulfill its legal obligation to affirmatively further fair housing byâ€¦

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1161
03:09:11.400 --> 03:09:29.510
Boardroom: alternative to in the corridor zoning plan. Putting more affordable homes in Berkeley's most exclusive, historically red-lined neighborhoods is not only good for our economy, but it's the right thing to do. I love my neighbors, and I want more of them.

1162
03:09:29.530 --> 03:09:49.179
Boardroom: And I think that apartments are good, actually. And when we put people closer to where they want to be and where they want to go, that means fewer cars on our roads, less carbon and air pollutants in our air, and more vibrant and vital neighborhoods that are not only

1163
03:09:49.200 --> 03:10:03.230
Boardroom: up with the times, but can be resilient to future changes. So I appreciate, everyone's comments here, but I would really love to see Alternative 2, not only on the corridors, but also in the streets adjoining. Thank you. Thank you.

1164
03:10:13.060 --> 03:10:37.270
Boardroom: Hello, Ms. Sorry, Ms. Mayor and members of the City Council. My name is Karina Holbrook, I'm a Berkeley resident, and I often shop at Elmwood, and I'm speaking to express my support for upzoting and for Berkeley's commitment for racial equality. I'm Japanese American, my mother is Japanese, I grew up part of my life in Japan, and someone like me, and when Elwood and Solana were created in 1931, I wouldn't have been able to rent a unit, I wouldn't have been able to buy a unit.

1165
03:10:37.270 --> 03:10:40.009
Boardroom: Just solely because of my race, nothing of who I am.

1166
03:10:40.010 --> 03:10:55.590
Boardroom: That's shameful, but we are making steps towards fixing it, and I commend the City Council for being brave and envisioning a better future. I fully support the proposed upzoning, and I encourage the City Council to think bigger, to allow for six doors everywhere, prioritize transit-oriented development, and build more housing.

1167
03:10:55.590 --> 03:11:12.629
Boardroom: That being said, I also support protecting small businesses and expanding commercial spaces. Small spaces are often more affordable, so I encourage this council to allow for commercial businesses at all intersections and reduce city fees for new and existing businesses. Let's build housing today for a better Berkeley tomorrow. Thank you.

1168
03:11:12.660 --> 03:11:13.660

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Boardroom: Thank you!

1169
03:11:17.630 --> 03:11:19.510
Boardroom: Okay, next person, please.

1170
03:11:23.560 --> 03:11:37.500
Boardroom: Good evening, Council. Good evening, everyone. My name is Jewel Ewer, and I'm the owner of Bill's Trading Post. My family's business, I'm the fourth generation, we've been in the same location for over 85 years.

1171
03:11:37.630 --> 03:11:40.130
Boardroom: and historic Elmwood District.

1172
03:11:41.430 --> 03:11:58.549
Boardroom: I am speaking today on a lot ofâ€¦ everyone has touched mostly on all the points that, about the zoning and how all that isâ€¦ it'sâ€¦ we didn't really get any information about that, but I would like to touch base on, the historical charm of that place.

1173
03:11:58.550 --> 03:12:07.590
Boardroom: The proposed construction project threatens not only the character of our charming neighborhood area, but also the livelihood of all the small businesses.

1174
03:12:07.920 --> 03:12:20.690
Boardroom: That makes this community unique. This project will bring a significant congestion to an already very congested area. College and Ashby, if you've ever driven down there, or even tried to walk, it's just, it's heavily trafficked.

1175
03:12:20.860 --> 03:12:30.250
Boardroom: People would struggle, or you'd just avoid going to the area during a construction period, which can last many years. Thank you. Excuse me.

1176
03:12:37.060 --> 03:12:41.640
Boardroom: Just hoping to get two or three hands from the audience. One, twoâ€¦

1177
03:12:41.740 --> 03:12:53.930
Boardroom: 25, 26. Sorry, wait, wait, no, we were, we did 25 and 26, so we're at 27. Sorry, 27, 28. 27, 28? Where's 28? Okay, thank you. Alright, go ahead. Thank you.

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1178
03:12:58.400 --> 03:13:14.669
Boardroom: I'll be honest, I hate coming to these meetings. I hate the stink eye from my council member, and I see you yimbies laughing over there while people like me bleed our hearts out. You sit there smiling while the businesses, the workers, and neighbors who build this city are fighting to stay.

1179
03:13:14.930 --> 03:13:22.660
Boardroom: We show up month after month because we still care, because we still love Berkeley, even when you don't act like you do.

1180
03:13:22.830 --> 03:13:42.019
Boardroom: I'm here because I love Telegraph. We are the canary in the coal mine. When Telegraph struggles, Berkeley's soul is in danger. From those stupid Lyft bikes, from YIMBY, Smart Ike Kiosks, to Blackstone Real Estate Development, to the destruction of over 100 mature trees, 30 years of topsoil at People's Park.

1181
03:13:42.020 --> 03:13:54.300
Boardroom: They always attack us first, the ones living 200% below the poverty line. And tonight, I'm the ghost of Christmas past, and I'll tell you what, Santa is pissed.

1182
03:13:54.610 --> 03:14:04.209
Boardroom: I love this city, I love the small businesses, I love working with Food Not Bombs, and Nabalone and Cheeseboard are here, who help us give meals to our community.

1183
03:14:04.210 --> 03:14:26.699
Boardroom: Thanks. I stand with 50-year-old businesses you've swept away, though, like trash for your housing progress, Missing Link Bike Cooperative, Annapurna, Mars Buffalo Exchange. You even find Ken Sarah Ken at Mad Monks thousands of dollars because our community dared to gather and share food after you barricaded us off at People's Park.

1184
03:14:26.700 --> 03:14:33.190
Boardroom: You took away our public space, then punished a business owner for helping us create our own. Shame on you.

1185
03:14:35.000 --> 03:14:55.160
Boardroom: You raced more than 100 parking spots for those double-stacked razor-wire shipping containers and called it safety. Guess what? It's a park. People park there. Now they have to double park on Durant Avenue just to pick up DoorDash, and they're constantly being policed for it.

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People get ticketed trying to support themselves and the city, and your response?

1186
03:14:55.160 --> 03:14:56.550
Boardroom: A frickin' bus lane.

1187
03:14:56.940 --> 03:15:08.019
Boardroom: Thanks. You'd rather bulldoze telegraph for a bike lane than stand for the businesses that are feeding us, employing us, and caring for our neighbors every day.

1188
03:15:08.770 --> 03:15:28.590
Boardroom: I have no confidence in the city council. I have no confidence in Paul Buttegan, who's been fitting in the city job for over a decade. I have no confidence because you criminalize our poor, you hand our streets to multinational corporations, and you sell out my neighborhood to a multi-billion dollar war corporation called UC Berkeley.

1189
03:15:29.810 --> 03:15:42.380
Boardroom: And you gave them the right to destroy our homes, our community, through eminent domain in the Constitution of the California state. And now, I won't even have telegraph

1190
03:15:42.550 --> 03:16:02.159
Boardroom: Christmas on Telegraph. You destroyed it when you built People's Park because now we can't have a street fair. I won't be able to hear our churches singing, or kids singing, Hark the Herald Angel sings. I won't be able to work with, Games of Berkeley to give out toys because of you, but you can help these people. Thank you.

1191
03:16:02.550 --> 03:16:03.850
Boardroom: Thank you.

1192
03:16:04.110 --> 03:16:05.070
Boardroom: Okay.

1193
03:16:10.180 --> 03:16:11.980
Boardroom: Hi,

1194
03:16:12.580 --> 03:16:28.669
Boardroom: Sometimes there is a gap between the ambitions of a program and the options that staff puts in front of you. With middle housing, they recommended that you zone South Berkeley at a greater density than North Berkeley, when the whole point was to eliminate those disparities.

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1195
03:16:28.670 --> 03:16:51.810
Boardroom: you rejected that, and you equalized the density. In other words, you acted to affirmatively further fair housing. But why did staff recommend that? They didn't set out to treat different areas differently, but they followed one of the assumptions of their profession, which is that changes in land use should be gradual and not stark. That approach, when you apply it to formerly redlined areas and formerly exclusionary areas, like the Elmwood.

1196
03:16:51.810 --> 03:16:53.290
Boardroom: by definition.

1197
03:16:53.290 --> 03:17:14.109
Boardroom: reinforces those disparities. Here in these proposals, by basing it on existing commercial zones, basing the details on existing land use patterns, we are reinforcing the exclusionary policies that we are trying to get away from. It is the antithesis of affirmatively furthering fair housing. We are not treating the high resource corridors the same as South and West Berkeley. Thank you.

1198
03:17:14.110 --> 03:17:15.040
Boardroom: Thanks.

1199
03:17:15.330 --> 03:17:18.559
Boardroom: Hey, folks, no booing, please. You can clap.

1200
03:17:18.830 --> 03:17:20.499
Boardroom: But please, no booing.

1201
03:17:21.240 --> 03:17:35.490
Boardroom: Hi. I'm here to agree with what the prior speaker was saying. I am here to ask staff to include 6 storeâ€¦ ask you to ask staff to study including 6 stories of housing across the board

1202
03:17:35.770 --> 03:17:54.910
Boardroom: across all of these neighborhoods, even Stephen, Solano College, San Pablo, and North Shattuck. As myâ€¦ as the previous speaker was saying, what makes San Pablo different from North Shattuck, from Solano? Why is it a different thing? These are all corridors, it's just that one of them was formerly redlined.

1203
03:17:55.280 --> 03:18:13.659

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Boardroom: This is one of the best chances we'll have for a while to affirmatively further fair housing in our city, and to create some integration in our zoning. I ask also that you upzone adjacent streets, gradually tapering the zoning down to the rest of the neighborhood. And I ask you not to require ground floor commercial and new construction. I live on San Pablo.

1204
03:18:13.660 --> 03:18:16.530
Boardroom: And the ground floor of my building is vacant.

1205
03:18:16.530 --> 03:18:26.900
Boardroom: the people who face onto the streetâ€¦ Sorry, it was vacant, finally. Anyway, please don't require ground floor and taper the zoning. Thanks, I mean, it goes bypassed.

1206
03:18:28.680 --> 03:18:29.740
Boardroom: Okay.

1207
03:18:32.530 --> 03:18:38.429
Boardroom: Thank you. Good evening. I live 3 blocks from college in Ashby with my parents.

1208
03:18:38.540 --> 03:18:43.159
Boardroom: I'm starting to work in low-income housing, and I deeply want affordable housing in Berkeley.

1209
03:18:43.570 --> 03:18:54.480
Boardroom: But we don't get affordable housing if we don't build housing. When market rate housing isn't built, those people don't cease to exist. These richer people outbid the rest of us for housing.

1210
03:18:55.350 --> 03:19:02.110
Boardroom: If we can't be better and truly give more people opportunity, we have said more housing, and we did not act on it.

1211
03:19:02.130 --> 03:19:21.220
Boardroom: By continuing to restrict new homes, Berkeley is closing its doors to its own children and to its own grandchildren. We, the younger people in the crowd, are the future of Berkeley, and I hope this City Council builds for the future. Thank you. Thank you. Excuse you!

1212
03:19:21.310 --> 03:19:37.829

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Boardroom: Not helpful. Folksâ€¦ Security. Decorum. Go ahead. Thanks, Alan, thanks, thanks to the council. So I'm a young father, and a homeowner in Elmwood. I have aâ€¦ Hey, hey, folks, you know what?

1213
03:19:38.500 --> 03:19:39.780
Boardroom: Decorum.

1214
03:19:40.350 --> 03:19:42.749
Boardroom: You can have a conversation outside.

1215
03:19:43.790 --> 03:20:01.840
Boardroom: Okay. Thank you. So, I'm a young father, I'm a homeowner in Elmwood. I have a young daughter, one more on the way. I love the Elmwood Corridor, I shop there every week. I'm looking forward to continuing to do so and raise my family there. I would want to urge the Council to support the corridor zoning effort. We need to create more opportunities

1216
03:20:01.840 --> 03:20:10.430
Boardroom: for, people like me, and especially ones who weren't as lucky as my wife and I in our 20s to be able to live here and to raise their families here.

1217
03:20:10.430 --> 03:20:22.799
Boardroom: In this incredible city. I mean, development can absolutely be disruptive. I've, I've really, you know, learned a lot from listening to all of the folks here tonight, and we should think about how to mitigate disruption where we can.

1218
03:20:22.800 --> 03:20:39.440
Boardroom: But I urge the Council to courageously prioritize the housing opportunity here. And lastly, I'd urge folks to think about the balance of all the voices who aren't in this room. I was actually here before, I had to leave to put my daughter to bed, and then I came back, and a lot of other folks in my position just couldn't swing that tonight. So, thank you so much.

1219
03:20:40.420 --> 03:20:41.620
Boardroom: Thank you.

1220
03:20:43.180 --> 03:21:05.219
Boardroom: Okay, so just so folks know, I'd love to get through the comment in here in person, and then we're gonna take another break. I think we're gonna take a 15-minute break, because it's been a long sit. And then I know there was someone who was over here that's stillâ€¦ just so you know, don't worry, you haven't lost your spot, I justâ€¦ and Kelly

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Hammergren as well, but that's it. Okay. Go ahead. Hi, I'm Julie Noctuy, and I've lived here since 1980.

1221
03:21:05.220 --> 03:21:20.260
Boardroom: I disagree with people who say redlining happened, you know, 60 years ago, so we should punish people now, because they somehow managed to get good jobs through good education, combine those resources, and buy a home.

1222
03:21:20.260 --> 03:21:45.180
Boardroom: Around the Elmwood. I think that the City Council should think outside the box, and not think that families are gonna be happy living for their entire lives in 6 to 8 to 12-story buildings. We might think about the woman who suggested having smaller units with, like, maybe 4 units, and place them other places so that the people who live in those units can feel that there's a community of their own, not just taking the elevator up and

1223
03:21:45.180 --> 03:22:04.910
Boardroom: down the 12-story building. So I think that we should also think about the city making some job efforts to educate people, give them job training so that they can afford to rent anything, because if they don't have some kind of income, they're not going to be able to afford anything. Thank you.

1224
03:22:05.940 --> 03:22:06.730
Boardroom: Okay.

1225
03:22:13.490 --> 03:22:24.379
Boardroom: Good evening, everyone. My name's Rebecca. I'm a worker in the North Shattuck neighborhood. We've been hearing a lot from business owners tonight, and much less, I think, from the workers, so I want to speak on behalf of

1226
03:22:24.380 --> 03:22:47.520
Boardroom: workers. Workers at these businesses can barely afford to live in Berkeley, much less in the high-resource neighborhoods that we're talking about tonight. As business owners, if you want to keep your workers, you've got two options. Pay us more, or help us lower the cost of housing. But I've got good news for you. Building more housing in Berkeling is working. I just moved out of an apartment in downtown, and I checked.

1227
03:22:47.520 --> 03:23:05.269
Boardroom: It's now renting for $400 cheaper than what I was paying for it a few months ago. If I had known that, I would have stayed and

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renegotiated. So why stop now? Let's keep building more housing so us workers can continue to live and work in all these beautiful neighborhoods. Thank you. Thanks.

1228
03:23:08.810 --> 03:23:15.479
Boardroom: Hello, I got a friend to give me a minute in case I need it. Thank you.

1229
03:23:15.640 --> 03:23:21.089
Boardroom: Hi, Council and Mayor. My name is Brandon Young, District 2 resident.

1230
03:23:21.540 --> 03:23:35.530
Boardroom: It's interesting to me how every time we have a conversation about a new district rezoning, it turns into a conversation on whether or not we should build more housing. That conversationâ€¦ I just want to address people here. That conversation is over.

1231
03:23:35.530 --> 03:23:38.670
Boardroom: that debate settled. This is a workshop.

1232
03:23:38.670 --> 03:23:55.610
Boardroom: And we should be focusing on how do we work together, find consensus, and implement policy that helps with this issue, particularly here, of retaining our small business community and supporting them in what is a transitional moment.

1233
03:23:55.730 --> 03:23:58.980
Boardroom: So toward that, I want to share some ideas.

1234
03:24:00.150 --> 03:24:09.830
Boardroom: These zones we're talking about are overwhelmingly smaller lot sizes, they're gonna have, very small setbacks. We probably want to encourage

1235
03:24:10.070 --> 03:24:15.950
Boardroom: Very small or no front yard setbacks to maintain that very vibrant commercial frontage.

1236
03:24:15.950 --> 03:24:30.530
Boardroom: And because of that lot configuration, I would consider our policymakers to reconsider the, on-site art requirement, our 1% in-lieu fee. Typically, those pieces of public art are provided on-site or on the building facade.

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1237
03:24:30.890 --> 03:24:35.930
Boardroom: I would kind of suggest that maybe we reassess the effectiveness of that program overall, butâ€¦

1238
03:24:36.160 --> 03:24:49.610
Boardroom: I think for this rezoning, we can consider, allowing the option of instead of having that fee or provision, we create a fund that helps, very similar to a program that San Francisco administers.

1239
03:24:49.610 --> 03:24:56.980
Boardroom: Support for our small businesses, relocation, and basically act as brokers between interested small businesses and new ground floors.

1240
03:24:57.250 --> 03:25:09.360
Boardroom: Next, there's a lot of interesting research out there about what we can do to help this issue of reducing the costs of improving our, ground floor commercial spaces, a lot of which

1241
03:25:09.360 --> 03:25:28.169
Boardroom: developers don't put the capital into turning what we call the hard shell into a rentable area. There's policies we can put in there. So yeah, let's think creatively and work on solutions. Thanks. Wait, I think this, this woman was behind you, Brandon, so yeah, go ahead, yeah, you. And then Kelly is behindâ€¦

1242
03:25:28.740 --> 03:25:32.639
Boardroom: I'm sorry, Donna, I forgot your name. Apologies. Go ahead.

1243
03:25:32.730 --> 03:25:50.729
Boardroom: And then Kelly, and then this person. Okay. My name is Donna Diedemar, and there are two things that I've noticed being said here tonight. We keep being told that, no one will use the 100% density bonus. We also keep hearing that we need to provide more affordable housing.

1244
03:25:50.840 --> 03:25:57.959
Boardroom: If that's the case, Then don't upzone to a place where, if you

1245
03:25:58.540 --> 03:26:02.590
Boardroom: Invoke the 100% density bonus, it won't be built.

1246
03:26:02.760 --> 03:26:12.400

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Boardroom: Zone to a place where it will require the 100% density bonus to get the affordable housing units you need.

1247
03:26:12.490 --> 03:26:26.609
Boardroom: So, don't let it go up to 12 if somebody does it, justâ€¦ because right now, you're just giving it away. You're giving away to developers that last, that other part of the, affordable housing. It's clear that

1248
03:26:26.610 --> 03:26:46.560
Boardroom: it's a disingenuous thing. And you can't guarantee on the equity thing, you can't guarantee who's gonna rent these places. So, that's a disingenuous argument. Thank you. Thanks, Donna. So, Kelly is next. Kelly is next in line. I had said that earlier, I'm sorry, I don't know if you got that, but sheâ€¦ sheâ€¦

1249
03:26:46.560 --> 03:26:51.299
Boardroom: this is like a mobility standing thing, so Iâ€¦ she told me she was standing there.

1250
03:26:52.050 --> 03:27:11.959
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. I'm not going to repeat what other people have said. I just want to make a few short comments. I think I attend more design review committee meetings than anyone else in this room. I've probably missed 5 or less in the last 11 years.

1251
03:27:12.200 --> 03:27:31.649
Boardroom: And I'd like to say that the worry about commercial space is very real. I invite everyone who remembers Occokole to go back to 2000 University and to see Cafe Brusco, because that's what is left over

1252
03:27:31.680 --> 03:27:55.480
Boardroom: After we've given everything to the residential building that they need. The elevator banks, the stairwells, the mail room, the leasing room, everything is just taken up on the first floor, and so there's very little commercial space, and unless you really invest a lot, you won't get it.

1253
03:27:55.790 --> 03:27:56.970
Boardroom: Thank you.

1254
03:28:00.410 --> 03:28:16.130
Boardroom: Thank you for your patience. Can I have one more minute, Kelly? Is there anyone left? Okay. So just a couple more things. I just

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want to make this real quick. I'd like you all to write down the title of this book.

1255
03:28:16.270 --> 03:28:19.100
Boardroom: It's called Sixth City.

1256
03:28:19.470 --> 03:28:38.839
Boardroom: And it's, disease, inequity, and land use, and it's about what happens when you add more density to land. And this is by Patrick M. Condon, who lives in Vancouver and is a landscape and city planner.

1257
03:28:38.900 --> 03:28:50.679
Boardroom: And what he found, he believed in adding density, and that it would really work in terms of lowering the cost of housing, and in 2021, he wrote this book.

1258
03:28:50.830 --> 03:29:01.239
Boardroom: And what he found is that it didn't lower the cost of housing at all, and there was actually someone who identified this problem back in the 19thâ€¦

1259
03:29:01.520 --> 03:29:11.420
Boardroom: century called Henry George, is that when you add density, you increase the value of the land and increase the housing.

1260
03:29:12.520 --> 03:29:13.390
Boardroom: Okay.

1261
03:29:14.680 --> 03:29:17.820
Boardroom: Thank you for your patience, I appreciate it. Go ahead.

1262
03:29:18.240 --> 03:29:28.580
Boardroom: I'm Mary White, I'm a West Berkeley artist and educator, and I go to the Ellum Woods several times a month, from West Berkeley to the Basic Bird and other places.

1263
03:29:28.580 --> 03:29:38.920
Boardroom: I think we have a disconnect between low-cost housing and this proposal, because I don't think density will mean low-cost housing at all.

1264
03:29:38.920 --> 03:29:43.149
Boardroom: And so I, I, I urge that you pause.

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1265
03:29:43.150 --> 03:29:59.949
Boardroom: and that you get the younger people who've spoken, and the businesses to come and talk, and that each area, each of these residential areas isâ€¦ or commercial is district. I also know that 4th Street is specifically popular because it's low.

1266
03:30:00.100 --> 03:30:08.200
Boardroom: low density in that area, that shopping area, and I've been here for about 45 years, andâ€¦

1267
03:30:08.430 --> 03:30:24.540
Boardroom: What about focusing on San Pablo, where allâ€¦ and University, where all of those houses, all those commercial businesses have managed to be destroyed? Thank you. So, concentrate on that cause. Thank you.

1268
03:30:33.330 --> 03:30:44.660
Boardroom: My name is Patrick Kennedy. As you all know, I am a big booster of housing, rental and for sale, and I'd like to talk a little bit about,

1269
03:30:44.660 --> 03:30:57.519
Boardroom: disruption of small businesses for development. I'm quite familiar with the Elmwood. My mom lives on Benvenue and, Woolsey, and she's been there since 1986. I patronized the basic bird, gordos.

1270
03:30:57.590 --> 03:31:06.650
Boardroom: the Elmwood Cafe, and many others. And I'd like to tell you that the fears of the neighbors and the businesses there are grossly

1271
03:31:06.750 --> 03:31:14.649
Boardroom: overblown with respect to interests of market-rate developers like myself in their spaces. They're too small.

1272
03:31:14.780 --> 03:31:19.940
Boardroom: The complications of construction are too great, and the costs ofâ€¦

1273
03:31:20.060 --> 03:31:28.789
Boardroom: Assembling a property that is big enough to make an economically viable development is far too great.

1274
03:31:29.000 --> 03:31:44.500

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Boardroom: Moreover, because the Council recently passed the missing middle housing, there are much moreâ€¦ there are many moreâ€¦ Thank you. Okay. â€¦opportunities. Thank you. There are many more opportunities next to Elmore. Thank you. No, no, no, no, no, please. Thank you.

1275
03:31:45.670 --> 03:31:58.920
Boardroom: We gotta keep theâ€¦ we gotta keep the flow. We're doing so well on timing, everyone. Thank you. Okay. The question was raised as to how the 2020-23 upzoning in Oakland has impacted the College Avenue businesses.

1276
03:31:59.050 --> 03:32:12.740
Boardroom: Last year, a small business owner in Rockridge, advised me that she and herâ€¦ the adjoining owners are living with complete uncertainty because

1277
03:32:13.040 --> 03:32:19.300
Boardroom: The landowner, who has never done this before, refused to provide more than a 3-year lease.

1278
03:32:19.330 --> 03:32:24.829
Boardroom: And so they're presuming that he's looking for the bigger profit and the development.

1279
03:32:24.830 --> 03:32:42.780
Boardroom: And second, I am puzzled why the Sacramento corridor isn't being looked at. It isâ€¦ has been designated a high-resource area. You have homes there selling single-family dwellings for $1.2, $1.4 million, and south of Dwight.

1280
03:32:42.780 --> 03:32:51.390
Boardroom: there are vacancies and underused properties that thatâ€¦ those areas could use housing. Thank you. Thank you.

1281
03:32:53.040 --> 03:32:59.639
Boardroom: 29â€¦ Wait, wait, wait, I had 29 written down already, so you're on 30.

1282
03:32:59.860 --> 03:33:19.280
Boardroom: 30, okay. Wait, sorry, so 30â€¦ how many minutes are you getting? 31? Two. Two? Okay, so you'll have 3 minutes total, and we went up to 31 just now, right? Okay, yeah. Okay. I'm Art Goldberg, I've lived in Berkeley since 1968.

1283

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03:33:19.480 --> 03:33:33.549
Boardroom: Nobody here, except one individual a short while ago, mentioned the greater cause, the greatest cause of Berkeley's housing shortage. That's UC Berkeley. UC Berkeley

1284
03:33:33.640 --> 03:33:47.589
Boardroom: agreed 10 years ago to limit its enrollment to 32,000. Right now, it's at 46,000. So there are 14,000 young people without housing who are students.

1285
03:33:47.590 --> 03:34:00.959
Boardroom: Now, you are building the housing for the students. A lot of these apartments are basically chicken coops where you can jam 3, 4, and 5 students into an apartment. Soâ€¦

1286
03:34:01.080 --> 03:34:02.869
Boardroom: I wonder whyâ€¦

1287
03:34:03.020 --> 03:34:22.039
Boardroom: UC doesn't build, and why it's throwing the burden onto the city. In 2023, the California Supreme Court, in its People's Park decision, said, university has plenty of places to build, so why are we destroying viable neighborhoods

1288
03:34:22.140 --> 03:34:41.699
Boardroom: to house students. Those are the people who you are trying to provide housing for, that you see should be providing housing for. And what is done, in your desire to provide that housing for UC students, you've killed the downtown, andâ€¦

1289
03:34:41.820 --> 03:35:02.230
Boardroom: You know, other cities seem to get by without these mandates. I don't see any high-rises in El Cerrito or Albany. I don't see any in Piedmont, where Patrick Kennedy lives, and I don't see any in Lafayette and Orinda. Why are we taking on this immense burden when no one else is?

1290
03:35:08.010 --> 03:35:09.450
Boardroom: Thank you.

1291
03:35:09.900 --> 03:35:10.930
Boardroom: Soâ€¦

1292
03:35:10.950 --> 03:35:35.030

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Boardroom: I was told that you've already used your minute, you gave it to somebody. 44. We've got extras. Okay, so Iâ€¦ well, but she has to use her minute, but she's telling me she didn't. She's got 44, so I don't know what happened, butâ€¦ Go ahead, you've got your minute. You're gonna take a minute. Okay, go ahead. Yeah. My name is Meryl Siegel, I'm the co-founder of beautiful San Pablo.

1293
03:35:35.190 --> 03:35:42.320
Boardroom: And I've been communicating with our people and their business owners, and they're asking if

1294
03:35:42.460 --> 03:35:54.110
Boardroom: it's possible to push San Pablo Avenue plan, specific plan, to another evening. I'm so sorry. We really have to keep going. There's a lot to cover. We haveâ€¦

1295
03:35:54.110 --> 03:36:07.989
Boardroom: Only 3 council meetings left, and there's a lot of information to do, soâ€¦ and we stillâ€¦ yeah, so, anyway, so we've finished the in-person comments for this evening. Can I just have a sense, if you are online, can you please raise your hand?

1296
03:36:08.090 --> 03:36:11.129
Boardroom: If you have a comment on this item.

1297
03:36:13.840 --> 03:36:14.609
Boardroom: Oh, my God.

1298
03:36:14.810 --> 03:36:18.440
Boardroom: We're gonna take a break, but I want to see how many comments we have.

1299
03:36:19.420 --> 03:36:28.560
Boardroom: It says 12 now, so if you're participating remotely on Zoom and you'd like to give comments, pleaseâ€¦

1300
03:36:28.760 --> 03:36:30.610
Boardroom: Raise your hand on Zoom.

1301
03:36:30.930 --> 03:36:34.179
Boardroom: Okay, so we have at least 12, butâ€¦ At least 12.

1302
03:36:34.590 --> 03:36:35.650

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Boardroom: 13.

1303
03:36:35.780 --> 03:36:45.059
Boardroom: 13? Okay, so we are gonna take a 15-minute break, and then we will be back for these 13 comments. Thank you.

1304
03:36:50.530 --> 03:36:57.700
Boardroom: Hello! Hi, everyone! It's 10-12, and we still haveâ€¦

1305
03:36:57.700 --> 03:37:19.920
Boardroom: I have at least 13 comments online. Folks? Wait, where's mine? How many comments is it? Sorry. Yes? 10 to 13â€¦ It keeps going. It's aboutâ€¦ now at 14â€¦ 14, okay. Alright, hey, folks, please, can I have your attention?

1306
03:37:21.800 --> 03:37:22.890
Boardroom: All right.

1307
03:37:23.420 --> 03:37:29.689
Boardroom: Very good. So we are back in session. Oh my gosh! Council members!

1308
03:37:30.020 --> 03:37:32.329
Boardroom: Thank you.

1309
03:37:32.740 --> 03:37:47.600
Boardroom: Alright, going on, we're going to the online comments. I know we're reaching the silly hour, I can tell. So let's go to our online comments. I think we've got about 14, we still have council member comments, and then we have another item, so let's get going. Okay, folks, pleaseâ€¦

1310
03:37:48.720 --> 03:37:56.799
Boardroom: Take your conversations outside. Okay, go ahead. Okay, the, first, public speaker is Bertha Magana.

1311
03:37:59.700 --> 03:38:02.649
berthamagana: Hi, my name is Berta Magana,

1312
03:38:02.850 --> 03:38:06.450
berthamagana: I own a house, right next to Solano Avenue.

1313

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03:38:06.450 --> 03:38:25.879
berthamagana: And I do not support the upzoning of Solano Avenue. My family and I are the only Mexican family on our block. We are one of only two families with a young child on our block, and as the first house right off of Solano, that means that we have two commercial properties.

1314
03:38:25.880 --> 03:38:50.080
berthamagana: to the left of our lot, and one commercial property in the back of our lot. So, I don't want to see a massive, ugly wall wrap around my backyard. Our backyard is gorgeous, it's an oasis, it's my child's favorite place to be, and if you really want to be equal, then support actual home ownership with green spaces. Don't just facilitate living in poverty in some high-rise.

1315
03:38:53.190 --> 03:38:56.969
Boardroom: Okay, next speaker is Veronica Fuchsen.

1316
03:39:04.040 --> 03:39:06.130
Boardroom: Should be able to unmute Veronica.

1317
03:39:06.130 --> 03:39:07.490
Veronika Fukson: Thank you.

1318
03:39:07.930 --> 03:39:10.690
Veronika Fukson: I'm sorry, my name is Veronica Fuchsen.

1319
03:39:10.880 --> 03:39:26.699
Veronika Fukson: I would like to join with the comments that were made by Sue Johnson and, the owner ofâ€¦ and Amy Thomas, and also of Mr. Simon, who spoke toward the very beginning.

1320
03:39:26.970 --> 03:39:44.109
Veronika Fukson: You know, this doesn't have to be an either-or, and there's a need for people to get together and to work these things out. Because something can happen doesn't mean that you have to make it happen, and so you can take your time.

1321
03:39:44.250 --> 03:39:47.100
Veronika Fukson: This one says that people want to beâ€¦

1322
03:39:47.230 --> 03:39:56.409
Veronika Fukson: cooperative, they want to get together, they want to figure some things out, and I urge you to do that. It's really, really important.

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1323
03:39:56.690 --> 03:40:04.700
Veronika Fukson: Having things dropped on one at theâ€¦ when they don't know it's coming and it's heavy is not the way to do government, believe me.

1324
03:40:04.830 --> 03:40:06.289
Veronika Fukson: Thank you very much.

1325
03:40:07.050 --> 03:40:10.340
Boardroom: Thank you. Next is Amy Baldwin.

1326
03:40:13.750 --> 03:40:18.160
aimee baldwin: Oh, hi, I was gonna cede my minute to Dietmar, if he's still online.

1327
03:40:19.290 --> 03:40:19.669
Boardroom: To whom?

1328
03:40:19.670 --> 03:40:23.349
aimee baldwin: Do you see Dietmar? Dietmar Lorenz? Is heâ€¦

1329
03:40:23.700 --> 03:40:27.700
Boardroom: I don'tâ€¦ Ow.

1330
03:40:27.900 --> 03:40:30.950
aimee baldwin: He might haveâ€¦ he might have gone to bed. Okay,

1331
03:40:31.110 --> 03:40:35.700
aimee baldwin: then I guess I will comment for myself. The episode of the Sorry, Amyâ€¦

1332
03:40:35.700 --> 03:40:36.290
Boardroom: either looking.

1333
03:40:36.290 --> 03:40:40.719
aimee baldwin: I found him? He's on. Yeah. Yes. Okay, great. I'm seating my minutes here.

1334
03:40:40.720 --> 03:40:42.100
Boardroom: Okay, thanks, Amy.

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1335
03:40:43.360 --> 03:40:45.050
Boardroom: Alrightâ€¦

1336
03:40:46.960 --> 03:40:54.840
Boardroom: Yeah, when he comes up, thenâ€¦ or when they come up, then they will get that extra minute. Go ahead. Yes. Okay, next is Scott.

1337
03:40:57.860 --> 03:41:14.239
scott: Yes, hi. My name is Scott Solmanoff. I want to thank all of the small business owners who came tonight and represented themselves at this meeting. I have lived in Berkeley for over 50 years, and I shop at all those stores and many more.

1338
03:41:14.240 --> 03:41:20.229
Boardroom: I'm opposed to upzoning. That is a power grab by Wall Street. Follow the money.

1339
03:41:20.320 --> 03:41:28.360
scott: Any discussion regarding housing and low-income housing must include representation from the University of California.

1340
03:41:28.360 --> 03:41:41.809
scott: The University of California has approximately 50,000 students, and they provide about 10,000 beds. This is part of the housing crisis that's been going on since I moved here in 1971.

1341
03:41:41.870 --> 03:41:59.750
scott: I also want to give a big happy birthday shout-out to the Cheese Board Collective. 58 years now, today, and I agree with Vanessa from the Cheese Board that to solve these issues, we must work together collectively, in community. Thank you very much.

1342
03:41:59.750 --> 03:42:00.779
Boardroom: Thank you!

1343
03:42:01.140 --> 03:42:03.660
Boardroom: Next is Becky O'Malley.

1344
03:42:17.400 --> 03:42:20.750
Boardroom: Becky O'Malley, you should be able to unmute.

1345

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03:42:21.690 --> 03:42:22.779
Becky O'Malley: Yeah, it's a mayor.

1346
03:42:23.450 --> 03:42:24.570
Boardroom: Okay.

1347
03:42:24.570 --> 03:42:31.810
Becky O'Malley: My husband, who shares this computer, is singing a minute to me, so I guess I have toâ€¦ .

1348
03:42:31.810 --> 03:42:37.169
Boardroom: Sorry, Becky, are you there so that you can tell us that you're giving a minute?

1349
03:42:37.660 --> 03:42:38.180
Becky O'Malley: Nope.

1350
03:42:38.690 --> 03:42:42.449
Becky O'Malley: Muhammad I would like, first of all, to thank all of you who.

1351
03:42:42.450 --> 03:42:53.740
Boardroom: Sorry, hold on one second. Just to be clear, so Becky needs to be there to give you a minute. Becky is there. I just can't hear. Okay.

1352
03:42:53.920 --> 03:42:55.130
Boardroom: Okay, go ahead.

1353
03:42:56.130 --> 03:42:56.979
Becky O'Malley: Where are we?

1354
03:42:58.430 --> 03:43:00.639
Becky O'Malley: Is it okay for me to start?

1355
03:43:01.010 --> 03:43:01.770
Becky O'Malley: Yep.

1356
03:43:02.210 --> 03:43:21.979
Becky O'Malley: Anyway, I would like to thank all of you for making the effort to get down there, and I heard some really remarkable speeches. Mark Goldberg at the end really nailed it, as did this other guy who

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spoke afterwards. It's the university that's causing all these problems, and there have been many deals with the university sometimes.

1357
03:43:21.980 --> 03:43:31.149
Becky O'Malley: With money exchanging hands, which were part of the program and continue to be part of the program. There's not a lot you can do about it.

1358
03:43:31.150 --> 03:43:45.649
Becky O'Malley: But I did want to point out one thing to you, and you might consult somebody at the university about this. The First Amendment, you can't say people can cheer, but they can't boo. That is censoring content of

1359
03:43:45.650 --> 03:43:52.010
Becky O'Malley: Permitted speech, and it's absolutely not inconsistentâ€¦ not consistent with the

1360
03:43:52.490 --> 03:43:56.570
Becky O'Malley: First Amendment, I think your legal counsel will probably tell you that.

1361
03:43:57.190 --> 03:44:00.789
Becky O'Malley: So, if people want to boo, they should be able to boo.

1362
03:44:01.180 --> 03:44:15.959
Becky O'Malley: And that's really all I have to say. I appreciate all the work that everybody else has done. I, myself, I'm at home with, the end of a bout of pneumonia, so I can't be there, which might be why I sound sort of funny, too.

1363
03:44:18.860 --> 03:44:22.419
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. Next is Nancy Rader.

1364
03:44:25.620 --> 03:44:41.239
Nancy Rader: Good evening. Yeah, my name is Nancy Rader. I live in the hills above North Shattuck. I avoid buying online as much as I possibly can, and buy local. Just today, I shopped at She's Board and Ace Hardware downtown. I buy all of my books at Pegasus, etc.

1365
03:44:41.350 --> 03:44:49.480
Nancy Rader: But for various reasons, it's not practical for me to walk or bike down and up the hill to shop, so I drive, but parking is already tough.

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1366
03:44:49.490 --> 03:45:02.699
Nancy Rader: So my question to the planners is, have you considered the impact of potentially much greater density and congestion in these commercial areas on the ability to park so people can keep supporting these businesses? What's the plan?

1367
03:45:02.850 --> 03:45:09.329
Nancy Rader: And if you build the cycle tracks that are also planned on Solano and Shattuck, we'll lose most of the parking we have.

1368
03:45:09.720 --> 03:45:23.079
Nancy Rader: I attended all three community meetings and didn't hear a word about the impacts of the proposal on parking, which allows thousands of people in the hills and people all across the city to buy local on Solano, North Shattuck, and the Elmwood. Thank you.

1369
03:45:23.730 --> 03:45:24.850
Boardroom: Thank you.

1370
03:45:25.750 --> 03:45:28.980
Boardroom: Okay, next is, Michelle.

1371
03:45:29.720 --> 03:45:31.570
Boardroom: Should be able to unmute.

1372
03:45:32.860 --> 03:45:42.010
Michelle: Hi, my name's Michelle Hainer, and I live on the edge of the Elmwood. I'm a high school teacher with two kids, including one in Berkeley High School.

1373
03:45:42.130 --> 03:45:56.029
Michelle: I would like to reinforce that, you know, in the past, gosh, less than a year, the City Council voted to open up, you know, 80% of Berkeley to a massive rezoning to increase housing stock.

1374
03:45:57.280 --> 03:46:11.230
Michelle: without going into to what extent that's just going to be fueled by venture capitalists, though we have received many cash offers on our old brown shingle house here, I want to reinforce that before we

1375
03:46:11.230 --> 03:46:20.350

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Michelle: instigate another wave of massive change, including the destruction of really precious historical areas, local businesses. We should go slow.

1376
03:46:20.350 --> 03:46:27.190
Michelle: And look at how housing is already going to be massively increased by what you have already implemented. Thank you so much.

1377
03:46:28.110 --> 03:46:29.129
Boardroom: Thank you.

1378
03:46:30.040 --> 03:46:32.649
Boardroom: Next is Tony Mester.

1379
03:46:37.470 --> 03:46:45.360
Toni Mester, Berkeley: Good evening. Good to see everybody. I would like to donate my minute to Dietmar Lorenz.

1380
03:46:45.530 --> 03:46:49.359
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. Thank you. Dietmar will have 3 minutes.

1381
03:46:50.850 --> 03:46:53.210
Boardroom: Next is Christopher Kroll.

1382
03:46:57.890 --> 03:47:04.739
Christopher Kroll: I just decided toâ€¦ I'm gonna give Dietmar my minute as well. I don't know if he wants it, but he's gonna get it. Thank you.

1383
03:47:04.740 --> 03:47:14.920
Boardroom: All right, thank you. Okay! Deepmar will have 4 minutes. Next is Nathan Landau.

1384
03:47:22.430 --> 03:47:23.450
Boardroom: Nathan?

1385
03:47:24.200 --> 03:47:25.699
Boardroom: Should be able to unmute.

1386
03:47:26.510 --> 03:47:27.160
nathanlandau: Unmute.

1387

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03:47:27.460 --> 03:47:28.120
Boardroom: There you go.

1388
03:47:28.120 --> 03:47:29.620
nathanlandau: Hi,

1389
03:47:30.410 --> 03:47:39.450
nathanlandau: We always have trouble identifying where housing should beâ€¦ should go. We all want it. These corridors are among the best places in the city.

1390
03:47:39.560 --> 03:47:49.350
nathanlandau: People who live there can walk to businesses like the Cheese Board and grocery stores. From North Shattuck, you can walk to BART.

1391
03:47:49.600 --> 03:47:57.950
nathanlandau: And of course, there are business districts around the world and the country that have apartment buildings andâ€¦

1392
03:47:58.750 --> 03:48:08.500
nathanlandau: businesses on the ground floor. And what we'll get from this is we'll get a mix of old and new spaces, different rent levels, it will be very healthy for the district.

1393
03:48:08.610 --> 03:48:13.289
nathanlandau: For, forâ€¦ particularly easy for me to see it on North Shattuck.

1394
03:48:13.580 --> 03:48:26.280
nathanlandau: I'd also say, what happens if housing isn't built? Well, we know that prices skyrocket. Also, the state could impose the builder's remedy, which would take away Berkeley's ability to control development. Thank you.

1395
03:48:27.470 --> 03:48:28.470
Boardroom: Thank you!

1396
03:48:28.590 --> 03:48:31.500
Boardroom: Okay, next is Joel Meyerson.

1397
03:48:32.870 --> 03:48:35.209
Boardroom: And Peggy Radel?

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1398
03:48:36.410 --> 03:48:51.280
Joel Myerson and Peggy Radel: Oh, yeah. So the representative from beautiful San Pablo requested that you push the discussion of the San Pablo plan to another evening, presumably because of the late hour and how much time's being taken up with the corridor zoning update.

1399
03:48:51.400 --> 03:48:58.329
Joel Myerson and Peggy Radel: And he basically dismissed her by saying, I'm so sorry, we really have to keep going, there are only 3 council meetings left.

1400
03:48:58.670 --> 03:49:08.839
Joel Myerson and Peggy Radel: You know as well as I do that the Council can call another special meeting anytime they want, and I think you're really just blowing off important stakeholders by not doing so. Thank you.

1401
03:49:11.440 --> 03:49:14.739
Boardroom: Okay, next is, Brianna Morales.

1402
03:49:17.410 --> 03:49:31.860
Brianna Morales: Hi! My name is Brianna with the Housing Action Coalition, a nonprofit that advocates for housing across California. Small businesses are essential, and displacement is a real concern. We need to pair strong protections with zoning that actually has new homes being able to be built.

1403
03:49:31.950 --> 03:49:54.800
Brianna Morales: Housing and small businesses cannot and should not be put against each other. More homes means more customers, more stability, and more life on our streets. Fixing the housing crisis means homes at all income levels, including, often forgotten, missing middle. In my work with affordable, non-profit market rate builders, when projects can't pencil, we lose new homes and crucial affordable housing funding that comes directly from market rate fees.

1404
03:49:54.910 --> 03:50:00.029
Brianna Morales: We urge a strong 6-story base zoning across all corridors, and no

1405
03:50:00.140 --> 03:50:18.820
Brianna Morales: mandatory grand floor retail. Focus active uses where they make sense and allow housing when retail isn't viable. Rather than, I support housing, butâ€¦ every neighborhood in Berkeley is someone's

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right place. If we want an inclusive city, especially now, we have to start saying yes, here too. We cannot afford to wait while in a housing crisis.

1406
03:50:18.820 --> 03:50:20.500
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you.

1407
03:50:21.140 --> 03:50:23.339
Boardroom: Next is Alfred Tu.

1408
03:50:26.170 --> 03:50:38.020
Alfred Twu: Hi, everyone! Here to speak in support of the corridor zoning. As a matter of fairness, South Berkeley already was rezoned, and San Pablo Avenue is coming up as well.

1409
03:50:38.320 --> 03:50:54.399
Alfred Twu: I think to address some of the concerns of the businesses, Berkeley could do something like San Francisco's Legacy Business Program, which provides funding to many of the longtime businesses to help them get through impacts from construction and other issues. Thank you.

1410
03:50:55.300 --> 03:50:56.380
Boardroom: Thank you.

1411
03:50:57.170 --> 03:51:03.520
Boardroom: Okay, next is Dietmar Lorenz, who have, 4 minutes.

1412
03:51:04.020 --> 03:51:23.929
Dietmar Lorenz: Hi, good evening, Mayor and Council. So, just to clarify, the seeded minutes by Tony Mester and Amy Baldwin and Chris Call, I think they wanted to seed these minutes for me to speak on the San Pablo-specific plan. So, I will keep this to one minute, relating to the corridor zoning update.

1413
03:51:23.930 --> 03:51:30.340
Dietmar Lorenz: I found this CZU public comments very compelling, very differentiated and nuanced, and

1414
03:51:30.340 --> 03:51:49.810
Dietmar Lorenz: I think it'sâ€¦ and, you know, also, many statements that it's really a false choice to say, well, it's 8-story or nothing, you know, thereâ€¦ I'm an architect, and, you know, I've seen this from both ends, and seeing how difficult it can get through with zoning and everything, but there is a great in-between zone

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1415
03:51:49.810 --> 03:52:06.590
Dietmar Lorenz: that has not been explored. Somebody made this comment, what's for dinner, chicken, right? So I think we need to zoom out on a larger city level, and I think it's very important to give equal opportunity for West Berkeley. We are into four and a half hours of thisâ€¦

1416
03:52:06.590 --> 03:52:07.300
Boardroom: Nope.

1417
03:52:07.300 --> 03:52:09.190
Dietmar Lorenz: And West Berkeley, again, is skating.

1418
03:52:09.190 --> 03:52:12.160
Boardroom: Sorry, that wasâ€¦ you said, did you want to use theâ€¦

1419
03:52:12.160 --> 03:52:16.540
Dietmar Lorenz: Then give meâ€¦ give me one extra minute for this, because I think it's really important.

1420
03:52:16.540 --> 03:52:17.279
Boardroom: Christopher, okay.

1421
03:52:17.280 --> 03:52:21.629
Dietmar Lorenz: Just saying, sorry, this is the end of it, and this is the last meeting.

1422
03:52:21.670 --> 03:52:44.930
Dietmar Lorenz: then you need to make time for it. This is going to redefine the city in a very fundamental way that will shape what the city will look like decades from now. And it isâ€¦ it's 10.30. The people in our group, in our neighborhood, they dialed out, they went home, they're tired. You are tired too, even if you're saying, well, it's too bad for you if you went home.

1423
03:52:44.930 --> 03:53:09.919
Dietmar Lorenz: But who of you really is going to have the stamina to give the same amount of consideration and an open ear to what we have to say in West Berkeley. It's a historically disadvantaged part of town, and again, this wouldâ€¦ we will be thrown under the bus by not givingâ€¦ getting the same opportunity that higher-resourced areas of the city had. So I would find it unconscionable to just keep going and brush this

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1424
03:53:09.920 --> 03:53:16.399
Dietmar Lorenz: decide, make more room for it, postpone the part for the San Pablo-specific plan, please. Thank you.

1425
03:53:20.090 --> 03:53:34.610
Boardroom: There's, that's theâ€¦ there's no more hands raised, so that's the end of public comments. Okay, so we are moving on to Councilmember comments. Briefly, I just want to touch on two things. One, yes, of course, we can always call another special meeting, but

1426
03:53:34.610 --> 03:53:47.089
Boardroom: out of respect to staff who have been waiting, out of the fact that there are many folks who have waited this long to speak on this second item, we are going to continue with it. And the other thing I wanted to address is theâ€¦

1427
03:53:47.090 --> 03:53:51.580
Boardroom: Booze. That is actually in our procedural matters.

1428
03:53:51.610 --> 03:54:00.940
Boardroom: document under decorum, soâ€¦ that is a stated thing. People are not allowed to boo and hiss, it's not a First Amendment violation, soâ€¦ okay.

1429
03:54:01.070 --> 03:54:13.710
Boardroom: Moving on to our Council comments, starting with Councilmember Taplin. Thank you, and let me please begin by saying that I certainly have stamina for both these corridors and my own corridors from Hubble Avenue.

1430
03:54:13.710 --> 03:54:21.429
Boardroom: And I do thank my West Berkeley people who have stuck it out, and I do share your frustration for how much space and time these corridors took up.

1431
03:54:21.640 --> 03:54:26.040
Boardroom: That being said, can you please, re-say what you're asking feedback on?

1432
03:54:26.170 --> 03:54:30.120
Boardroom: Yes, please.

1433
03:54:30.400 --> 03:54:50.060

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Boardroom: Yeah, well, thank you, Councilmember Taplin. We're gonna bring those questions back up. I think, to summarize, we were hoping to get your feedback on the alternatives presented, whether you think Alternative 1 or 2 or neither of those hits the mark, to the extent you're comfortable giving us feedback.

1434
03:54:50.150 --> 03:54:54.440
Boardroom: The building form alternatives we presented regarding step-backs.

1435
03:54:54.870 --> 03:55:17.400
Boardroom: ground floor residential, whether to require it throughout the entirety of these districts, or you saw the maps that we showed where we would allow ground floor residential in certain areas of these corridors, and also the question of whether City Council would be interested in having staff and the team bring back more detailed, objective design standards

1436
03:55:17.400 --> 03:55:23.729
Boardroom: For each of these corridors, and we could potentially look at differentiated standards that vary.

1437
03:55:23.730 --> 03:55:31.329
Boardroom: For each corridor, if Council's interested in that. So, it would be helpful to get that feedback.

1438
03:55:31.700 --> 03:55:40.860
Boardroom: Yes, I will limit, like, my feedback to the zoning alternatives, and the ground floor question.

1439
03:55:41.100 --> 03:55:48.420
Boardroom: And I do want to reflect that what I heard tonight was a very strong interest in protecting our small businesses.

1440
03:55:49.010 --> 03:55:57.090
Boardroom: And a great concern forâ€¦ The risk ofâ€¦ Extensive commercial vacancy.

1441
03:55:57.660 --> 03:56:01.570
Boardroom: What I did not quite hear was whetherâ€¦

1442
03:56:02.410 --> 03:56:05.719
Boardroom: The conditions of these three corridors were conducive

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1443
03:56:05.850 --> 03:56:08.640
Boardroom: Currently, to the vitality of these businesses.

1444
03:56:08.960 --> 03:56:21.909
Boardroom: And if so, how? And if not, why not? Likeâ€¦ Does low-density, low pedestrian traffic, supportâ€¦ Fragile small businesses.

1445
03:56:24.660 --> 03:56:31.650
Boardroom: As someone who lives along a thriving, vibrant, and historic commercial district.

1446
03:56:31.800 --> 03:56:42.740
Boardroom: that has neighborhood-serving businesses. It's been my experience that having customers who live nearby is a net positive for them, and that's how they've been able to stay.

1447
03:56:44.490 --> 03:56:56.680
Boardroom: That being said, I do look forward to the continued outreach to the businesses in these corridors, and I would like to see what's working for them, what's not working for them, so we can think about how to make those

1448
03:56:57.130 --> 03:57:01.379
Boardroom: Conditions, continuous throughout each of these corridors moving forward.

1449
03:57:03.280 --> 03:57:21.109
Boardroom: I don't think we should require commercial ground floor, not because I don't think it's nice to have continuous storefronts, I just also am very concerned about, you know, the potential of having extensive commercial vacancies, so I think some flexibility, is important there.

1450
03:57:23.390 --> 03:57:43.269
Boardroom: I mean, I didn't hear this as much as I thought I might have heard it by now, but there were a few comments, few, albeit few, that somehow housing belongs somewhere else, everywhere else, it seems like. And in response to the person who asked why we're not trying to build on parks, it's because we have

1451
03:57:43.890 --> 03:57:46.859
Boardroom: Districts that are zoned for residential uses.

1452
03:57:47.670 --> 03:57:58.740

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Boardroom: And if you zoom out from the parks mentioned, those would be, well, specifically Strawberry Creek Park and Zim Hill Park, you'll see neighborhoods that have built more housing than all the neighborhoods we're talking about tonight, right now.

1453
03:58:01.120 --> 03:58:05.100
Boardroom: And so, therefore, I do think it's important to have parity across

1454
03:58:06.550 --> 03:58:14.240
Boardroom: the corridors, because I don't see any utility in reinforcing the segregationist history of exclusionary zoning.

1455
03:58:16.940 --> 03:58:19.320
Boardroom: So I would support 7 across.

1456
03:58:22.120 --> 03:58:23.070
Boardroom: Thank you.

1457
03:58:23.590 --> 03:58:27.800
Boardroom: Thank you. Moving on to Councilmember Kesarwani.

1458
03:58:27.800 --> 03:58:39.960
Boardroom: Thank you very much, Madam Mayor. Thank you again to our planning staff and the consultant team for your extensive work and the community outreach that has taken place since

1459
03:58:39.960 --> 03:59:03.200
Boardroom: the Council first passed the housing element back in January 2023. You know, this is a really exciting night, for me personally, you know, that we are discussing rezoning these transit commercial corridors in high-resource neighborhoods. As was stated during the presentation, this is because it is in our housing element plan required by the state.

1460
03:59:03.260 --> 03:59:05.860
Boardroom: Why is it in our housing element?

1461
03:59:05.860 --> 03:59:23.340
Boardroom: It'sâ€¦ it's there because we are required to affirmatively further fair housing. This is a mandate that originates from the Federal Fair Housing Act of 1968 to create inclusive communities.

1462
03:59:23.340 --> 03:59:26.889

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Boardroom: On a technical level, what this means is that

1463
03:59:26.890 --> 03:59:34.810
Boardroom: We have a requirement to attempt to locate more affordable housing in higher-income neighborhoods.

1464
03:59:34.820 --> 03:59:47.890
Boardroom: And the slide that we saw during the Q&A, Councilmember Taplin asked that we put that up. We could see visually that there has not been development of any kind, you know, whether affordable or not.

1465
03:59:47.890 --> 03:59:58.440
Boardroom: on Solano and North Shattuck and College, I think we just have a couple projects now on North Shattuck, so we know that our rules are a barrier.

1466
03:59:58.440 --> 04:00:15.000
Boardroom: Weâ€¦ we have just 2 stories that are allowed currently on Solano Avenue, which is such a wide street. We have college that only allows 2 to 3 stories. North Shattuck is just 3 to 4 stories, and we all pass thatâ€¦

1467
04:00:15.250 --> 04:00:28.830
Boardroom: Bank of America lot, it's completely underutilized. There's so much potential there, and, you know, I understand it was actually just recently purchased, and so if we can do this rezoning, we can hopefully have

1468
04:00:28.870 --> 04:00:46.960
Boardroom: people living right there, right next to Cheese Board, and all of those wonderful businesses, walking along that street, patronizing those businesses, you know, that is really what I see as beneficial to the businesses, and that's not to minimize the concerns we heard tonight. I actually want to thank

1469
04:00:47.200 --> 04:01:05.020
Boardroom: especially the business owners who are trying to run a business, who took the time out of their evening to come and talk to us tonight. I really think we need to continue, and I know our staff and consultants will continue to reach out to businesses.

1470
04:01:05.100 --> 04:01:10.789
Boardroom: And Iâ€¦ I just want to express my support for the study that we will be doing.

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1471
04:01:10.940 --> 04:01:25.059
Boardroom: I think the staff mentioned through strategic economics to look at, what we can do to make sure that our small businesses are supported. So, let me just get into the feedback points in the remaining time that I have.

1472
04:01:25.060 --> 04:01:31.780
Boardroom: I think that we should have a minimum height across all of the commercial transit corridors.

1473
04:01:31.780 --> 04:01:42.409
Boardroom: of 7 stories, and I think we should keep the 8 stories for North Shattuck as proposed in Alternative 2. And here's why. People tell us

1474
04:01:42.410 --> 04:02:01.560
Boardroom: that they don't want to see taller buildings in residential neighborhoods. We kept middle housing to 3 stories. And, you know, I'm oftenâ€¦ I often get feedback from the public that we think that the taller buildings should go on the commercial transit corridors. So I think this is our opportunity to do that.

1475
04:02:01.560 --> 04:02:07.959
Boardroom: Weâ€¦ I just want to remind us, we zoned the North Berkeley and Ashby BART station for 7 stories.

1476
04:02:07.960 --> 04:02:27.000
Boardroom: State law, SB79, that was just signed by the governor, will now allow 7 stories within a quarter mile of all of our BART stations, and 6 stories within a quarter mile to a half mile from those stations. So we are going to see, over time, more height.

1477
04:02:27.000 --> 04:02:39.789
Boardroom: along transit corridors. So I think it makes sense for these three corridors to sort of have the similar standard of 7 stories. And I really think that we need to do this now. I think aboutâ€¦

1478
04:02:39.860 --> 04:03:04.850
Boardroom: Some of the young families we heard from, some of them have been fortunate enough to buy a home in Berkeley. We didn't hear from some of the people we heard from during middle housing, some of those grad students living in garages. We know that ourâ€¦ many of our college students are homeless, they're couch surfing or living in cars. We need to be thinking about the next generation. My son is 7 years old and in second grade.

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1479
04:03:04.850 --> 04:03:27.489
Boardroom: So 15 years from now, when he and his peers graduate from college and they're trying to figure out where they're going to live, we need to plan for that future, for the next generation. So I think we need to be ambitious now. I also think we need to look at increasing the floor area ratio for non-residential and mixed-use development to make sure that

1480
04:03:27.490 --> 04:03:41.840
Boardroom: there is the square footage that's necessary for things to be feasible. I just want to quickly wrap up that I think we should have no step-backs, because I don't want to lose units. I don't want to do that trade-off ofâ€¦

1481
04:03:41.840 --> 04:03:53.000
Boardroom: of losing units for step-backs. I think we should be flexible by con- on the ground floor, I'm talking about, by concentrating retail in the targeted nodes.

1482
04:03:53.060 --> 04:04:11.770
Boardroom: those major intersections, and allowing ground floor residential or office in other locations to, again, to improve feasibility. And I don't think we need differentiated objective design standards for each corridor. I'll talk more about that when we get to the San Pablo plan. I think we can use

1483
04:04:11.770 --> 04:04:28.079
Boardroom: some targeted standards for the ground floor, and apply them to all the corridors. So, that's all I have. Thank you very much, and thank you again to the business owners who came and spoke about their concerns, and I know that we will continue to outreach to them. Thank you. Councilmember O'Keefe.

1484
04:04:29.230 --> 04:04:33.659
Boardroom: Thanks a lot. Thank you so much to planning staff. You guys areâ€¦

1485
04:04:33.960 --> 04:04:43.000
Boardroom: You're doing great. And thanks so much to everyone who came out, especially the small businesses. I really appreciated hearing from so many of them.

1486
04:04:44.450 --> 04:04:50.980

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Boardroom: Small businesses are among the most vulnerable and most affected by this kind of change, so it's very important to have their voice.

1487
04:04:51.170 --> 04:05:06.099
Boardroom: And I want to say it's probably true, like, two things are true. I think that planning staff was very diligent and did, a great job reaching out. It's also a huge task, and so I think that's true, and it's also true that

1488
04:05:06.130 --> 04:05:17.280
Boardroom: there were quite a few business owners who didn't hear about it. And so, I just want to, I thinkâ€¦ don't feel blamed, but I think that'sâ€¦ I do want to validate that clearly that was some people's experience. I want to plug my newsletter.

1489
04:05:17.280 --> 04:05:36.209
Boardroom: Any small business in Solano or, North Taddock should absolutely subscribe to my newsletter, because we definitely announced it a lot. You can get great information that way. But anyway, if that was your experience, I'm sorry. Fortunately, we had this forum. This was also to get feedback. So, you know, I'm glad you're part of the conversation now.

1490
04:05:39.190 --> 04:05:48.169
Boardroom: So, that wasâ€¦ that's the main feedback I have, is that I agree, and I really think we do need protections for small businesses. I was glad to hear that there'sâ€¦

1491
04:05:48.170 --> 04:06:01.220
Boardroom: Nothing really to talk about now, but it sounds like you guys are taking it really seriously, and you have a process moving forward that will result in some good ideas. So I'm looking forward to that, and I really am gonna place a lot of importance on something coming from that.

1492
04:06:01.670 --> 04:06:03.579
Boardroom: That's myâ€¦ that's my main feedback.

1493
04:06:03.720 --> 04:06:10.620
Boardroom: And thenâ€¦ I justâ€¦ I have to say something that's been bothering me,

1494
04:06:11.300 --> 04:06:21.789

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Boardroom: You know, and most people left, unfortunately, but so many people tonight said, you know, this is being shoved down our throat, this isâ€¦ we're only giving one option, nobody's listening to us.

1495
04:06:21.990 --> 04:06:23.979
Boardroom: We're only being offered chicken.

1496
04:06:24.140 --> 04:06:35.429
Boardroom: I mean, I'm not makingâ€¦ like, I hear that, and it makes sense. That sounds frustrating. That's totally valid. But what I didn't hear alongside that is, like, an alternate idea.

1497
04:06:35.870 --> 04:06:52.919
Boardroom: Like, Iâ€¦ if there's another way to bring density to these neighborhoods, I want to hear it. They want to hear it. We're open-minded, you know, this is theâ€¦ this is what we're working with now, nothing is set in stone, and so I just want to give a plug for just, like, work with us.

1498
04:06:53.410 --> 04:07:13.090
Boardroom: It'sâ€¦ and so, I really, you know, I invite it, and I'm sorry that people feel left out. Okay, so the process is ongoing, and there will be more conversations, and I know that they're nodding. They definitely want to hear from you. We do too, and thank you again for coming. So, okay, I want to just want to make one final point, which isâ€¦

1499
04:07:13.250 --> 04:07:16.220
Boardroom: I have a real North Star when it comes toâ€¦

1500
04:07:16.440 --> 04:07:18.570
Boardroom: How to think about this sort ofâ€¦

1501
04:07:18.670 --> 04:07:21.020
Boardroom: Thing we're up to here, and that's equity.

1502
04:07:21.430 --> 04:07:22.660
Boardroom: And soâ€¦

1503
04:07:22.810 --> 04:07:33.670
Boardroom: this is my feedback for all the other questions, okay? Small businesses, and then whatever we're doing in the other corridors that we've upzoned, I want to do that with these.

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1504
04:07:34.820 --> 04:07:37.829
Boardroom: It's equity. That's the whole point of this.

1505
04:07:38.450 --> 04:07:39.540
Boardroom: Soâ€¦

1506
04:07:39.570 --> 04:07:48.410
Boardroom: when I hear proposals like, well, you know, but ourâ€¦ but it's soâ€¦ we love our businesses. Yeah, we love our businesses. I love them. I love all of Berkeley's businesses.

1507
04:07:48.420 --> 04:07:59.860
Boardroom: So, I want us to do whatever we're doing citywide, and just to bring it back to my original point, I want the small business protections that we will come up with to be applied citywide.

1508
04:08:00.630 --> 04:08:11.460
Boardroom: I want, you know, Sue Johnson's lips to be protected, I want your basic bird to be protected, and I want all the nail shops on University and San Pablo to be protected.

1509
04:08:12.090 --> 04:08:18.730
Boardroom: Right? Like, this is universal, this is equity, and that's a very important value, and that should be our North Star.

1510
04:08:19.170 --> 04:08:21.230
Boardroom: And so, I thinkâ€¦

1511
04:08:21.500 --> 04:08:29.889
Boardroom: That's all I want to say, although I get my nails done on North Shattuck, I want to say. Polished is a great place, but I want all the nail shops to be protected.

1512
04:08:30.160 --> 04:08:35.789
Boardroom: But polished is great. Okay, so that's all. So, small businesses.

1513
04:08:36.250 --> 04:08:39.020
Boardroom: be an equity. That's my feedback. Thank you.

1514
04:08:39.540 --> 04:08:42.990
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember, Councilmember Traja.

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1515
04:08:44.530 --> 04:08:50.820
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor. Thank you, colleagues. I want to begin with a shared truth.

1516
04:08:50.990 --> 04:08:58.920
Boardroom: We all care deeply about making Berkeley a place where people can afford to live, work, create, and belong.

1517
04:08:59.120 --> 04:09:02.070
Boardroom: In short, a Berkeley we can all call home.

1518
04:09:02.250 --> 04:09:08.519
Boardroom: We hear from young families, students, and working professionals who want to stay here and cannot.

1519
04:09:08.950 --> 04:09:22.559
Boardroom: We also hear from small businesses who are holding the cultural and economic heart of our neighborhoods, and from property owners who are navigating real financial pressures and real uncertainty in this market.

1520
04:09:23.400 --> 04:09:26.800
Boardroom: So the question is not whether we need more housing.

1521
04:09:26.900 --> 04:09:28.679
Boardroom: Which we absolutely do.

1522
04:09:29.300 --> 04:09:34.149
Boardroom: The question is how we create this housing? How do weâ€¦

1523
04:09:34.430 --> 04:09:40.120
Boardroom: Affirmatively for their fair housing in a way that strengthens our communities.

1524
04:09:44.210 --> 04:09:48.410
Boardroom: There are twoâ€¦ values here.

1525
04:09:48.660 --> 04:09:53.150
Boardroom: That may, at first glance, appear to be intention.

1526

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04:09:53.430 --> 04:09:54.920
Boardroom: But don't have to be.

1527
04:09:55.610 --> 04:10:05.970
Boardroom: And I am confident That, by the time We, as a community, together, Figure this out.

1528
04:10:06.520 --> 04:10:09.580
Boardroom: They will not be in tension anymore.

1529
04:10:09.940 --> 04:10:24.590
Boardroom: We do need to understand the impacts on small businesses. Construction can be extremely disruptive. Businesses rely on consistent foot traffic, predictable customer patterns, and stable rent conditions.

1530
04:10:24.830 --> 04:10:29.220
Boardroom: If we're encouraging redevelopment along our most vibrant corridors.

1531
04:10:30.400 --> 04:10:36.739
Boardroom: What is our concrete plan to support the businesses that make these corridors vibrant in the first place?

1532
04:10:37.100 --> 04:10:44.909
Boardroom: We want them to still be here when new residents arrive, not replaced by empty storefronts or national chains.

1533
04:10:46.200 --> 04:10:49.410
Boardroom: And we must acknowledge the mixed incentives.

1534
04:10:49.640 --> 04:10:51.570
Boardroom: Facing property owners.

1535
04:10:51.800 --> 04:10:56.030
Boardroom: Some want stability, and want to keep neighborhoods serving businesses.

1536
04:10:56.880 --> 04:10:57.900
Boardroom: Others?

1537
04:10:58.100 --> 04:11:05.859

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Boardroom: Probably no one that attended tonight. May hold properties vacant, waiting for redevelopment.

1538
04:11:06.430 --> 04:11:12.809
Boardroom: And these dynamics have real consequences for street life, economic diversity, and cultural identity.

1539
04:11:13.170 --> 04:11:17.909
Boardroom: So how are we accounting for this variability in policy design?

1540
04:11:18.290 --> 04:11:26.080
Boardroom: We have lived through the very real impact of stout construction and unfinished projects in my district.

1541
04:11:27.210 --> 04:11:34.340
Boardroom: A condition that predates my time on the Council, but one that we are absolutely committed to resolving.

1542
04:11:35.520 --> 04:11:44.969
Boardroom: We need clear safeguards and performance standards to prevent long-term commercial vacancies called shells and fenced-off lots.

1543
04:11:47.900 --> 04:11:49.870
Boardroom: There is a path here.

1544
04:11:50.650 --> 04:12:00.150
Boardroom: I was heartened to hear, staff's responses to my questions around how do we protect these small businesses.

1545
04:12:01.380 --> 04:12:07.730
Boardroom: I was very, confident about my vote in support of middle housing.

1546
04:12:08.070 --> 04:12:09.150
Boardroom: Becauseâ€¦

1547
04:12:09.510 --> 04:12:21.489
Boardroom: I believe this was the first council meeting, after I was sworn in. I also voted for what I believe to be, one of the strongest demolition ordinances in the nation.

1548

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04:12:22.270 --> 04:12:39.420
Boardroom: We, unfortunately, are constitutionally barred from having those same levels of protection, but I want to work with all of you and with staff to figure out what we are able to do to keep small businesses here.

1549
04:12:39.510 --> 04:12:43.129
Boardroom: Just gonna briefly respond,

1550
04:12:43.360 --> 04:12:48.220
Boardroom: To feedback topics on zoning alternatives around height.

1551
04:12:48.570 --> 04:12:51.870
Boardroom: I agree with the Planning Commission's recommendation.

1552
04:12:52.070 --> 04:12:52.880
Boardroom: that.

1553
04:12:53.050 --> 04:12:59.239
Boardroom: Perhaps what matters most is, what we're doing to, keep

1554
04:12:59.380 --> 04:13:06.490
Boardroom: The vitality of the neighborhood, so this may be, somewhat context-specific.

1555
04:13:06.890 --> 04:13:17.510
Boardroom: Similarly, with the, upper floor step back, I, I, I do believe to further housing,

1556
04:13:17.510 --> 04:13:34.290
Boardroom: I support, there not being a step back on the main street, but I certainly understand the reason and, would be open to having, a step back, going, towards the residential neighborhoods.

1557
04:13:34.530 --> 04:13:43.330
Boardroom: On ground floor, I support, transit, havingâ€¦ commercial, storefronts.

1558
04:13:43.810 --> 04:13:54.799
Boardroom: On the ground floor, concentrated along, certain nodes, andâ€¦ 30 seconds,

1559

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04:13:54.980 --> 04:14:10.660
Boardroom: I very much support objective design standards. Councilmember O'Keefe and I used to be on a committee to try to develop them, and maybe we can actually get it done here. I wanted no design standards.

1560
04:14:11.060 --> 04:14:11.900
Boardroom: Oh my god.

1561
04:14:12.030 --> 04:14:28.359
Boardroom: I support thinking beyond these particular resource-rich areas. Some commenters have said, let's look at the north side of Sacramento, or south side of Sacramento, other, wide arteries.

1562
04:14:28.530 --> 04:14:36.069
Boardroom: I am very open to looking at those as well. And lastly,

1563
04:14:36.350 --> 04:14:52.460
Boardroom: I very much support flexibility, including, being creative around having live-work, looking at what San Francisco is doing, that can be our North Star right now. You're a minute over now, so I justâ€¦ please, if you canâ€¦ Yeah.

1564
04:14:52.460 --> 04:15:02.829
Boardroom: We have a responsibility to build housing and to protect the communities we're building it for. And I believe that we do not have to choose one or the other.

1565
04:15:02.950 --> 04:15:16.040
Boardroom: The goal is to do both well with care, and I am committed to working with all of you and the neighborhoods and our small businesses, and we'll be reaching out to those in our district. Thank you. â€¦to do that.

1566
04:15:16.380 --> 04:15:18.219
Boardroom: Okay, Councilmember Humber Humbert.

1567
04:15:18.760 --> 04:15:29.319
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor, and I bargained with the Mayor to get a couple extra minutes by promising not to ask too many questions, so I'm gonna try to wrap this up within 7.

1568
04:15:29.360 --> 04:15:42.629
Boardroom: Thank you, Director Klein, Uttaro Ramakrishna, and Justin Horner, and the planning staff for all your work on this really important

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effort. Thanks to the consultant team, who produced such a thoughtful report, and I want to thank

1569
04:15:42.630 --> 04:15:55.650
Boardroom: the entire team for the outreach they've done so far, and I know they will continue to do, and, you know, casting no shade, but let's do even more. I think it's really critical, and that's what we heard tonight.

1570
04:15:55.780 --> 04:16:07.989
Boardroom: Deep thanks to all those who've spoken here tonight, and the vast numbers of Berkeley residents, merchants, a lot from my district, who've sent compelling emails, all of which I've carefully read and considered.

1571
04:16:08.320 --> 04:16:22.260
Boardroom: First, I want to emphasize that I reject arguments that District 8 and the Elmwood should not allow for any new homes, or that they strictly belong elsewhere. I've heard a lot of that, and it's disheartening, and I don't believe in it. It's unfair.

1572
04:16:22.460 --> 04:16:28.600
Boardroom: My conviction that we can't simply say no to any new housing along college is consistent with my strong support

1573
04:16:28.800 --> 04:16:37.600
Boardroom: for middle housing, which upzones significant portions of District 8, and I hope will go a long way to addressing previous exclusionary zoning practices.

1574
04:16:37.600 --> 04:16:53.989
Boardroom: I think that middle housing was the right thing to do, and that we need to continue to take steps, even beyond the corridors of zoning that we're considering here, to make sure that District 8 is building its fair share. I want to see my daughters be able to afford to live a middle-class life in Berkeley. They're in theirâ€¦

1575
04:16:53.990 --> 04:17:13.699
Boardroom: mid to late 20s, and it's really so difficult for them now. I want to see other people's children and grandchildren have the same opportunity to become homeowners if they don't want to be renters in our beautiful community. I want to see people living close to work instead of burning time and carbon, commuting in from exurbs.

1576
04:17:14.030 --> 04:17:28.420

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Boardroom: At the same time, the Elmwood Commercial Corridor faces a number of concerns and constraints that I believe are unique. It's a very narrow street, very small lots, and I believe these argue for a careful, focused approach.

1577
04:17:28.780 --> 04:17:39.320
Boardroom: College is by far the narrowest of the three corridors under consideration, which means maximum building heights would need to be lower to maintain proportionality with the street width.

1578
04:17:39.440 --> 04:17:58.779
Boardroom: I know some of my colleagues don't agree with that. Even more importantly, College Avenue is the shortest of the corridors, comprising essentially only two blocks of retail. When you combine this with the fact that College Avenue has, I think at this point, well, there might be one old storefront that's been empty, but essentially zero retail vacancy.

1579
04:17:58.780 --> 04:18:21.510
Boardroom: This means that any displaced businesses will have nowhere else to go within the district, and that their loss would have a much greater impact within this small and tight-knit shopping area. Additionally, Elmwood has what are currently some of the most continuous pedestrian-oriented retail blocks in Berkeley. Not a single driveway crosses the sidewalks along College Avenue, all the way from Russell.

1580
04:18:21.510 --> 04:18:30.489
Boardroom: to Webster. This differs considerably from the other corridors, where there are multiple existing parcels with auto-oriented parking and driveways facing the sidewalk.

1581
04:18:30.630 --> 04:18:37.430
Boardroom: The only parking areas facing college are at the 7-Eleven and the post office, both at the very edges of the district.

1582
04:18:37.630 --> 04:18:50.170
Boardroom: Indeed, combined with the rear parking lot of the Wells Fargo, which has its driveway on Ashby, these three parcels represent the sole likely opportunity sites for potential development identified by the project team.

1583
04:18:50.170 --> 04:18:58.319
Boardroom: Taken together, I think all of these constraints argue for limiting the rezoning at this time to the three parcels identified as opportunity sites.

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1584
04:18:58.840 --> 04:19:00.670
Boardroom: I want to emphasize

1585
04:19:00.780 --> 04:19:18.889
Boardroom: that taking this approach would have no effect on the projected potential units, as far as I can tell, because these three sites were the ones really deemed likely to redevelop, and thus are the only sites, maybe I'm wrong, the project team calculated build-out 4, but perhaps a fewâ€¦ some additional.

1586
04:19:19.060 --> 04:19:27.000
Boardroom: If we can get the exact same projected housing potential, or something similar, but take an approach that addresses neighbors' and merchants' concerns.

1587
04:19:27.000 --> 04:19:40.750
Boardroom: Why wouldn't we take that opportunity, that approach? In the future, development, economics, or the will of the neighborhood or council may change, the new zoning could be expanded to other parcels, but given what we've heard from stakeholders and what staff

1588
04:19:40.750 --> 04:19:42.199
Boardroom: Have deemed our best

1589
04:19:42.420 --> 04:20:01.720
Boardroom: sites, I think we should work smarter, not harder, when it comes to rezoning, specifically in the Elmwood. I want to also acknowledge the apparent lack of economically feasible housing opportunity along college is understandably disappointing to people who want to see a greater degree of geographic equity, and I agree. This is why

1590
04:20:01.780 --> 04:20:09.399
Boardroom: I want to suggest that we also, not in the context of this project, but immediately after, if we can.

1591
04:20:09.450 --> 04:20:15.629
Boardroom: We look into potentially doing a targeted rezoning of both some upper Claremont parcels

1592
04:20:15.640 --> 04:20:30.939
Boardroom: that currently feature solely auto-oriented uses, such as theâ€¦ as well as the areas of Telegraph Avenue that fall outside the

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Southside Plan. The long stretch from Woolsey to Parker. Taken together, such-up zonings could contribute

1593
04:20:31.010 --> 04:20:47.330
Boardroom: huge multiple, you know, multiples of the housing that's available on the puny little, or the very small area of College Avenue. If the goal is to increase geographic equity and maximize housing production in the high-resource areas.

1594
04:20:47.330 --> 04:20:58.160
Boardroom: Adding Telegraph, which is a high resource area. It's just on the other side of the Elmwood and Willard, and runs through District 8, and along District 8 for its whole length.

1595
04:20:58.160 --> 04:20:59.790
Boardroom: from Woolsey to Parker.

1596
04:20:59.960 --> 04:21:15.220
Boardroom: Having said all of this, I think we ought to look at that, and I think we ought to upzone, Telegraph, because Telegraph is not a thriving commercial district, and noâ€¦ intend to cast no shade, butâ€¦ but it couldâ€¦ it could use a help, it could use a leg up.

1597
04:21:15.220 --> 04:21:30.429
Boardroom: Having said all of this, I understand there are a number of directions this could go, depending on the sentiments of my colleagues. I therefore want to provide a few other specific points of direction tonight that I think will be crucial for any upzoning option and potential housing development in Elmwood.

1598
04:21:30.540 --> 04:21:34.679
Boardroom: One, we preserve active retail frontage along College Avenue.

1599
04:21:34.680 --> 04:21:52.099
Boardroom: Two, in addition to minimum active retail frontage, I would strongly encourage adoption of requirements for any new residential entrances and lobbies to be located at the rear of the buildings, off of College Avenue. I want objective design standards to be ready for adoption concurrent with any rezoning.

1600
04:21:52.100 --> 04:22:16.879
Boardroom: They don't need to be particularly prescriptive, but I want to make sure we're avoiding what are poor design choices, like over-articulated facades. I strongly support objective design standards that mirror Planning Commissioner Alfred Tu's excellent work about reducing

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massing, but increasing visual articulation and ornamentation. This would also be consistent with more traditional building styles and what we currently actually have.

1601
04:22:16.880 --> 04:22:17.680
Boardroom: Elmwood.

1602
04:22:17.680 --> 04:22:30.889
Boardroom: Finally, I want to ensure that a retail retention and relocation program is also put in place at the time of adoption. I know we're legally limited in what we can require in this respect.

1603
04:22:30.890 --> 04:22:39.559
Boardroom: But perhaps some incentives and other carrots and sticks and development agreements could be deployed to ensure that all the corridors retain existing businesses, all of them.

1604
04:22:39.780 --> 04:22:42.699
Boardroom: Again, I want to thank staff and the project team

1605
04:22:43.000 --> 04:22:52.210
Boardroom: And all the Berkeley residents who spoke and emailed me about this effort, I hope my comments tonight demonstrate that even as I remain committed to allowing

1606
04:22:52.210 --> 04:23:06.709
Boardroom: for more homes in our community, I'm listening to and acting on your concerns, and I welcome your continued participation as we take what will be many more additional steps in this effort. It's not over. Thank you. Madam Mayor?

1607
04:23:06.710 --> 04:23:09.010
Boardroom: I move we extend the meeting till midnight.

1608
04:23:09.010 --> 04:23:11.120
Boardroom: Second. Second.

1609
04:23:11.210 --> 04:23:18.040
Boardroom: Okay, is there any objection to that? No. Okay. Then we will extend the meeting until midnight.

1610
04:23:21.060 --> 04:23:31.179

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Boardroom: Sorry, Iâ€¦ so, I'm gonna give up some of my time, just because we went a bit over there. So, I'm gonna move on to Councilmember Bartlett, please.

1611
04:23:32.650 --> 04:23:50.569
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor. And I want to appreciate and join myself to many of the Vice Mayor's comments. You know, Mr. Humbert is Vice Mayor now. No one has mentioned that so far tonight. Yeah, it's important to mention that. It's important. Because we mentioned it when Ben wasâ€¦ You know, you gotta stand up for yourself.

1612
04:23:50.610 --> 04:24:09.889
Boardroom: So, yeah, the, you know, so the land use committee, that I chair, we had a brief opening discussion about, small business retention and the storefront issue, and this is an issue, our conversation tonight has really, driven home the point.

1613
04:24:09.890 --> 04:24:16.029
Boardroom: That we need to really get creative around, preventing our storefront apocalypse.

1614
04:24:16.030 --> 04:24:24.569
Boardroom: And to that end, we are really blessed and fortunate that college is stacked, and it's, the businesses are there.

1615
04:24:24.600 --> 04:24:31.030
Boardroom: And we know from experience, when they have to leave for 2 or 3 years, they don't come back.

1616
04:24:31.100 --> 04:24:35.739
Boardroom: I have a number of places like that in my district, and it's difficult.

1617
04:24:36.090 --> 04:24:54.490
Boardroom: So, you know, I do want to say probably on the college front, those lots are small, so they likely will not be torn down and developed into large buildings. So that's something. If they'd extended it, like I wish they would, wish you would, there are larger lots that you could work with.

1618
04:24:54.530 --> 04:25:03.609
Boardroom: Which could ease the pressure, that I think that our people are feeling on college. But I guess you can't, you're doing the CZ thing.

1619

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04:25:03.730 --> 04:25:05.059
Boardroom: But if you were able to.

1620
04:25:05.810 --> 04:25:23.330
Boardroom: I would urge you to extend the College Avenue arena. And also, the Vice Mayor had great ideas about some spot zoning of parcels around it, which are large, which could draw the development pressure away from the stores.

1621
04:25:23.880 --> 04:25:25.670
Boardroom: And, what else,

1622
04:25:26.410 --> 04:25:36.820
Boardroom: You know, I, of course, you know, having gone through this process, with tremendous vigor for many years, and, having to tangle with my colleagues, andâ€¦

1623
04:25:36.820 --> 04:25:48.110
Boardroom: everyone else in the community and you all, and landing on 7 stories along the Adeline Corridor, you know, I definitely, call me old-fashioned, I just like the whole fairness thing, I want 7 stories everywhere.

1624
04:25:48.930 --> 04:25:49.900
Boardroom: It's justâ€¦

1625
04:25:50.860 --> 04:25:58.989
Boardroom: Call me old-fashioned, what can I say? And, yeah, I think, Vice Mayor, I think,

1626
04:26:00.060 --> 04:26:01.690
Boardroom: The,

1627
04:26:04.620 --> 04:26:15.390
Boardroom: I think those are my key points. Telegraph 2 also could absorb and facilitate some of this pressure. The telegraph region we're talking about is the part that's,

1628
04:26:15.530 --> 04:26:17.780
Boardroom: I guess, to the south.

1629
04:26:17.940 --> 04:26:23.539

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Boardroom: of the era you're thinking of around, my colleague's era, so going down from Dwight

1630
04:26:23.550 --> 04:26:35.319
Boardroom: Dwight towards Ashby, that area that we share, could use development. It is, there'sâ€¦ you'd have very little pushback from the community there, because it's really kind ofâ€¦

1631
04:26:35.320 --> 04:26:48.900
Boardroom: kind of not activated, much in the same way that, parts of Adeline Corridor were not. So I, I, I, I would encourage you to expand, this corridor horizon to Telegraph as well.

1632
04:26:49.300 --> 04:26:55.149
Boardroom: And I think that's all I have to say. And someone mentioned Henry George. Someone mentioned Henry George Economics.

1633
04:26:55.230 --> 04:27:08.229
Boardroom: But that was you at the area. So I'm an old-school Henry Georgist, and you know, I think, and this is, of course, the concept of, of getting revenue from those who utilize the public space, the public goods.

1634
04:27:08.240 --> 04:27:16.470
Boardroom: And I do think that, we will be evolving into that, sooner or later, because it makes the most sense, and it survives theâ€¦

1635
04:27:16.580 --> 04:27:18.229
Boardroom: the wealth concentration.

1636
04:27:18.800 --> 04:27:24.549
Boardroom: So, and more on this later. Thank you. But thank you. Okay, thank you, Councilmember Lunapara.

1637
04:27:24.920 --> 04:27:38.250
Boardroom: Thank you. I have a couple thoughts, and they're a little disorganized, so, sorry. But I first just want to thank staff for the work that has gone into this, for the outreach and the effort that it required.

1638
04:27:38.360 --> 04:27:43.999
Boardroom: I also want to thank, many of the people who showed up tonight to engage in the public process.

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1639
04:27:44.490 --> 04:27:50.220
Boardroom: People are mostly gone, but I stillâ€¦ I want to talk a little bit aboutâ€¦

1640
04:27:50.900 --> 04:28:07.420
Boardroom: I mean, first, what Mayor Ishii mentioned, that we're still in the preliminary stages of this decision-making process. We received emails that they're claiming that there's no public process for this, and I think that that's a little ridiculous. Public outreach was conducted with residents and business owners, and

1641
04:28:07.950 --> 04:28:25.729
Boardroom: Yeah. Secondly, that'sâ€¦ that is how initial data collection processes work. They are based on a representative sample of the population. Third, this is public process. That's why we had this meeting. This is a work session, and there's no formal decision being made tonight, and so we were here to listen to everyone's

1642
04:28:26.000 --> 04:28:26.990
Boardroom: opinions.

1643
04:28:27.160 --> 04:28:38.359
Boardroom: Ourâ€¦ and that will inform our final say, not next week, not next month, not even in 6 months. This is gonna return to Council around July 2026, so we haveâ€¦ we have a lot of time.

1644
04:28:39.820 --> 04:28:51.609
Boardroom: I've also been hearing from neighbors who are conflating the concept of upzoning with the potential destruction of the cherished businesses and vibrant neighborhoods that we love, and I think that this perspective is really unfair.

1645
04:28:51.700 --> 04:29:03.570
Boardroom: Our community is in dire need of more housing, and it is unfair to expect that certain neighborhoods, specifically Districts 1, 2, 3, 4, and 7, should shoulder the entire responsibility of creating new housing.

1646
04:29:03.740 --> 04:29:15.130
Boardroom: An equitable approach to housing requires systemic collaboration across all neighborhoods to ensure the development and preservation of diverse, affordable housing options in a variety of neighborhoods. The wealthiest neighborhoods are not exempt.

1647

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04:29:15.310 --> 04:29:20.800
Boardroom: In fact, with resources concentrated in those areas, they are poised to welcome new neighbors.

1648
04:29:21.180 --> 04:29:24.790
Boardroom: And while I empathize with the businesses that came out here to speak, and I hope that

1649
04:29:24.800 --> 04:29:42.459
Boardroom: they will be included in further versions of this. I do agree with my colleagues that we need to apply the same standard across all commercial corridors across the city, and we should not be treating these high-resource neighborhoods as uniquely in need of protection when we haven't done that for rezoned corridors all over the city.

1650
04:29:42.770 --> 04:30:01.700
Boardroom: I also don't really understand why the height of a building would destroy the livability of neighborhoods or be fatal for businesses. I don't see how a new 3-story building would be fundamentally different from a new 7-story building when the temporary impacts of construction would be the same, but the long-term effect of new neighbors, and therefore new customers and workers, would be multiplied.

1651
04:30:02.100 --> 04:30:19.330
Boardroom: I really appreciated an email that we received from the Elmwoodâ€¦ from Elmwood families refuting the claim that upzoning destroys neighborhoods. They said, quote, more housing is actually what's going to save these neighborhoods from turning into ghost towns. More people will create vibrant, thriving business districts. And actually, the Southside Plan.

1652
04:30:19.330 --> 04:30:36.050
Boardroom: Which is the densest in both residential units and one of the densest in small businesses. And also one of the most vibrant neighborhoods in the city. The Southside Plan has some really great ideas about incentivizing and requiring smaller commercial units to avoid some of the large commercial vacancies that we see.

1653
04:30:36.780 --> 04:30:40.930
Boardroom: I also, I want to clarify that council rights

1654
04:30:41.030 --> 04:30:56.699
Boardroom: and pass this policy, and this is from Council staff, and all the city departments follow Council's direction. So it is misguided, inappropriate, and unacceptable to direct your frustration or anger at our planning director or his staff, who have done so much work for us.

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1655
04:30:56.960 --> 04:31:13.569
Boardroom: The direction to upzone these areas ultimately comes from a state mandate and from the Berkeley City Council, so I and my colleagues are here to listen to your concerns, to answer your questions, and to engage in conversation, because that's our job, but do not castigate staff for doing theirs.

1656
04:31:14.050 --> 04:31:23.329
Boardroom: Finally, I want to concur that I think we should have a minimum of base 7 stories across all the corridors, but between these alternatives, I do prefer Alternative 2.

1657
04:31:23.330 --> 04:31:35.550
Boardroom: Of those presented to us. I don't think that there needs to be upper floor stepbacks, and I think that we should be flexible with the ground floor requirements and not require ground floor commercial outside of the commercial notes. Thank you.

1658
04:31:37.700 --> 04:31:47.850
Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmemberâ€¦ oh, Blackbee, yeah. Great, thanks, and Madam Mayor, I know you and I are the last two standing between us in San Pablo, so I'm gonna try and be real fast.

1659
04:31:47.850 --> 04:31:59.500
Boardroom: I just want to thank staff and the team for their amazing work, the presentation, and I justâ€¦ I doâ€¦ I join my colleagues in thanking, everyone who's come out tonight and participated. This is a work session, this was a workshop.

1660
04:31:59.500 --> 04:32:09.930
Boardroom: this is not the beginning of the end. It may not even be the end of the beginning. So we're very much in the middle of this process. That's what this was designed for, and we appreciate, the feedback.

1661
04:32:09.930 --> 04:32:28.720
Boardroom: I want to associate my comments with, Councilmember O'Keefe, Councilmember Humbert, Councilmember Trega, three of my colleagues whose districts are directly affected by this. I share some of the same concerns they have, and the seeking solutions that sort of balance all the equities here. So I appreciate your leadership and your thought partnership on this.

1662
04:32:30.300 --> 04:32:45.989

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Boardroom: You know, I value the feedback of everyone who came tonight. I value the passion of all the small business owners who came. you know, I know that being a small business person is more than a full-time job, it's more than a livelihood, it's about you, it's your identity, it's who you are.

1663
04:32:45.990 --> 04:32:53.760
Boardroom: So I want to thank you first for caring about the future of these corridors and the city that we all love. We all love, from whatever perspective we come to it.

1664
04:32:53.760 --> 04:33:08.629
Boardroom: And I look forward to continuing this conversation and thinking together about what we want Berkeley to be, not just this year or next year, or 5 years from now, but 25 and 50 years from now. That's really what this effort's all about, and we all need to kind of think big about that.

1665
04:33:08.680 --> 04:33:14.720
Boardroom: You know, Iâ€¦ as I was sitting up here, I've been thinking, you know, I've talked to a number of residents in District 6,

1666
04:33:14.880 --> 04:33:18.560
Boardroom: Many people who are thinking about downsizing at this stage of their life.

1667
04:33:18.580 --> 04:33:36.519
Boardroom: Their kids have moved out, they've got a house, they've got a car, maybe they don't want to drive the car. And they love the cheese board, and they love North Berkeley. How great would it be to have housing where people can move and live, and be walking distance of all these great amenities?

1668
04:33:36.520 --> 04:33:52.590
Boardroom: And then we've got, you know, I think the ideal here is we've got all sorts of people sharing the same spaces together, sharing the same community together, whether you're grandparents and you're retired, or whether you're a student, or whether you're a young family. And I think that's really the vision of where we're trying to get. That's the goal.

1669
04:33:52.590 --> 04:34:04.549
Boardroom: And I think that's a beautiful vision. I think that's great. That's a great aspiration. You know, I believe we can walk and chew gum at the same time. You know, we can build new housing and support our small businesses.

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1670
04:34:04.599 --> 04:34:17.319
Boardroom: We can activate these three corridors and make them even more compelling spaces where we all want to spend time. And I think, again, that's the goal. We have a lot of work to do. Like, we're not there yet. Clearly, you know.

1671
04:34:17.410 --> 04:34:34.470
Boardroom: weâ€¦ well, we have a good start at this product, but we have more engagement to do, we have more communication to do, we have more kind of bridge building to do, and some problem solving to do. And Iâ€¦ but I have confidence with this team, we can do it. Couple of very specific comments,

1672
04:34:34.720 --> 04:34:41.029
Boardroom: I, I also support figuring out ways we can add some of these small business protections.

1673
04:34:41.040 --> 04:35:00.460
Boardroom: I do really think, like we're seeing in the San Pablo plan, if we could add these public realm policies, again, and think about what we want to do with these spaces beyond just how we're zoning them for, for development of housing and how we're protecting the businesses, but really how we're activating these spaces. So I really encourage that to be part of this process if we can.

1674
04:35:00.490 --> 04:35:13.960
Boardroom: But really, it's, you know, let's think bigger, let's work together, my door is open, I went up to a number of people after the session this evening, and I think we all do want the same thing, in the sense of.

1675
04:35:13.960 --> 04:35:24.220
Boardroom: finding a way forward here, and making sure that we're all included in this process, because we share the city, we share these spaces, and we share the vision for where we want the community to go. So, I look forward.

1676
04:35:24.250 --> 04:35:30.089
Boardroom: to the process ahead. Thank you. Thank you. Actually, Councilmember Taplin also has hisâ€¦

1677
04:35:30.290 --> 04:35:36.949
Boardroom: My apologies, very, very, oh, sorry. Very quickly, I would support 8 stories on North Shaddock.

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1678
04:35:37.000 --> 04:35:50.509
Boardroom: I think any consideration of ODS should include cost impact analysis, and should preclude design review. And because no one else has said this, anyone who thinks that the downtown is dead, I invite you to join me any night of the week, and I will show you just how much life there is. Thank you.

1679
04:35:53.270 --> 04:36:07.259
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you so much again to staff, to everyone who came and gave public comments. I really appreciate you all taking the time out of your evenings, to share your thoughts with us, and also for the presentation, just all the time and energy that went into it.

1680
04:36:07.259 --> 04:36:13.699
Boardroom: This is about supporting housing and thriving businesses. We can do both.

1681
04:36:14.110 --> 04:36:24.779
Boardroom: Yes, of course, things will change, and at the same time, we're committed to a fair, transparent, and thoughtful process in partnership with local businesses, residents, and community members.

1682
04:36:24.860 --> 04:36:33.849
Boardroom: It's clear to me that we need to do more outreach, and, that more engagement is needed with the business community, and as Jordan mentioned earlier.

1683
04:36:33.849 --> 04:36:46.699
Boardroom: The planning department's available and interested in meeting with the business owners, community leaders, residents, different groups of folks, so this is your opportunity. If you are looking for a sign.

1684
04:36:46.700 --> 04:36:50.309
Boardroom: It's here, it's now, so please reach out.

1685
04:36:50.310 --> 04:36:57.410
Boardroom: As Jordan said, his staff have, business cards on them, so go ahead and grab one if you haven't already.

1686
04:36:58.390 --> 04:37:16.909
Boardroom: I don't know if people know this, but Jordan actually came to the Planning Department from the Office of Economic Development, so I know that he's really committed to retaining and supporting our vibrant

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commercial districts, and that he really does understand the impacts of housing on business districts, because this is literally the area he used to work in.

1687
04:37:16.950 --> 04:37:22.969
Boardroom: Regarding the specific staff, guidance that staff is looking for,

1688
04:37:23.200 --> 04:37:44.199
Boardroom: I want to say that I agree with my colleagues about consistency. Just to be clear, it's equality, not equity, because if it was equity, we would actually upzone these areas even more. Not to be too smart about it, but I'm just saying, I think that what folks are saying is that we should be equal, and I think that is important to be considering as we're talking about this.

1689
04:37:44.200 --> 04:37:52.400
Boardroom: I am interested in having staff explore the criteria forâ€¦ a potential criteria for zoning overlay for specific opportunity sites.

1690
04:37:52.400 --> 04:38:02.560
Boardroom: As an alternative, especially in the Elmwood, where the streets are more narrow, I understand that there's some cost-benefit, but I'd like to look at what that looks like.

1691
04:38:02.560 --> 04:38:12.900
Boardroom: In terms of ground floor residential, I don't think we should require commercial uses on the ground floor, since I'm really concerned about having too many empty storefronts. We have many empty storefronts in our city.

1692
04:38:12.930 --> 04:38:20.859
Boardroom: And at the same time, of course, we need to consider what we can do to prevent commercial dead zones. So that, of course, can really impact businesses as well.

1693
04:38:21.930 --> 04:38:34.559
Boardroom: For the objective design standards, I really don't have very strong opinions about this. I think it's great to encourage things, and at the same time, I think requiring them can be overly burdensome.

1694
04:38:34.560 --> 04:38:44.359
Boardroom: But I know that we've had conversations about objective design standards that are similar to, like, North Berkeley Bard Station or something, and I think that would be interesting to be able to see.

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1695
04:38:44.740 --> 04:38:48.360
Boardroom: Andâ€¦ Iâ€¦

1696
04:38:49.070 --> 04:38:55.059
Boardroom: want to just come back to this thing that I said at the beginning, that it's about supporting

1697
04:38:55.290 --> 04:39:14.030
Boardroom: housing and thriving businesses. We don't have to pick. I love our business community. I shop in all these stores, all these folks that came today. I'm there quite often. And so I really do want to keep our businesses thriving, and we don'tâ€¦ it doesn't have to be either-or. So, this is our opportunity. We've heard the feedback.

1698
04:39:14.450 --> 04:39:28.940
Boardroom: our staff's gonna take that, and and we're gonna make some adjustments, right? So, thank you all so much. Because this is a work session, that's it. We don't have a vote, so we're gonna move on to the next item.

1699
04:39:29.490 --> 04:39:30.770
Boardroom: Thank you.

1700
04:39:31.790 --> 04:39:35.109
Boardroom: Thank you so much, Councilmembers. If you could just give us twoâ€¦

1701
04:39:35.369 --> 04:39:37.730
Boardroom: Minutes, or maybe even just one.

1702
04:39:38.130 --> 04:39:43.670
Boardroom: First shifting.

1703
04:39:44.180 --> 04:39:53.629
Boardroom: Thank you. Alright, Robert, here we go. How's it going?

1704
04:39:53.920 --> 04:39:55.220
Boardroom: I do.

1705
04:39:58.150 --> 04:40:01.820
Boardroom: Oops. Looking forward to hearing.

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1706
04:40:03.130 --> 04:40:15.899
Boardroom: Alright. How's that room feeling? Good, how are you feeling? I'm feeling good. We're ready. Okay. Can you pull up the deck? Yep. Awesome.

1707
04:40:16.290 --> 04:40:17.110
Boardroom: I'm sorry.

1708
04:40:19.560 --> 04:40:23.320
Boardroom: Okay, I've heard this is about a 15-ish minute presentation.

1709
04:40:23.810 --> 04:40:25.280
Boardroom: Soâ€¦

1710
04:40:25.820 --> 04:40:38.410
Boardroom: All right. Send it to midnight, so let's see, we've got questions, comments, public comments, soâ€¦ ready, set, go! Item 2, San Pablo Avenue-specific plan. I'm gonna turn it over to Senior Planner Robert Rivera.

1711
04:40:39.060 --> 04:40:47.270
Boardroom: All right. Good evening, Councilmembers. Robert Rivera, Senior Planner with the Planning Department and Project Manager of the San Pablo Avenue Specific Plan.

1712
04:40:47.480 --> 04:41:02.769
Boardroom: Here's our agenda for this evening. Tonight, I'll discuss the project background and provide a summary of the outreach we've done to date. Then I'll provide an overview of the specific plan and how it's organized. I'll review policies from the specific plan as it relates to

1713
04:41:02.790 --> 04:41:09.829
Boardroom: what we've heard and the overall vision and desired results of the plan, providing discussion questions as I go along.

1714
04:41:10.130 --> 04:41:17.189
Boardroom: Then I'll close by discussing how the specific plan relates to West Berkeley, and lastly, provide next steps.

1715
04:41:18.530 --> 04:41:31.489
Boardroom: Before we discuss our outreach, I want to briefly discuss why we're conducting a specific plan. There are 3 main drivers to this

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specific plan process. One is City Council referral. In 2015, City Council

1716
04:41:31.490 --> 04:41:38.659
Boardroom: In recognition of the need for a robust plan for the corridor, referred staff to develop a plan that could guide development.

1717
04:41:38.740 --> 04:41:57.679
Boardroom: Second is available funding. ABAG and MTC designated San Pablo Avenue as a Priority Development Area, or PDA, in their long-range planning efforts. This designation provided access to dedicated funding, and the City of Berkeley in February of 2021 applied and were awarded with

1718
04:41:57.680 --> 04:42:07.089
Boardroom: approximately $750,000 in planning grant funds for San Pablo Avenue. And lastly, the recently adopted housing element includes Program 27,

1719
04:42:07.090 --> 04:42:18.510
Boardroom: Which directs staff to develop a plan which will increase allowed densities and or development capacity, and study design standards, public improvements, and mechanisms to incentivize affordable housing.

1720
04:42:20.520 --> 04:42:32.530
Boardroom: Just to ground us, here's a map of the specific plan boundary. The specific plan boundary comes from the MDC-defined PDA, and includes parcels currently zoned as West Berkeley Commercial.

1721
04:42:32.610 --> 04:42:42.619
Boardroom: In addition, the plan boundary was refined to capture additional opportunity sites, and the specific plan is also within the larger West Berkeley plan area.

1722
04:42:44.950 --> 04:43:04.599
Boardroom: Here's our community engagement and plan development process to date. The specific planning process started in 2023 and included key community leader interviews, target intercept surveys, small group meetings, and a community open house where staff received feedback and comments related to the general condition of the corridor.

1723
04:43:04.600 --> 04:43:13.789

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Boardroom: Staff ask questions like, what resources would be most important, which areas would you like to see prioritized, and what is your future vision of the corridor?

1724
04:43:14.010 --> 04:43:27.390
Boardroom: The feedback from Phase 1 directly impacted the formation of policies that were presented in Phase 2 of this specific plan. In Phase 2, staff presented these proposed policies for more feedback and refinement.

1725
04:43:27.390 --> 04:43:37.379
Boardroom: We held pop-ups at various events, including a walking tour of the corridor, and conducted a community workshop to discuss height and massing in public open space.

1726
04:43:37.840 --> 04:43:51.180
Boardroom: In this current phase, we're excited to present the public review draft of the specific plan and receive even more feedback. Staff recently distributed flyers on the corridor and held a review session for the specific plan last week.

1727
04:43:51.190 --> 04:44:09.850
Boardroom: Over 65 community members attended, provided feedback and comments on the proposed policies, and we anticipate even more discussion as we present the specific plan at various hearings in the year, with our aim to incorporate feedback and prepare a final draft for adoption by the middle of next year.

1728
04:44:11.970 --> 04:44:27.000
Boardroom: Before I provide an overview of the specific plan, I wanted to touch on some of the key findings from our existing conditions work, starting with community demographics and equity. A demographic analysis was conducted for the study area to highlight how the community has changed over time.

1729
04:44:27.160 --> 04:44:39.030
Boardroom: Much of the area was historically redlined in the 1930s, which shaped the neighborhood's demographic, with many Black, Asian, and other racial and ethnic communities settling in South and West Berkeley.

1730
04:44:39.080 --> 04:44:53.869
Boardroom: Today, more than half of the study area is designated as an equity priority community, which is a regional designation used to target funding for affordable housing, transportation, and land use improvements in areas impacted by historic inequities.

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1731
04:44:53.950 --> 04:45:09.150
Boardroom: As neighborhoods within the study area continue to grow, demographic shifts have varied across racial and ethnic groups. From 2000 to 2020, the white population increased by over 45%, while the black population decreased by over 39%.

1732
04:45:09.510 --> 04:45:18.559
Boardroom: Even with these changes, the corridor remains one of Berkeley's most diverse areas, and has a greater racial and ethnic diversity compared to the city as a whole, and Alameda County.

1733
04:45:19.540 --> 04:45:32.769
Boardroom: With regards to commercial activity, Santa Pablo Avenue is Berkeley's largest commercial corridor and functions more as a regional destination for specific uses, rather than a walkable neighborhood-serving commercial district.

1734
04:45:32.810 --> 04:45:48.110
Boardroom: The corridor contains a variety of existing commercial uses and serves as a home to many small, locally-owned businesses, light industrial uses, service providers, and community institutions that reflect the neighborhood's cultural and economic diversity.

1735
04:45:48.200 --> 04:46:01.580
Boardroom: An assessment conducted as part of the specific plan indicates that approximately 90% of the brick-and-mortar businesses are locally owned, with 21% being women-owned and 41% being owned by people of color.

1736
04:46:01.990 --> 04:46:19.250
Boardroom: Ground floor vacancy rates by square footage doubled between 2017 and 2020, from 5.5% to 10.8%, peaking at about 15.5% in 2023, but recently has declined to 7.1% in 2024.

1737
04:46:19.490 --> 04:46:28.970
Boardroom: Retail sales tax is the largest source of tax revenue for the area, larger than food and beverage taxes, and professional and business service taxes.

1738
04:46:31.020 --> 04:46:49.240
Boardroom: Some of the existing transportation and public space conditions. Originally part of the Lincoln Highway, San Pablo Avenue has long served as a major regional and national transportation route, and remains designated as a state highway, which means any improvements within the right-of-way require approval by Caltrans.

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1739
04:46:49.240 --> 04:46:54.600
Boardroom: There are also ongoing projects by Alameda CTC, which include safety enhancements.

1740
04:46:54.600 --> 04:46:58.869
Boardroom: Parallel bike improvements, and bus lane and bike lane improvements.

1741
04:46:59.350 --> 04:47:11.759
Boardroom: Staff conducted public realm and open space analysis, evaluating the streetscape conditions and its elements, such as sidewalks, landscaping, street furnishing, lighting, and building and site frontages.

1742
04:47:11.800 --> 04:47:18.030
Boardroom: One finding, and a major public comment, is there are no public parks along San Pablo Avenue.

1743
04:47:18.070 --> 04:47:24.249
Boardroom: or within the specific plant area, which means the sidewalks are the only public space along San Pablo Avenue.

1744
04:47:24.260 --> 04:47:43.930
Boardroom: The sidewalk conditions vary, but are typically 13 feet wide, but are narrower compared to the preferred width guidance in the city's 2020 pedestrian plan. Some stretches along San Pablo Avenue feature a consistent tree canopy and active storefronts that create a more pedestrian-friendly setting, but these remain the exception.

1745
04:47:45.900 --> 04:48:04.460
Boardroom: As we presented this information to the community, we've heard a variety of feedback. In all our outreach events, staff received support for affordable, mixed-income, high-density housing, but there were concerns about architectural details. Some folks were concerned that excessive building height and massing could diminish the public realm.

1746
04:48:04.500 --> 04:48:12.670
Boardroom: However, the community as a whole recognizes that San Pablo provides opportunities to address regional and local housing issues.

1747
04:48:12.830 --> 04:48:27.979
Boardroom: The community expressed frustration with poor sidewalks and expressed a desire for safer, greener, more vibrant public realm, and

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there was strong interest in active, flexible ground floor uses to reduce vacancy and improve vibrancy along the corridor.

1748
04:48:30.090 --> 04:48:42.459
Boardroom: Overall, community members expressed their vision that San Pablo Avenue will be a vibrant mixed-use district that connects neighborhoods, supports a variety of housing and local business, and reflects Berkeley's cultural heritage.

1749
04:48:44.120 --> 04:49:00.320
Boardroom: Staff has translated that overall vision into four key areas of positive change, or our overall desired results from the specific plan. Each of these goals will be addressed through policies, programs, development standards, incentives, and other implementation strategies.

1750
04:49:00.380 --> 04:49:14.540
Boardroom: First, we aim to increase the diversity of housing types and the overall supply of housing to better serve a range of households. This includes creating opportunities for affordable housing, live-work housing, and family-friendly housing units.

1751
04:49:14.540 --> 04:49:25.440
Boardroom: Second, we want to increase business activity to support a thriving community. This includes expanding allowed uses, such as temporary pop-ups, makerspaces, and public markets.

1752
04:49:25.510 --> 04:49:28.700
Boardroom: And providing support for local small businesses.

1753
04:49:28.760 --> 04:49:46.510
Boardroom: Third, the plan seeks to enhance interaction between private and public spaces, encouraging designs that connect buildings, streets, and open areas to create a more vibrant, engaging public realm. And lastly, we aim to improve local and citywide access by strengthening connections to parks, schools.

1754
04:49:46.510 --> 04:49:53.140
Boardroom: neighborhoods, employment and commercial centers, as well as major destinations like BART, downtown, and UC Berkeley.

1755
04:49:55.420 --> 04:50:14.899
Boardroom: Here's how the specific plan is organized. The first two chapters, the introduction and the vision, provide background on the planning process to date and set the stage for the rest of the document. Those are followed by the main chapters, land use, economic development,

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streets, transportation, and the public realm, including utilities, and finally, implementation.

1756
04:50:15.400 --> 04:50:23.619
Boardroom: Each of these chapters connects to the objective design standards, which refine and provide more detailed development standards within the specific plan.

1757
04:50:24.090 --> 04:50:36.370
Boardroom: As you'll see throughout the presentation, many of the policies and objectives are interrelated. I'll begin each section by reviewing what we've heard from the community, the desired results, and review the policies.

1758
04:50:36.480 --> 04:50:40.939
Boardroom: I'll end each section by providing some discussion questions before I move on to the next one.

1759
04:50:42.510 --> 04:51:02.050
Boardroom: Starting with land use, the community expressed a desire for more housing, both in quantity and diversity of housing types. Overall, the community agreed that the nodes should be the focus of the plan area. Community members who want more affordable mixed-income housing were also concerned about excessive height and massing.

1760
04:51:02.160 --> 04:51:07.400
Boardroom: Across all outreach events, community members were concerned about the high storefront vacancy rates.

1761
04:51:07.790 --> 04:51:15.630
Boardroom: And the following land use policies are intended to increase the variety of housing types and increase the overall supply while supporting business activity.

1762
04:51:18.010 --> 04:51:29.989
Boardroom: First, in order to update standards and create a zoning framework, staff is proposing a new commercial San Pablo zoning district that will replace the existing CW, West Berkeley Commercial District.

1763
04:51:31.240 --> 04:51:50.580
Boardroom: Staff is also proposing to keep the nodes, but proposing two types of nodes, allowing greater residential and commercial intensity in Tier 1 nodes, and then Tier 2 nodes. Tier 1 nodes being intersections of University, Gilman, and Ashby, and San Pablo, and Tier 2 nodes being Cedar and Dwight and San Pablo.

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1764
04:51:51.960 --> 04:52:06.409
Boardroom: Staff is also proposing a housing overlay on 6 newly designated parcels within the plan area to allow and encourage 100% affordable housing and family-friendly units. Again, this would apply to 6 parcels designated

1765
04:52:06.770 --> 04:52:09.140
Boardroom: Muly within the specific plan boundary.

1766
04:52:10.930 --> 04:52:28.009
Boardroom: Here are the existing and proposed development standards for the proposed commercial San Pablo zoning district. The maximum height currently allowed by the existing CW zoning district is 40 feet and 3 stories for single use, and 50 feet and 4 stories for mixed use

1767
04:52:28.010 --> 04:52:32.500
Boardroom: Regardless of location. And ground floor commercial is required within the nodes.

1768
04:52:32.690 --> 04:52:42.539
Boardroom: The maximum height proposal in Tier 1 nodes, which are at University and Gilman and Ashby, would be 85 feet and 8 stories.

1769
04:52:42.690 --> 04:52:50.950
Boardroom: The maximum height proposed in Tier 2 nodes would be 65 feet and 6 stories, which are Cedar and Dwight.

1770
04:52:51.000 --> 04:53:03.170
Boardroom: While development standards outside of nodes would be proposed to be a maximum height of 55 feet and 5 stories, and then ground floor commercial would still remain required within those nodes.

1771
04:53:05.200 --> 04:53:10.659
Boardroom: Questions for Council related to land use. Are the proposed development standards appropriate?

1772
04:53:10.830 --> 04:53:17.340
Boardroom: Should there be different development standards in the nodes, and should the specific plan include the proposed housing overlay?

1773
04:53:19.850 --> 04:53:33.220

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Boardroom: The land use chapter is also proposing to establish a San Pablo Avenue local density bonus program. This local density bonus program would provide an alternative to the state density bonus program. Under current state density bonus law.

1774
04:53:33.220 --> 04:53:46.209
Boardroom: Developers are able to waive or reduce development standards set by the city. This alternative would allow developers to pay an in-lieu fee to the city's Affordable Housing Trust Fund, to receive a similar density bonus.

1775
04:53:46.260 --> 04:54:03.730
Boardroom: However, in exchange, the city would ask developers to follow certain objective design standards, such as open space requirements, ground floor commercial requirements, such as minimum depth and improvements like grease interceptors, as well as building facade articulation and massing requirements.

1776
04:54:05.300 --> 04:54:16.060
Boardroom: Moving on to economic development, what we've heard from the community is a desire for a mix of local-serving businesses, affordable retail, and a variety of restaurants, cafes, and bars.

1777
04:54:16.120 --> 04:54:32.489
Boardroom: However, input from businesses, architects, and developer stakeholders identified challenges that hindered the ground floor commercial use. Retail professionals cited an oversupply of commercial space along the corridor, and businesses reported high

1778
04:54:32.670 --> 04:54:33.420
Boardroom: Sorry.

1779
04:54:34.350 --> 04:54:49.800
Boardroom: Businesses reported high tenant improvement costs that are either cost prohibitive or not suitable for many small businesses' needs because they're too shallow or unimproved. The following policies are intended to increase business activity and support a thriving community.

1780
04:54:52.910 --> 04:55:12.860
Boardroom: The next policy is related to economic development. The policy would create a ground floor commercial in-lieu fee for spaces outside of the nodes. This in-lieu fee would allow residential ground floor instead of the required commercial space for only properties outside of the nodes, thereby concentrating commercial space within the nodes.

1781

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04:55:13.040 --> 04:55:21.140
Boardroom: Funds from this policy would be allocated to other economic development policies, like strengthening the city's revolving loan fund.

1782
04:55:21.200 --> 04:55:37.040
Boardroom: Revenue generated from the commercial in-lieu fee would supplement the City's revolving loan fund to provide targeted financial assistance to small businesses for tenant improvements, assistance in relocation within the plan area due to redevelopment and succession planning.

1783
04:55:37.350 --> 04:55:54.069
Boardroom: The specific plan would also propose to initiate a study to evaluate the feasibility and scope of forming one or more business improvement districts in the plan area. The study would assess a range of coverage and could explore extensions into portions of West Berkeley outside of the plan area.

1784
04:55:56.090 --> 04:56:08.459
Boardroom: Questions related to economic development, are there specific economic development policies that should not be included in this specific plan, or are there any other economic development policies or strategies that the plan should consider?

1785
04:56:11.420 --> 04:56:24.870
Boardroom: Moving on to the public realm, community members expressed support for buildings with engaging and active building frontages. Concerns were expressed that new developments are creating urban gated communities that are nice to live in, but not to live around.

1786
04:56:25.030 --> 04:56:35.590
Boardroom: Participants also would like to see ground floor and underutilized space become community gathering spaces for outdoor events, food trucks, and pop-up retail to support local businesses.

1787
04:56:35.800 --> 04:56:43.179
Boardroom: The intent of the following policies are to enhance the interaction between public and private spaces, and enhance local and citywide access.

1788
04:56:44.530 --> 04:56:57.859
Boardroom: The specific plan proposes policies to incentivize the widening of sidewalks, and is proposing objective standards to define sidewalk zones with a requirement to restore full sidewalks as redevelopment occurs.

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1789
04:56:57.990 --> 04:57:07.689
Boardroom: As a land use policy, the specific plan is proposing incentives for sidewalk easements and requirements to provide privately owned public open spaces.

1790
04:57:09.040 --> 04:57:20.000
Boardroom: The specific plan would also look to encourage converting up to 10 minor street segments into side street plazas by limiting or removing vehicle access at intersections within San Pablo Avenue.

1791
04:57:20.190 --> 04:57:26.180
Boardroom: Land use policies would also create incentives for adjacent development to provide side street plazas.

1792
04:57:26.350 --> 04:57:43.759
Boardroom: With regards to safety, the specific plan also includes strategies to reduce vehicle speeds and improve overall safety for all transit modes, prioritizing pedestrian and bicycle improvements on streets that provide access to schools, parks, and connections to major destinations.

1793
04:57:45.060 --> 04:57:54.970
Boardroom: Questions related to the public realm, are the proposed street designs and mobility strategies sufficient to address safety and comfort for all travel modes along San Papo Avenue?

1794
04:57:56.610 --> 04:58:10.180
Boardroom: As included in the staff report, the draft plan includes a detailed objective design standard document. The ODS defined requirements based on different building types, ranging from townhomes to medium and large high-rise developments.

1795
04:58:10.180 --> 04:58:17.289
Boardroom: The ODS defines standards for building massing, articulation, and includes details for roof treatments and fenestration.

1796
04:58:17.290 --> 04:58:26.380
Boardroom: They also defined standards for how certain uses engage with the sidewalk and public realm to create a more engaging and comfortable pedestrian environment.

1797
04:58:26.380 --> 04:58:43.360
Boardroom: This includes how ground floor residential units are designed to balance the desire for active, building frontage with adequate privacy

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for ground floor residents, and include requirements for commercial spaces, defining minimum commercial depth, and even improvements like venting and grease interceptors.

1798
04:58:45.210 --> 04:59:00.870
Boardroom: Questions related to objective design standards. To what extent should the specific plan incorporate objective design standards? How can the specific plan balance inclusion of ODS with flexibility to avoid being overly prescriptive? And should ODS

1799
04:59:00.870 --> 04:59:07.839
Boardroom: be applied to all projects, or only certain types, and should ODAS replace design review requirements?

1800
04:59:10.030 --> 04:59:21.660
Boardroom: The following map shows the intersection of West Berkeley Plan and the San Pablo Avenue specific plan. As part of the specific plan process, because the plan intersects portions of the West Berkeley Plan.

1801
04:59:21.660 --> 04:59:34.360
Boardroom: Staff must amend the West Berkeley Plan and update sections related to San Pablo. As part of the planning process, staff conducted an assessment of the West Berkeley Plan and found that a large majority of the West Berkeley Plan

1802
04:59:34.490 --> 04:59:43.899
Boardroom: implementation measures have been completed. Any future updates to the specific plan and West Berkeley Plan area would require a general plan amendment.

1803
04:59:43.900 --> 04:59:59.869
Boardroom: which is a limited process compared to a zoning amendment. General plan amendments are limited to 4 amendments a year. Given that a large majority of the West Berkeley Plan implementation measures have been completed, another option would be to retire the West Berkeley Plan.

1804
05:00:00.070 --> 05:00:15.379
Boardroom: Retirement of the West Berkeley Plan could simplify future policy developments in West Berkeley and allow for greater policy flexibility. However, staff could propose only amendments necessary to enact the policies included in the specific plan.

1805
05:00:15.770 --> 05:00:23.960

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Boardroom: Questions for Council is, should the West Berkeley Plan be amended specifically to enact this specific plan, or should it be retired altogether?

1806
05:00:27.140 --> 05:00:43.159
Boardroom: Here are our next steps. The public review draft is available on the City's website for comments until mid-January. Staff anticipates attending a variety of hearings and will present at the Transportation Infrastructure Commission, as well as multiple future hearings at Planning Commission and Council.

1807
05:00:43.170 --> 05:00:57.930
Boardroom: After receiving and compiling feedback, staff will begin preparation of the final draft plan, with the goal of plan adoption by the end of spring, or beginning of summer in 2026. And this concludes staff's presentation, and I'm available for any questions.

1808
05:00:58.410 --> 05:01:02.970
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Councilmember Taplin, do you want to start with some questions?

1809
05:01:04.700 --> 05:01:10.239
Boardroom: Just questions. Thanks. I just have one question, can we see the plan study area? Sure.

1810
05:01:15.230 --> 05:01:18.300
Boardroom: Okay, sorry.

1811
05:01:22.030 --> 05:01:27.709
Boardroom: You mentioned that there were no parks in the planned study area.

1812
05:01:27.860 --> 05:01:32.640
Boardroom: Does that mean that George Florence is outside of the planned study area?

1813
05:01:33.600 --> 05:01:34.810
Boardroom: Here's the planets that I eat.

1814
05:01:35.020 --> 05:01:36.010
Boardroom: Georgeâ€¦

1815
05:01:37.720 --> 05:01:45.269

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Boardroom: George Florence Pants is within the study area, but I believe it wasn't open, when we were conducting the existing conditions.

1816
05:01:46.600 --> 05:01:52.180
Boardroom: Thank you. It's Strawberry Creek Park in the Plant City area.

1817
05:01:55.970 --> 05:01:59.570
Boardroom: Pardon me? It's Strawberry Creek Park in the Plant City area.

1818
05:02:06.260 --> 05:02:07.480
Boardroom: I don't believe so.

1819
05:02:08.260 --> 05:02:13.300
Boardroom: Great, thank you. Just wanted to, I just wanted to ask, just so people weren'tâ€¦

1820
05:02:13.490 --> 05:02:16.419
Boardroom: Worried that there were no parks anywhere nearby.

1821
05:02:18.350 --> 05:02:21.559
Boardroom: Okay, thank you, Councilmember Trega.

1822
05:02:23.070 --> 05:02:26.589
Boardroom: Thank you. I have, two questions,

1823
05:02:27.130 --> 05:02:35.859
Boardroom: The local density bonus, is essentially what is being contemplated,

1824
05:02:36.110 --> 05:02:50.270
Boardroom: As, described on page 12 of the report, I'mâ€¦ I'm curious whatâ€¦ Would incentivize an applicant

1825
05:02:50.390 --> 05:02:55.069
Boardroom: to chooseâ€¦ This for the local density bonus scheme.

1826
05:02:55.190 --> 05:02:58.510
Boardroom: Where they have to give up certain rights.

1827
05:02:58.690 --> 05:03:07.020

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Boardroom: over the state density bonus. So that's one question. The second one is around the revolving loan fund.

1828
05:03:07.380 --> 05:03:21.330
Boardroom: would this be a separate fund from the one that currently exists? My understanding is citywide for, businesses facing, relocation or other hardships?

1829
05:03:24.400 --> 05:03:31.519
Boardroom: With regards to the local density bonus, our interviews with real estate and, different developers

1830
05:03:31.630 --> 05:03:36.579
Boardroom: Found that theâ€¦ Ability to pay an in-lieu fee?

1831
05:03:36.700 --> 05:03:43.010
Boardroom: Instead of providing on-site affordable housing was enough value that wouldâ€¦

1832
05:03:43.920 --> 05:03:50.450
Boardroom: would be enough of an incentive to encourage, the local density bonus program, and

1833
05:03:50.890 --> 05:03:53.529
Boardroom: And some objective design standards.

1834
05:03:55.830 --> 05:04:11.980
Boardroom: And then with regards to the revolving Loan Fund, as the language is now, it would supplement the revolving loan fund, and could include additional details that may, describe qualifications for, for, use of the funds.

1835
05:04:15.220 --> 05:04:27.270
Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmember Blackaby? Just had one question, about the in-love fee for the ground floor commercial. So this is assuming, then, for a developer, that it's moreâ€¦ it's more desirable to have

1836
05:04:27.640 --> 05:04:33.249
Boardroom: ground floor not be commercial but residential? Like, that's the assumption? Yeah. And so they wouldâ€¦

1837
05:04:33.890 --> 05:04:47.290

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Boardroom: So, in order to be able to do that, they would be motivated to pay this fee? Correct. Okay. And so we'd rather have them pay the fee than just encourage them toâ€¦ I'm just trying to think through how that would work, unless we think it's a desirable in and of itself.

1838
05:04:47.290 --> 05:05:00.210
Boardroom: to create more ground floor residential, in which case we wouldn't want to disincentivize them with a fee, but I was just thinking through that. Yeah, yeah, what we found, looking at the recent development along San Pablo, and the development standards.

1839
05:05:00.210 --> 05:05:09.509
Boardroom: Was that because there was a discrepancy between the height of the single-use and mixed-use, that there was more of an incentive

1840
05:05:09.510 --> 05:05:26.489
Boardroom: forâ€¦ to gain additional floor with mixed-use development. So developers andâ€¦ we're proposing projects with minimal, ground floor commercial spaces that were unimproved in order to achieve that additional story of residential.

1841
05:05:26.590 --> 05:05:29.910
Boardroom: Because of single use, we're allowed the 40.

1842
05:05:29.930 --> 05:05:48.819
Boardroom: 40 feet max, and mixed-use were allowed that 50 feet max. So developers were providing minimal, ground floor commercial, and weren't improving those spaces, and would rather let them sit empty in order to receive the additional residential,

1843
05:05:49.920 --> 05:05:56.299
Boardroom: So this is an attempt to kind of capture that fact. Great, thank you, I justâ€¦ thank you, thanks for helping me explain that, appreciate it.

1844
05:05:56.880 --> 05:05:58.619
Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmember Lunopara?

1845
05:05:59.160 --> 05:06:05.140
Boardroom: Thank you. I also haveâ€¦ I'm not sure I fully understand the local density bonus.

1846
05:06:05.400 --> 05:06:12.199

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Boardroom: portion of things, theâ€¦ I'm gonnaâ€¦ I wanna talk through it, and thenâ€¦ and thenâ€¦

1847
05:06:12.670 --> 05:06:21.750
Boardroom: please correct me. The goal of the state density bonus is to produce more affordable housing units total.

1848
05:06:22.730 --> 05:06:28.759
Boardroom: And in return, they receive a higherâ€¦ they receive concessions and waivers.

1849
05:06:29.050 --> 05:06:36.010
Boardroom: What would the goal of giving them a waiver Here, be.

1850
05:06:37.030 --> 05:06:54.410
Boardroom: So, because of the success of the Affordable Housing Trust Fund to generate more affordable housing, the goal here would be to generate even more funds for the Affordable Housing Trust Fund in exchange for, certain objective design standards that the community has

1851
05:06:54.630 --> 05:06:58.670
Boardroom: has deemed incredibly important. Andâ€¦

1852
05:06:58.880 --> 05:07:11.459
Boardroom: Those funds would be able to pay an in-lieu fee, and have more, higher density, but be required to comply with those objective design standards.

1853
05:07:12.400 --> 05:07:20.479
Boardroom: So, Iâ€¦ Iâ€¦ Don't want this to end up with us having lessâ€¦

1854
05:07:21.420 --> 05:07:31.009
Boardroom: affordable units or the equivalent in funds than we would if they had the state density bonus. It doesn't bother me if they're on-site or not on-site.

1855
05:07:31.260 --> 05:07:36.790
Boardroom: I just don't want to end up with less totalâ€¦ less netâ€¦ affordable housing units.

1856
05:07:38.150 --> 05:07:46.250
Boardroom: And I'm not sureâ€¦ that isn't clear to me here. I don't know if there's moreâ€¦ information on that.

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1857
05:07:47.860 --> 05:07:59.989
Boardroom: No, I appreciate that, and I think that's one of the things we should look at as we consider whether to advance this as part of the final plan, looking at the total number of unit productions, because there likely would be

1858
05:08:00.310 --> 05:08:04.059
Boardroom: at least some kind of trade-off there. I mean, that's why.

1859
05:08:04.290 --> 05:08:16.030
Boardroom: they're incentivized to fee out, rather than provide the units on-site. So, we'll take another look at running those numbers so that any potential trade-offs are clear.

1860
05:08:16.400 --> 05:08:20.890
Boardroom: Thank you, and also, because the density bonus has so many

1861
05:08:21.000 --> 05:08:33.139
Boardroom: pieces to it, where if you provide a little amount of affordable housing versus if you provide 100% affordable housing, how this could also play into thatâ€¦ those many levels of how much money they would fee out.

1862
05:08:33.310 --> 05:08:38.479
Boardroom: Because if we are giving them this local density bonus program and they're choosing to fee out.

1863
05:08:38.760 --> 05:08:44.070
Boardroom: That fee should be higher than what we usually Well, give them.

1864
05:08:44.290 --> 05:08:45.200
Boardroom: Yeah.

1865
05:08:45.370 --> 05:08:53.209
Boardroom: That's it, thanks. Thank you, Councilmember Castarwani. Yes, thank you very much. Oh, I just want to express,

1866
05:08:53.290 --> 05:09:09.499
Boardroom: since Councilmember Lunapada brought up the, local, density bonus, option, that I'm also interested in just more details around that. And then the question I had was around the in-lieu fee to opt out of

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1867
05:09:09.500 --> 05:09:16.149
Boardroom: commercial on the ground floor. I know Councilmember Blackaby asked about that. I guess I'm just not sure of the,

1868
05:09:16.570 --> 05:09:21.440
Boardroom: How does the fee solve the problem that you were describing ofâ€¦

1869
05:09:21.710 --> 05:09:37.170
Boardroom: of, you know, because I think we've all heard that, that developers don't even put the ground floor rent in their pro forma, and so they have no incentive to improve the space so that it can be leased up.

1870
05:09:37.550 --> 05:09:42.040
Boardroom: Soâ€¦ I guess it's hard for me to imagine, like, okay, soâ€¦

1871
05:09:42.040 --> 05:09:59.029
Boardroom: So we charge them a fee, how does that improve the situation? So then they get out of it and they don't have to do commercial? Is that the idea? Correct, yeah. They would not have to provide the ground floor commercial, and then the funds would be used to help support small businesses,

1872
05:09:59.120 --> 05:10:02.849
Boardroom: Within the nodes of the specific plan, area.

1873
05:10:03.950 --> 05:10:22.619
Boardroom: Okay, because our idea is that in the nodes, I mean, that's one of the proposals, in the nodes, we do want to have commercial. So, okay, so the idea of the fee is just for the nodes. Just for outside of the nodes. Or outside of the nodes. Okay.

1874
05:10:24.400 --> 05:10:33.320
Boardroom: Okay, so, so, because we, because we could just do, we could just say, outside the nodes, it doesn't matter. We, you don't have to doâ€¦

1875
05:10:33.320 --> 05:10:48.980
Boardroom: ground floor commercial. We'll let you do office space, or live work, or residential, and then there's no in-lieu fee. And thenâ€¦ but the trade-off is then there's no funds to support the small businesses in the nodes.

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1876
05:10:49.170 --> 05:10:51.440
Boardroom: So it's just sort of,

1877
05:10:51.880 --> 05:10:56.349
Boardroom: Okay, I mean, I guess a lot is riding on how high is this fee?

1878
05:10:56.450 --> 05:11:04.780
Boardroom: Which you haven't stated here, correct? No. Yeah, we would still have to do additional studies to determine a fee that would beâ€¦

1879
05:11:05.220 --> 05:11:20.170
Boardroom: not too high that it deters developers from paying it, but high enough where it can still generate a good number of funds for business support. So, we'd still have to do that analysis. Okay, thank you.

1880
05:11:21.510 --> 05:11:24.600
Boardroom: Yep, those are great questions, thank you all.

1881
05:11:24.730 --> 05:11:30.749
Boardroom: I'm also curious what you think led to the drastic decline of vacancies on San Papo Avenue.

1882
05:11:31.940 --> 05:11:43.090
Boardroom: You mean increase? No, well, decrease, I think it went down. Yeah, it went up and then down. And then down, yeah. I know why it went up. Why did it go down?

1883
05:11:43.770 --> 05:11:51.119
Boardroom: I mean, I would be speculative. I know that theâ€¦ that San Pablo has beenâ€¦

1884
05:11:51.280 --> 05:12:00.060
Boardroom: later to react, to recovery, compared to the other commercial corridors from, from COVID and, and that, but I'mâ€¦

1885
05:12:00.210 --> 05:12:07.379
Boardroom: not 100% sure what led to the sudden drop in vacancy rates in 2024.

1886
05:12:07.560 --> 05:12:19.070

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Boardroom: Okay, we also had a lot of vacancies recently, so we don't have the 2025 numbers yet, so, alright, thank you. I think those are the only questions, so let's go to public comment, and then we're gonna go after that.

1887
05:12:19.180 --> 05:12:24.520
Boardroom: we will go to Council Comments. So, if you knowâ€¦ soâ€¦

1888
05:12:24.720 --> 05:12:28.279
Boardroom: Question? No, I'll move to extend the meeting. Oh.

1889
05:12:28.560 --> 05:12:30.490
Boardroom: So, 1.30.

1890
05:12:30.740 --> 05:12:40.720
Boardroom: 12.30, 1230. 1230. Sorry, sorry, sorry, 12.30. Okay, there's the second. Is there anyâ€¦ is anyone opposed to extending our meeting till 12.30?

1891
05:12:41.630 --> 05:12:45.350
Boardroom: Okay, very good. So, if you have public comment, please line up.

1892
05:12:52.530 --> 05:12:54.299
Boardroom: I seeâ€¦ go ahead, come on up!

1893
05:12:55.480 --> 05:12:57.079
Boardroom: Go ahead. Yep.

1894
05:12:57.570 --> 05:12:59.000
Boardroom: Woo! Okay.

1895
05:13:00.420 --> 05:13:02.170
Boardroom: Hi.

1896
05:13:02.210 --> 05:13:25.060
Boardroom: So different vibes here for San Pablo, which is sort of the point, right? This San Pablo plant is important, it's a corridor that is really struggling. I'm there all the time. I push my kids in a stroller down that street. In my little area north of University, there are probably a couple of dozen shops and restaurants that I treasure just as much as anybody else in any other neighborhood treasures their shops.

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1897
05:13:25.060 --> 05:13:28.759
Boardroom: Something that happened a few years ago was the 99-cent store closed, and

1898
05:13:28.760 --> 05:13:32.520
Boardroom: If you never shopped there, you wouldn't know that it was actually a low-cost grocery store.

1899
05:13:32.520 --> 05:13:34.279
Boardroom: It did not have

1900
05:13:34.280 --> 05:13:57.490
Boardroom: the same clientele that you get down the street at Whole Foods. It was the only place in, I don't know how far, where you could buy affordable, fresh groceries, and I don't know what happened to those people. I don't know, are they driving farther now for their groceries? Are they just not eating fresh food now? This is actually a fragile community, and so we need to be really thoughtful and deliberate and consider the completeness of the community.

1901
05:13:57.490 --> 05:14:01.579
Boardroom: Also, privately owned public spaces often suck, so let's, like.

1902
05:14:01.850 --> 05:14:04.869
Boardroom: Be thoughtful about it. Thank you. Okay.

1903
05:14:05.580 --> 05:14:06.580
Boardroom: Coming up!

1904
05:14:12.350 --> 05:14:18.420
Boardroom: Yeah, so I have, my minute and Donna Diedemar's minute.

1905
05:14:18.640 --> 05:14:42.029
Boardroom: I mightâ€¦ I might have piggies, but I might not need 3 minutes, so I'd like to giveâ€¦ if I don't need the third minuteâ€¦ Why don't you start, and we'll see. And we'll see. But you've got 2 minutes, at least, and then, you know, I know you've got a third in theâ€¦ in the wings. Go ahead. So, mainly what I wanted to talk about was what it would look like, and how it would be a walkableâ€¦

1906
05:14:42.330 --> 05:14:47.080
Boardroom: A walkable, vibrant, place.

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1907
05:14:47.250 --> 05:14:48.970
Boardroom: And,

1908
05:14:49.030 --> 05:15:01.349
Boardroom: Iâ€¦ I think at some point, it should be broke. I don't think all of the retail should be in the nodes, because I could imagine, like, being on Cedar and then having to run.

1909
05:15:01.350 --> 05:15:09.309
Boardroom: Becauseâ€¦ to university, from Node, to Node to go shopping, so I think that should be rethought.

1910
05:15:09.330 --> 05:15:17.439
Boardroom: I know there's been a problem with ground floor residential, and I just think the planners need toâ€¦

1911
05:15:17.650 --> 05:15:29.229
Boardroom: demand. They need to get something from the developers and say, make sure you build adequate, appropriate first floor residential. We've,

1912
05:15:29.400 --> 05:15:44.950
Boardroom: And, you know, this is a commercial corridor. People want to have their amenities. The other night at the planning department meeting, someone mentioned that there should be something really grand on San Pabro Avenue, because it's a grand place.

1913
05:15:45.140 --> 05:15:53.139
Boardroom: And, certainly the Rivoli theater is a grand place, but, I don't think that will be kept in such a state.

1914
05:15:53.430 --> 05:16:09.359
Boardroom: I also hope that we can maintain the cultural, diverse ambience of the businesses and the historical buildings. It's not going to be everyone, but there really needs to be a focus on maintaining that as well.

1915
05:16:09.610 --> 05:16:17.069
Boardroom: And I think thatâ€¦ is about all.

1916
05:16:17.240 --> 05:16:33.149

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Boardroom: The businesses do need their parking, and we know that the new buildings won't have much parking in them, so that really needs to be considered. Every business that I've spoken to, and I've spoken to businesses up and down San Pablo Avenue.

1917
05:16:33.360 --> 05:16:40.079
Boardroom: talked about how their businesses would really close up if there wasn't the parking.

1918
05:16:40.540 --> 05:16:41.730
Boardroom: Thanks, Merrill.

1919
05:16:42.370 --> 05:16:43.709
Boardroom: Come on up, Kelly.

1920
05:16:47.580 --> 05:16:50.290
Boardroom: It's late, I'll try to be coherent.

1921
05:16:50.910 --> 05:16:58.010
Boardroom: Just a couple of things. The design review committee is really important in terms of

1922
05:16:58.370 --> 05:17:05.040
Boardroom: The design of the building, of making it better buildings, and it's not something that really slows down the process.

1923
05:17:05.300 --> 05:17:11.140
Boardroom: So, it would be really disappointing to have that excluded from this process.

1924
05:17:11.220 --> 05:17:28.210
Boardroom: I don't have enough time to go into a lot more. I think a local density bonus is really kind of a poor idea, and I hope that that's not pursued. I just have a lot of concerns, because

1925
05:17:29.050 --> 05:17:41.499
Boardroom: we really need more inclusionary housing, and I'm afraid that with the local density bonus, we'll loseâ€¦ we'll lose inclusionary housing, and we'll really have less affordable housing.

1926
05:17:41.620 --> 05:17:52.470
Boardroom: I think, you know, businesses do better when we have clusters of businesses, and I guess I'mâ€¦ Thanks, Kelly. â€¦out of time.

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1927
05:17:53.300 --> 05:17:57.280
Boardroom: Carol will give you her minute. Okay, go ahead.

1928
05:17:58.320 --> 05:18:06.280
Boardroom: We really do need a lot more study on this, and I would like to say that I've been looking a lot at San Pablo.

1929
05:18:06.280 --> 05:18:31.239
Boardroom: lately, just in terms of getting out and walking, especially looking at the new buildings thatâ€¦ the newer buildings that have gone up on San Pablo. And the frontage is really uninviting, and the businesses that are going in, and we really need to do something aboutâ€¦ we need to have objective standards that make those buildings inviting, because it's not inviting to walk

1930
05:18:31.240 --> 05:18:32.340
Boardroom: bye.

1931
05:18:32.340 --> 05:18:51.740
Boardroom: reflective glass, or a plain wall. And if you just get out and walk that street, and look at theâ€¦ and look at the newâ€¦ the newer projects, and theâ€¦ the frontage on those buildings, or the lack of frontage, it's reallyâ€¦

1932
05:18:51.740 --> 05:19:00.980
Boardroom: It's nothing that you really want to be around, and we have to do much better. I have a lot of ideas I can share later. Thanks, Kelly.

1933
05:19:02.280 --> 05:19:05.250
Boardroom: Did you have a comment? No? Okay.

1934
05:19:05.420 --> 05:19:12.570
Boardroom: Anyone online? Currently I have 3, 4 hands raised for comments onâ€¦

1935
05:19:12.700 --> 05:19:24.460
Boardroom: San Pablo area-specific plan, now is the time to raise your hand if you're on Zoom. And if Diedmar is on, I think they have 2 extra minutes from before.

1936
05:19:24.460 --> 05:19:33.720

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Boardroom: they had had 3, they used one of them, so now there's 2, so justâ€¦ I was keeping track of that in case someone came on just to give him back his minutes, soâ€¦

1937
05:19:33.990 --> 05:19:36.649
Boardroom: Yes, first is Amy Baldwin.

1938
05:19:38.820 --> 05:19:39.810
Boardroom: Oh.

1939
05:19:40.040 --> 05:19:46.100
Boardroom: Yeah. Amy, do youâ€¦ are you withdrawing your minute from Ditamar, or did you want toâ€¦ Keep it.

1940
05:19:46.280 --> 05:19:50.780
aimee baldwin: I thinkâ€¦ I think I'm gonna say my own statement.

1941
05:19:50.930 --> 05:19:55.729
aimee baldwin: I don't know whose minute got used at the lastâ€¦ during the last comment.

1942
05:19:57.090 --> 05:19:59.389
aimee baldwin: I don't know.

1943
05:19:59.450 --> 05:20:19.309
aimee baldwin: One thing I wanted to say was that the Office of Economic Development spoke with the planners about the San Pablo plan, but the Office of Economic Development told me that only business improvement districts have regular meetings with the Office of Economic Development, and San Pablo does not currently have any business improvement districts.

1944
05:20:19.340 --> 05:20:26.219
aimee baldwin: Therefore, the small businesses on San Pablo Avenue have not been represented by the OED.

1945
05:20:26.290 --> 05:20:32.329
aimee baldwin: And I really hope that, even though it is scheduled to close comments.

1946
05:20:32.630 --> 05:20:39.050
aimee baldwin: gatherings in mid-January that I hope the plan will have an opportunity to create.

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1947
05:20:39.110 --> 05:20:50.320
aimee baldwin: a venue for businesses to come and voice their concerns. Another problem is that our city does not have something set up like a commission-style setting where

1948
05:20:50.320 --> 05:20:59.630
aimee baldwin: These conversations could have been going on for years, and everyone would have much more knowledge about the needs of small businesses and business districts, and how to make them work.

1949
05:21:00.160 --> 05:21:02.200
aimee baldwin: And we seem to be reshuffling everything.

1950
05:21:02.200 --> 05:21:02.700
Boardroom: That's funny.

1951
05:21:02.700 --> 05:21:04.770
aimee baldwin: Knowing how it's gonna beâ€¦

1952
05:21:04.770 --> 05:21:10.539
Boardroom: Thank you, Amy. Your time's up. Thank you. Okay, next is, Deepmar Lawrence.

1953
05:21:11.040 --> 05:21:12.689
Boardroom: We'll go 2 minutes.

1954
05:21:12.890 --> 05:21:30.100
Dietmar Lorenz: Hi, yeah, again, I want to express my frustration to see the West Berkeley portion hearings so rushed literally at the 11th hour, and as several council members have noted, the room has emptied. This is not fair. So let me make good use of my time here.

1955
05:21:30.100 --> 05:21:41.909
Dietmar Lorenz: I appreciate that many concerns expressed in the sessions that were held are, in fact, reflected in this draft plan, such as the differentiating of Tier 1 and Tier 2 nodes.

1956
05:21:41.910 --> 05:21:45.279
Dietmar Lorenz: and the importance of the public realm. However.

1957
05:21:45.280 --> 05:21:54.410

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Dietmar Lorenz: Overall, the ODS measures seem a little like a grabback of smaller-scale mitigations. It's hard to see a broader vision

1958
05:21:54.410 --> 05:22:06.819
Dietmar Lorenz: on an urban planning scale, form-based and more muscular, for the lack of a better term. I attended the Planning Commission yesterday, and there were several members who echoed that concern.

1959
05:22:06.860 --> 05:22:07.990
Dietmar Lorenz: Talk to them.

1960
05:22:07.990 --> 05:22:31.270
Dietmar Lorenz: Robert noted that the sidewalks are the only public space along the corridor, and I think that needs more than parklets and other incremental tweaks. San Pablo stretches almost 3 miles from one end of Berkeley to the other. Once built up to 6 to 8 stories, these tall walls would truly form a corridor that would need periodic relief valves in the form of open plazas.

1961
05:22:31.370 --> 05:22:54.459
Dietmar Lorenz: Such truly public plazas would make sense at the Tier 2 nodes, I think. I would call them the community nodes, because they don't have the cross traffic from the freeway entrances. So they are neighborhood nodes, and those have to act as community hubs for the increasing West Berkeley population. Let's keep in mind, 6,700 new units, as proposed here.

1962
05:22:54.460 --> 05:22:56.880
Dietmar Lorenz: At an average Berkeley household size.

1963
05:22:56.880 --> 05:23:02.940
Dietmar Lorenz: size means 18,000 new residents, which is roughly the population of Albany.

1964
05:23:02.940 --> 05:23:19.180
Dietmar Lorenz: Therefore, we can't approach this solely through the lens of stacking apartments. This is about building a city, not a bedroom community for Silicon Valley. And that leads to the goal of the 15-minute city. It doesn't make sense to propose half a million square feet of residential areaâ€¦

1965
05:23:19.180 --> 05:23:20.040
Boardroom: Thanksgiving out.

1966

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05:23:20.040 --> 05:23:23.509
Dietmar Lorenz: commensurate commercial and community amenities. Thank you.

1967
05:23:23.900 --> 05:23:26.210
Boardroom: Thank you. Okay, thank you.

1968
05:23:27.460 --> 05:23:29.530
Boardroom: Next is Theo Gordon.

1969
05:23:31.120 --> 05:23:32.420
Boardroom: Hold on,

1970
05:23:33.400 --> 05:23:34.739
Boardroom: Theo Gordon.

1971
05:23:36.670 --> 05:23:38.380
Boardroom: Wait, notâ€¦ okay, not you.

1972
05:23:38.380 --> 05:23:40.660
Sarah Bell (she/her): Okay, I will unmute myself, sorry.

1973
05:23:42.820 --> 05:23:44.170
Boardroom: Okay, Theo Gordon.

1974
05:23:44.170 --> 05:23:46.340
Theo Gordon: Sorry about that. Hi,

1975
05:23:46.360 --> 05:23:59.430
Theo Gordon: Councilmembers, thank you for, continuing to work on this. I, as you know, homeowner and dad, et cetera, et cetera. I support this plan. Just a few specific points. Don't make this overall too complicated.

1976
05:23:59.430 --> 05:24:17.310
Theo Gordon: Let's not overdo it with popos and nodes and all that, just allow 8 stories everywhere. Let's improve the sidewalks and streetscape. It's a wonderful neighborhood, just like the Elmwood we heard all about earlier tonight, but it's got a highway going down the center. We can get so much more out of that withâ€¦ than just keeping it a car sewer.

1977
05:24:17.310 --> 05:24:19.959

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Theo Gordon: Lastly, but most importantly, I want to talk about equity.

1978
05:24:19.960 --> 05:24:32.470
Theo Gordon: Every neighborhood is special, every neighborhood is someone's backyard, so you have 3 choices. You don't build in anyone's backyard, you banish people to the exurbs, you perpetuateâ€¦ or you perpetuate segregation, and only build in the backyards ofâ€¦

1979
05:24:32.470 --> 05:24:40.540
Theo Gordon: those who have never had a voice, or you treat the city equitably, and allow 8 stories of buildings across all commercial corridors. Thank you.

1980
05:24:40.840 --> 05:24:41.840
Boardroom: Thank you.

1981
05:24:42.830 --> 05:24:45.180
Boardroom: Okay, now Cerebell.

1982
05:24:48.120 --> 05:24:49.969
Sarah Bell (she/her): Thank you so much.

1983
05:24:50.110 --> 05:25:06.879
Sarah Bell (she/her): So, thank you for everybody who put work into this plan. As mentioned before, I live on San Pablo, I love West Berkeley, and I like so much about this plan. I like the idea of incentivizing plazas, widening sidewalks, public open space.

1984
05:25:07.180 --> 05:25:18.859
Sarah Bell (she/her): While I think I like the idea of, higher intensity commercial nodes, I agree with the previous commenter that, we could beâ€¦ we could run the risk of being overly prescriptive.

1985
05:25:18.860 --> 05:25:26.270
Sarah Bell (she/her): I think we should allow intense housing everywhere along the corridor. I think a custom density bonus for ground floor commercial

1986
05:25:26.270 --> 05:25:39.120
Sarah Bell (she/her): Or perhaps from an inlu fee could be good, but let's not make the developers who are already providing a good, that is housing, on tight margins, to pay for our commercial. Let's use carrots, not sticks, to get what we want.

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1987
05:25:39.190 --> 05:25:51.669
Sarah Bell (she/her): I also want to clarify, earlier I asked for 6 stories, but Iâ€¦ but more is better. We should make sure we get to at least 8 stories, and I want to thank every council member who spoke up for treating San Pablo and the other commercial corridors.

1988
05:25:51.670 --> 05:25:52.820
Boardroom: Thank you.

1989
05:25:53.010 --> 05:25:55.200
Boardroom: Thanks, Sarah.

1990
05:25:55.760 --> 05:26:01.769
Boardroom: Oh, okay, we haveâ€¦ You can do it. Come on.

1991
05:26:01.950 --> 05:26:13.060
Boardroom: Thank you, I appreciate it. Just wanted to speak to this and voice support as someoneâ€¦ as a son of aâ€¦ someone who lives a block from the corner of San Pablo and Delaware.

1992
05:26:13.170 --> 05:26:21.199
Boardroom: As you know, my name is Taj. I'm a resident who strongly supports the San Pablo Avenue-specific plan, and in particular, the proposed upzoning along the corridor.

1993
05:26:21.490 --> 05:26:29.709
Boardroom: Citablo is one of our region's most transit-rich, walkable arterials. It is exactly where Berkeley should be placing more homes, including mixed-income and affordable units.

1994
05:26:29.890 --> 05:26:33.559
Boardroom: Close to AC transit lines, bike networks, and daily services.

1995
05:26:34.000 --> 05:26:49.460
Boardroom: We cannot meaningfully respond to our housing shortage, reduce displacement pressure, or achieve our climate goals without increasing the legal capacity to build more homes where people can actually live car-like. And Iâ€¦ also, on this point, I want to second what Theo Gordon said before me about the equity piece of all this.

1996
05:26:49.730 --> 05:26:52.530
Boardroom: I think that's very important that we keep in mind.

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1997
05:26:53.310 --> 05:27:05.330
Boardroom: The corridor already functions as a major urban spine. The zoning in this plan finally recognizes that reality aligns the land use with the transportation and climate frameworks we have already adopted.

1998
05:27:05.780 --> 05:27:13.250
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you. Thanks so much. Okay, going on to Councilmember comments. We're starting with Councilmember Taplin.

1999
05:27:13.250 --> 05:27:27.530
Boardroom: Thank you very much, and thanks, everyone. I may need your help going through the discussion questions. I do have notes here, but I want to make sure I'm not missing anything. Just to quickly share my origin story, as you all know, I grew up down along San Pablo Avenue, my entire world, forâ€¦

2000
05:27:27.640 --> 05:27:47.469
Boardroom: 37 years of my life has been bounded by, Sarah Palin University and, and essentially the East Bay Nursery. I've lived in that little square for all these years, including now, so this is very close to home. Onâ€¦ I do like the tiered node structure.

2001
05:27:47.530 --> 05:27:51.749
Boardroom: I do think, the height should be uniform across.

2002
05:27:52.160 --> 05:27:53.859
Boardroom: I would support 7.

2003
05:27:54.240 --> 05:28:02.320
Boardroom: I'm, and on the Muley overlay, I, you know, I would support

2004
05:28:02.500 --> 05:28:06.100
Boardroom: Allowing conversion of what are currently parking lots.

2005
05:28:06.470 --> 05:28:09.780
Boardroom: Into, multifamily residential.

2006
05:28:09.900 --> 05:28:17.279
Boardroom: Were this overlay to allow and enable, housing technologies that could accommodate family growth?

2007
05:28:17.510 --> 05:28:19.849

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Boardroom: And which would be income integrated.

2008
05:28:21.020 --> 05:28:27.869
Boardroom: Thank you. I'm no on the Popos.

2009
05:28:28.220 --> 05:28:39.080
Boardroom: I think, you know, ODS should be focused primarily on the ground floor to create a pleasant and continuous pedestrian experience.

2010
05:28:39.260 --> 05:28:46.809
Boardroom: That being said, I think it's important that whatever ODS we consider be cost-effective and actually result in the kinds of things you want to see.

2011
05:28:47.050 --> 05:28:52.410
Boardroom: I'm a no on the local density bonus.

2012
05:28:55.270 --> 05:29:05.140
Boardroom: very pleased to see the recommendation to do a bid study. My office has been engaging with several of the merchant clusters in this area over the years.

2013
05:29:05.270 --> 05:29:19.699
Boardroom: we've identified that there is a concentration of organized activity along University and San Pablo, and there are two groups I think would be ideal partners, one being the University Avenue Emergence Association, the other being the International Marketplace.

2014
05:29:21.650 --> 05:29:33.850
Boardroom: And, you know, we're a bid to ever extend beyond that. I think that the, sort of, innovation hub around Aquatic Park could be a potential area.

2015
05:29:35.370 --> 05:29:50.720
Boardroom: And I think, you know, we wouldâ€¦ we would then see two different, populations. We would have merchants versusâ€¦ not versus, we have merchants, and in addition to those, we would have, sort of, large property owners, so we want to think about how we can, sort of, wed the twoâ€¦

2016
05:29:50.940 --> 05:29:52.390
Boardroom: Areas of need.

2017

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05:29:53.290 --> 05:30:01.429
Boardroom: I hated that one. Very supportive of, ofâ€¦

2018
05:30:01.940 --> 05:30:07.460
Boardroom: the idea of having side street plazas, and I want to join my remarks at DMARS regarding that.

2019
05:30:08.740 --> 05:30:14.340
Boardroom: And on the West Berkeley Plan, so this is something that I've actually spent my entireâ€¦

2020
05:30:14.590 --> 05:30:26.380
Boardroom: time in office thinking about, and I've been, like, tinkering with, potential referrals to do a new West Berkeley plan, which I do plan to bring forward next year, so fair warning.

2021
05:30:26.770 --> 05:30:28.300
Boardroom: Paul.

2022
05:30:31.770 --> 05:30:39.070
Boardroom: But forâ€¦ for tonight, I think it would make sense to, amend the parts of the plan thatâ€¦

2023
05:30:39.460 --> 05:30:44.549
Boardroom: Would be specifically required by the adoption of this plan?

2024
05:30:44.850 --> 05:30:53.540
Boardroom: andâ€¦ yeah, because I would want to sunset it without having somethingâ€¦

2025
05:30:53.940 --> 05:30:59.110
Boardroom: to replace it with. I do recognize that the current plan has run its course.

2026
05:30:59.420 --> 05:31:17.539
Boardroom: I doâ€¦ I do see immense value in having a long-term plan for advanced manufacturing, and for the creation of jobs, and for growing a resilient local economy that could leverage both the history of, you know, West Berkeley and Oceanview, andâ€¦

2027
05:31:17.970 --> 05:31:22.480
Boardroom: you knowâ€¦ How we got here today.

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2028
05:31:22.620 --> 05:31:31.699
Boardroom: And balancing that with, you know, the kinds of amazing things we could do when we wed innovation to, creative land use.

2029
05:31:32.880 --> 05:31:38.810
Boardroom: Then have I missed anything?

2030
05:31:41.130 --> 05:31:46.390
Boardroom: We've got 30 seconds left. Streets. Yes,

2031
05:31:47.710 --> 05:31:52.530
Boardroom: Yes, I do acknowledge that ACTC's doing a lot of work here, but I, you knowâ€¦

2032
05:31:52.750 --> 05:31:56.880
Boardroom: I support all safety measures that will improve

2033
05:31:57.370 --> 05:32:12.320
Boardroom: The safety of all road users, pedestrians, cyclists, transit riders, especially, you know, we do have a number of senior homes along the avenue, so having safe crossings are of great concern to me and many of my neighbors.

2034
05:32:15.580 --> 05:32:18.240
Boardroom: Thank you.

2035
05:32:18.390 --> 05:32:24.290
Boardroom: Thank you, and thank you for being so respectful of the 5 minutes. Councilmember Kesarwani.

2036
05:32:26.370 --> 05:32:42.910
Boardroom: Thank you very much, Madam Mayor. I'll try to be as efficient as possible, given the hour. Thank you again, staff, for the presentation, and can you bring backâ€¦ okay, are these the prompts that you have for us? Is it all on this slide?

2037
05:32:43.970 --> 05:32:46.380
Boardroom: Oh, okay, soâ€¦

2038
05:32:46.590 --> 05:32:55.219

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Boardroom: Alright, that's fine. I think I've covered all of those in my comments. So, I already talked about height, but just to reiterate, I think thatâ€¦

2039
05:32:55.250 --> 05:33:00.590
Boardroom: I think there's no need to differentiate height by nodes.

2040
05:33:00.610 --> 05:33:15.739
Boardroom: And, I'm comfortable with 7 stories here, and I think where the nodes could, be useful is differentiating ground floor uses, so having commercial

2041
05:33:15.830 --> 05:33:33.229
Boardroom: at theâ€¦ I guess they're called the retail nodes, and then being more flexible elsewhere along the corridor. And I have already explained my reasoning for why I think we can go higher to just align with what we're doing at other, transit stations and transit corridors.

2042
05:33:33.230 --> 05:33:41.110
Boardroom: And then I am also interested in exploring a higher floor area ratio so that, we can ensure that

2043
05:33:41.110 --> 05:33:52.249
Boardroom: projects are feasible and have the square footage that they need. On the objective design standards, I thought that these standards were, too complex.

2044
05:33:52.420 --> 05:34:03.720
Boardroom: And, you know, I was thinking philosophically, do I think that the new buildings that have gone up in our city in the last 10 years

2045
05:34:03.810 --> 05:34:22.399
Boardroom: are designed badly? I don't think so. Maybe some people in the audience think that, but it's typically that the people who have a problem with the design of new buildings, honestly, are against all development, in my experience. Soâ€¦

2046
05:34:22.400 --> 05:34:31.309
Boardroom: So, I haven't met people whoâ€¦ She's sharing her opinion, please let her speak. â€¦who have, who have said, I supportâ€¦

2047
05:34:31.570 --> 05:34:33.820
Boardroom: housing, whoâ€¦

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2048
05:34:33.990 --> 05:34:44.119
Boardroom: you know, just have a problem with the design. So I justâ€¦ and I'm sorry if that has offended people, but that's the reality. I don't think we're winning anybody by having theseâ€¦

2049
05:34:44.900 --> 05:34:57.209
Boardroom: numerous, complex, and costly objective design standards. We have to recognize that it is already very expensive to create these buildings, because the building code

2050
05:34:57.210 --> 05:35:07.459
Boardroom: already has such extensive requirements, so I just don't think there's a lot of added value with it. Having massing breaks eliminates

2051
05:35:07.610 --> 05:35:10.509
Boardroom: Residential square footage thatâ€¦

2052
05:35:10.700 --> 05:35:24.259
Boardroom: That I think we want. I think we want those homes, and so, I also thought it was reallyâ€¦ I just have to say this, I thought it was really odd to have objective design standards for middle housing here.

2053
05:35:24.540 --> 05:35:40.619
Boardroom: when that's a citywide program, and we're not having objective design standards for middle housing anywhere else in the city, I think that creates a very weird precedent. So, in general, I just didn't support these objective design standards. I do want to say that, you know, I could seeâ€¦

2054
05:35:40.700 --> 05:35:56.090
Boardroom: some utility and some limited standards for the ground floor that I think should apply to the other three corridors as well. You know, things like having the windows and things like that. I think that could be useful. And then theâ€¦

2055
05:35:56.390 --> 05:35:59.019
Boardroom: Finally, in terms of public realm.

2056
05:35:59.180 --> 05:36:05.640
Boardroom: I'm not for the, privately owned public open spaces. I don't think that thatâ€¦

2057
05:36:05.900 --> 05:36:18.250

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Boardroom: creates a lot of value. I'm also concerned about the 40 square feet per unit of open space. I think that's too high, and, could have the effect ofâ€¦

2058
05:36:18.370 --> 05:36:30.960
Boardroom: severely reducing the unit count that's feasible in buildings, or, and I think it could be very harmful for affordable housing. So I think we shouldâ€¦

2059
05:36:30.960 --> 05:36:43.989
Boardroom: instead of looking at those two strategiesâ€¦ I mean, I think we can have some open space per unit, but I'm worried that 40 square feet is too much. So, instead, I think we should look atâ€¦

2060
05:36:44.340 --> 05:36:46.870
Boardroom: Having wider sidewalks.

2061
05:36:47.130 --> 05:37:06.900
Boardroom: And, you know, my thought was, well, if we increase the floor area ratio, maybe we can make space for a wider sidewalk, because I think, in places on San Pablo and University and elsewhere in our city where there's space to put tables and chairs out in front of aâ€¦

2062
05:37:07.380 --> 05:37:10.940
Boardroom: a restaurant or other type of business, it'sâ€¦

2063
05:37:11.100 --> 05:37:30.009
Boardroom: a very nice amenity, and I think people enjoy that, and so if we have the wider sidewalk, that's what would make that possible. And there's just gonna be more people, onâ€¦ on this corridor, hopefully, so they're gonna need more space. I do just want to really applaud, the inclusion of the parklets and closing off

2064
05:37:30.010 --> 05:37:33.290
Boardroom: streets to create plazas. I think having

2065
05:37:33.290 --> 05:37:53.129
Boardroom: those sorts of spaces in the public realm is beneficial. I'm just gonna quickly wrap up and say that I do support the concept of a local density bonus, because I think it, where I think it could be particularly useful is for condo development, because the state density bonus requires you to have

2066
05:37:53.370 --> 05:38:10.100

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Boardroom: affordable condos on site, and I think that just renders a condo project infeasible. So I think weâ€¦ maybeâ€¦ and I don't know if we canâ€¦ because I think some people are against it, so if there's a way to just do local density bonus for condos.

2067
05:38:10.230 --> 05:38:22.169
Boardroom: maybe that's what we could try. But, you know, I don't think it's worth, I don't want to see us just drop that idea completely, because I think, you know, to Councilmember Lunapata had said, like, you know, maybe if the fee isâ€¦

2068
05:38:22.750 --> 05:38:40.669
Boardroom: increase, it might be workable. And then Iâ€¦ I just want to say, Iâ€¦ after I asked you the question about the commercial in-lieu fee, I justâ€¦ I just want to express, a deep skepticism about it, because there are already so many fees and exactions.

2069
05:38:40.710 --> 05:38:44.990
Boardroom: I was told today, and I haven't verified it independently, soâ€¦

2070
05:38:45.290 --> 05:38:56.479
Boardroom: take it for what it's worth, that the cost of a project in Berkeley, 27% of it is related to our local fees and permit check costs.

2071
05:38:56.880 --> 05:38:58.900
Boardroom: I haven'tâ€¦ I haven't double-checked that, butâ€¦

2072
05:38:59.070 --> 05:39:06.529
Boardroom: But, we need to be very cognizant of what we're adding to this, because it's just, it's not,

2073
05:39:06.860 --> 05:39:15.969
Boardroom: there isn't just an unlimited well of resources, you know, to do this. We have 17 projects in our downtown that are stalled right now.

2074
05:39:15.980 --> 05:39:21.230
Boardroom: because of the economic conditions, so I don't think it's reasonable to just keep adding more fees.

2075
05:39:21.230 --> 05:39:36.520
Boardroom: I do think we should retire the West Berkeley plan, and I do support the housing overlay for the MULI sites. Thank you. Thank you,

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Councilmember O'Keefe, and also, we might need to extend, depending on how long everyone's comments are, so just keep that in mind.

2076
05:39:36.850 --> 05:39:48.699
Boardroom: That helps. Mostly because I'm just really tired, and I'm sorry, I can't be more helpful, but I'm not gonna talk, just for the sake of talking, I'm just gonna say what might be useful, which is,

2077
05:39:49.490 --> 05:40:02.350
Boardroom: The part of this that I really just want to speak up for is the attention to the open public space. And I think, actually Councilmember Castorwani just said it much better than I was going to, but just emphasizing the plazas and wider sidewalks.

2078
05:40:02.380 --> 05:40:13.690
Boardroom: more than the, privately owned stuff. I think that's really where we can move this from being, like, a good, solid plan that will make a nice area to, like, a

2079
05:40:13.690 --> 05:40:25.550
Boardroom: beautiful, livable, community-feeling, vibrant area. Those things make a huge difference, so I really wanted to make a plug for that. And no, no design standards.

2080
05:40:25.600 --> 05:40:26.430
Boardroom: That's all.

2081
05:40:27.580 --> 05:40:29.410
Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmember Tregop?

2082
05:40:31.000 --> 05:40:39.369
Boardroom: Thank you. I, largely associate myself with Councilmember Taplin's, remarks.

2083
05:40:39.510 --> 05:40:48.370
Boardroom: Maybe after we're done with the downtown Berkeley isn't Dead tour, we can go toâ€¦ San Pablo is a live tour.

2084
05:40:48.420 --> 05:41:05.599
Boardroom: I, I wanted to just quickly highlight, I, I do support, 7 stories along this corridor. It is, wide enough to, I think, accommodate that, and certainly has, a lot of carrying capacity.

2085

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05:41:05.620 --> 05:41:24.769
Boardroom: I recognize that there are some legal questions that need to be answered around, different elements of this proposal, you know, the in-loo fees, the local density bonus, certain elements will likely require a nexus study to be done.

2086
05:41:24.800 --> 05:41:32.229
Boardroom: With that said, I'm excited about, this plan overall for its creativity.

2087
05:41:32.690 --> 05:41:40.260
Boardroom: I do want to, and this is not a caution, I just want to flag,

2088
05:41:40.360 --> 05:41:49.830
Boardroom: Iâ€¦ to the extent that certain elements of it are, you know, carry the day and are implemented.

2089
05:41:50.030 --> 05:42:04.559
Boardroom: I would like to see that, in the west of Berkeley, particularly the, other commercial corridors, and I think we've talked about this on the dies extensively, around equity along all commercial corridors.

2090
05:42:05.370 --> 05:42:14.280
Boardroom: I will say, I generally, support objective design standards.

2091
05:42:14.390 --> 05:42:24.610
Boardroom: I agree that in order for them to succeed, they cannot be overly onerous. I look forward to hearing more, about that.

2092
05:42:25.970 --> 05:42:34.320
Boardroom: I concur with the concept of concentrating,

2093
05:42:34.700 --> 05:42:42.889
Boardroom: Where we put, ground floor, retail or commercial, along commercial nodes.

2094
05:42:42.990 --> 05:42:54.079
Boardroom: I was, I appreciated the comment someone made about the loss of the 99-cent store.

2095
05:42:54.350 --> 05:43:09.389

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Boardroom: I remember going to the grocery outlet as well, that used to be there, and then sadly had to close. And I don't know where those customers, now go as well, the ones that can't afford, Whole Foods.

2096
05:43:09.420 --> 05:43:26.660
Boardroom: And that was unfortunate, and, it wasâ€¦ I was on the ZAB that, voted to, replace that with, housing. And there was, at the time, the promise of a community-serving, grocery use.

2097
05:43:26.700 --> 05:43:41.919
Boardroom: But we could not, as a city, regulate that, and it just, you know, didn't pencil. And so that, that kind of led to my, over time, I guess, recognition, evolution of thought,

2098
05:43:42.800 --> 05:43:44.520
Boardroom: we can'tâ€¦

2099
05:43:44.620 --> 05:43:54.669
Boardroom: even if we want to, and I think all of us would like to demand certain uses, and we just can't. It's what the market will bear.

2100
05:43:54.670 --> 05:44:15.600
Boardroom: I don't think the market will bear having the entire length of San Pablo be, storefront commercial, uses that are occupied. The ones that sat empty for years have been replaced with live-work, in some cases, and that seems to actually be working well, and occupancy levels are up.

2101
05:44:15.600 --> 05:44:20.470
Boardroom: And so that is how, I, I've justâ€¦

2102
05:44:20.670 --> 05:44:37.119
Boardroom: I support, doing what we can and understanding the macroeconomics and how, the interplay of them, and understanding the forces that we can't control, and doing what we can around the carrots approach, and incentives.

2103
05:44:38.940 --> 05:44:51.389
Boardroom: Last comment, on, mobility. I, I support any effort to, move San Pablo from, a historic highway used.

2104
05:44:51.390 --> 05:45:06.010

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Boardroom: to something where, as a bike rider, I would not be scared to, go down the length of San Pablo, or something that, can prioritize, bus traffic, you know,

2105
05:45:06.240 --> 05:45:22.579
Boardroom: And so, I'm curious how that could be done, and there may be some conflicts with some car-sorbing uses, but I definitely support that vision. Thank you so much for all your work on this plan.

2106
05:45:23.110 --> 05:45:31.059
Boardroom: I'm gonna make a motion to extend the meeting to 1245, just so we don't hit it. Second. Second. Okay, is there anyone in opposition?

2107
05:45:31.570 --> 05:45:43.829
Boardroom: Opposed? No? Okay, great. We will extend to 1245, thank you. Okay, councilmember Humbert, we'll come back to you, Councilmember Taplin, after everyone's gone.

2108
05:45:45.140 --> 05:45:49.990
Boardroom: Yeah, thank you, Madam Mayor. My comments are going to be really brief.

2109
05:45:50.880 --> 05:45:54.279
Boardroom: San Pablo Avenue is one of my favorite parts of town.

2110
05:45:54.470 --> 05:46:07.849
Boardroom: And I'm really looking forward, and I really sort of appreciate the history of it as being the western end of a highway that ran across the whole country. I mean, it's justâ€¦ there's something about that thatâ€¦

2111
05:46:07.980 --> 05:46:09.459
Boardroom: I find really neat.

2112
05:46:09.660 --> 05:46:27.929
Boardroom: I like to spend time there. My favorite grocery store, Mi Tiara, is there. And, I just really look forward to it having wider sidewalks and a lot moreâ€¦ and more vibrant street life than it even has now. So, those are my comments. And thank you for everybody who's worked on this.

2113
05:46:28.080 --> 05:46:33.029
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember. Okay, Councilmember Blackbee, and then Luna Parra, and thenâ€¦

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2114
05:46:33.100 --> 05:46:45.130
Boardroom: Taplin, and thenâ€¦ Yeah, I'll also be extremely brief, just mostly to thank staff for their great work and the creativity. I know a lot of time and effort and outreach has gone into this, so thank you. The creativity, I'm especially drawn.

2115
05:46:45.130 --> 05:47:00.509
Boardroom: to the public realm policies and just the thought, and how exciting that would be to activate this space in that way. And I hope that as we move the corridors piece ahead, we can also push our thinking in the same direction there, because I just think it makes the whole plan work, and I think it will also

2116
05:47:00.510 --> 05:47:12.359
Boardroom: build more support, for what we're trying to do in all these places, so thank you for that. And, I'm not thoroughly coherent, so other comments I'll make in writing and email, other feedback, but thank you.

2117
05:47:12.380 --> 05:47:14.399
Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmember Luna Parra?

2118
05:47:15.040 --> 05:47:21.059
Boardroom: Thank you, Iâ€¦ I also really want to thank staff for many reasons, thisâ€¦

2119
05:47:21.340 --> 05:47:28.920
Boardroom: plan doesn't get as much attention as some of the corridors that we saw earlier, but it is, just as important, so thank you so much.

2120
05:47:29.130 --> 05:47:37.309
Boardroom: I agree with my colleagues about the 7 to 8 stories, uniformly, andâ€¦

2121
05:47:37.590 --> 05:47:41.780
Boardroom: Generally against the private open space idea.

2122
05:47:42.180 --> 05:47:45.500
Boardroom: Those don't. Those don't work.

2123
05:47:46.310 --> 05:47:50.509
Boardroom: I think, broadly, the state density bonus is a really incredibleâ€¦

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2124
05:47:51.120 --> 05:48:04.140
Boardroom: well-crafted policy, and I'm very cautious to try to work around it, unless there's something that we really value more than affordable housing units, and there's very little that I would value more than affordable housing units, soâ€¦

2125
05:48:04.470 --> 05:48:16.469
Boardroom: I'm not necessarily entirely opposed to it, but I think that we should be really careful about the things that we're weighing, and that we would be training by making an alternative.

2126
05:48:19.310 --> 05:48:25.899
Boardroom: I really love the idea of bulb outs throughout the corridor. I think that that's really exciting, and can reallyâ€¦

2127
05:48:27.320 --> 05:48:29.839
Boardroom: I encourage a lot more pedestrianâ€¦

2128
05:48:30.010 --> 05:48:34.209
Boardroom: Vitality and, and just area, just in, likeâ€¦

2129
05:48:35.070 --> 05:48:39.570
Boardroom: a positive urban realm. Iâ€¦ that's really cool. I'm excited. Thank you!

2130
05:48:41.200 --> 05:48:52.639
Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmember Taplin, did you want to add something? Yes, thank you very much, and I appreciate your patience. I suddenly recovered everything I forgot. I want to express support for mobility hubs.

2131
05:48:53.140 --> 05:49:03.189
Boardroom: I wanted to move my horse over to the camp that supports a local density bonus, if that could enable, BMR ownership units.

2132
05:49:04.410 --> 05:49:11.650
Boardroom: I wanted to voice support forâ€¦

2133
05:49:12.230 --> 05:49:15.040
Boardroom: ground floor live work outside the nodes.

2134

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05:49:15.540 --> 05:49:21.570
Boardroom: But express skepticism aboutâ€¦ the utility of a commercial in Luffy.

2135
05:49:23.880 --> 05:49:25.079
Boardroom: Thank you very much.

2136
05:49:25.880 --> 05:49:32.770
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. Big thank you to staff, everyone for staying so late, thank you all so much.

2137
05:49:32.770 --> 05:49:46.579
Boardroom: I do want to just, like, give a shout out to the little dots, because I know we talkâ€¦ I remember going to the presentation, one of the presentations, where you put little dots against the things that you care about, and I could see that really here in this presentation.

2138
05:49:46.580 --> 05:49:53.579
Boardroom: So I just want to say thank you, because I know you all took a lot of feedback and put it into this. So, big thank you.

2139
05:49:53.580 --> 05:50:14.889
Boardroom: And, you know, at the same time, I know that sometimes when we do something by committee, that it means that there's a lot of feedback, and sometimes it feels like it's not always as streamlined, and so I am a little bit concerned that this might be, you know, overly complicated, so I am concerned about that piece of it. When it comes to height, I'm with my colleagues on this, I think consistency's really important.

2140
05:50:14.890 --> 05:50:23.720
Boardroom: I also want to explore the trade-offs that Councilmember Lunaparo brought up so we can really understand the impact on affordable housing. Thank you for bringing that to the forefront.

2141
05:50:23.720 --> 05:50:36.229
Boardroom: I do like the ideas ofâ€¦ the idea of plazas and closed streets, as opposed to private spaces that are open to the public. I also see them closed off and, you know, not really that accessible to the public, unfortunately.

2142
05:50:36.230 --> 05:50:59.840
Boardroom: And, I really want to voice my support again for the businesses that are down here. I'm really excited that we had a reduction in our vacancies, that's pretty cool, even though we don't know why. And then just, I think that it was made a comment, was made earlier about,

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OED doesn't meet regularly, or only meets regularly with business districts, and there are San Pablo businesses that aren't represented.

2143
05:50:59.840 --> 05:51:22.610
Boardroom: But I just want folks to know that doesn't mean that OED doesn't meet or represent those businesses. They still represent them, they'll still work with them, so certainly for any business owners out there, if you're feeling like your voice wasn't heard in this, or you want to be more involved in the process, please definitely reach out, you know, planning department, but also OED. Our Office of Economic Development is a really incredible resource.

2144
05:51:22.610 --> 05:51:31.110
Boardroom: And you can always start your own, your own, district, so, definitely want to encourage folks to look into that as well.

2145
05:51:31.110 --> 05:51:41.709
Boardroom: And those are my comments, and this is a workshop, so we're not voting on anything, so thank you so much to staff, thank you to council, thank you everyone for comments and staying late.

2146
05:51:41.710 --> 05:51:56.860
Boardroom: It is 1227, so I'm gonna make a motion to adjourn. Okay, is there any opposition? And nobody's online, so we are adjourned. Very good. Thank you all so much. Have a good evening. Er, morning.

2147
05:52:02.720 --> 05:52:03.740
Boardroom: Yes.

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